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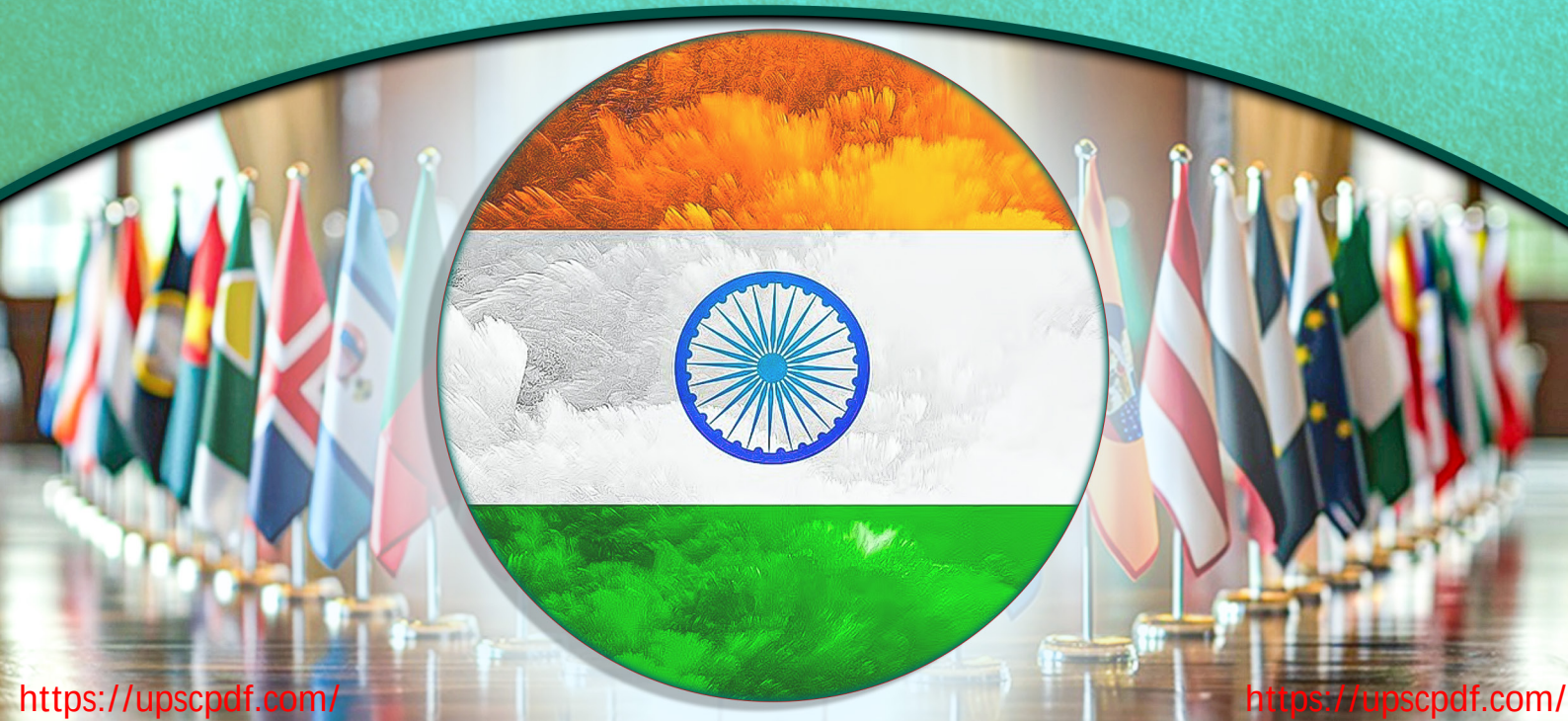

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1 Conflict Zones / Areas of Interest

1.1 Africa region

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following statements: **(2024)**
Statement-I: There is instability and a worsening security situation in the Sahel region.
Statement-II: There have been military takeovers/coups d'état in several countries of the Sahel region in the recent past.
Which one of the following is correct in respect of the above statements?
(a) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct and Statement-II explains Statement-I
(b) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct, but Statement-II does not explain Statement-I
(c) Statement-I is correct, but Statement-II is incorrect
(d) Statement-I is incorrect, but Statement-II is correct

2. In recent years Chad, Guinea, Mali and Sudan caught the international attention for which one of the following reasons is common to all of them? **(2023)**
(a) Discovery of rich deposits of rare earth elements
(b) Establishment of Chinese military bases
(c) Southward expansion of Sahara Desert
(d) Successful coups

3. Which of the following countries has been suffering from decades of civil strife and food shortages and was in news in the recent past for its very severe famine? **(2023)**
(a) Angola (b) Costa Rica (c) Ecuador (d) Somalia

4. Consider the following pairs: **[2022]**

Country	-	**Important reason for being in the news recently**
1. Chad	-	Setting up of permanent military base by China
2. Guinea	-	Suspension of Constitution and Government by military
3. Lebanon	-	Severe and prolonged economic depression
4. Tunisia	-	Suspension of Parliament by President

How many pairs given above are correctly matched?
(a) Only one pair (b) Only two pairs
(c) Only three pairs (d) All four pairs

5. Consider the following statements: **(2022)**
1. Bidibidi is a large refugee settlement in north-western Kenya.
2. Some people who fled from South Sudan civil war live in Bidibidi.
3. Some people who fled from civil war in Somalia live in Dadaab refugee complex in Kenya.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
(a) 1 and 2 (b) 2 only (c) 2 and 3 (d) 3 only

6. Very recently, in which of the following countries have lakhs of people either suffered from severe famine/acute malnutrition or died due to starvation caused by war/ethnic conflicts? **(2018)**
(a) Angola and Zambia (b) Morocco and Tunisia
(c) Venezuela and Colombia (d) Yemen and South Sudan

7. A very big refugee camp called Dadaab, recently in the news, is located in **(2009)**
(a) Ethiopia (b) Kenya (c) Somalia (d) Sudan

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8. Consider the following pairs: **[2023]**

Regions often mentioned in news	–	Reason for being in news
1. North Kivu and Ituri	–	War between Armenia and Azerbaijan
2. Nagorno-Karabakh	–	Insurgency in Mozambique
3. Kherson and Zaporizhzhia	–	Dispute between Israel and Lebanon

How many of the above pairs are correctly matched?

(a) Only one (b) Only two (c) All three (d) None

9. Which one of the following pairs of countries fought wars over a region called Ogaden? **[2009]**

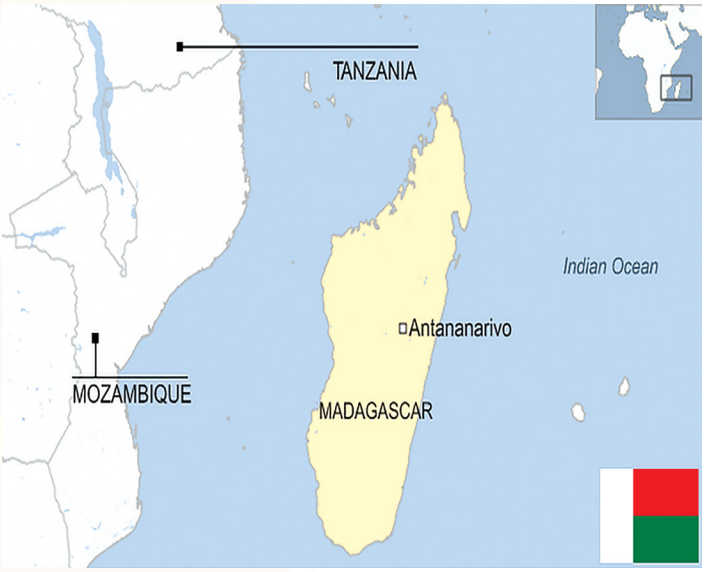
(a) Eritrea and Sudan (b) Ethiopia and Somalia
(c) Kenya and Somalia (d) Ethiopia and Sudan

Answers: 1.(a), 2.(d), 3.(d), 4.(c), 5.(c), 6.(d), 7.(b), 8.(d), 9.(b)

Types of Crisis in Regions of Africa

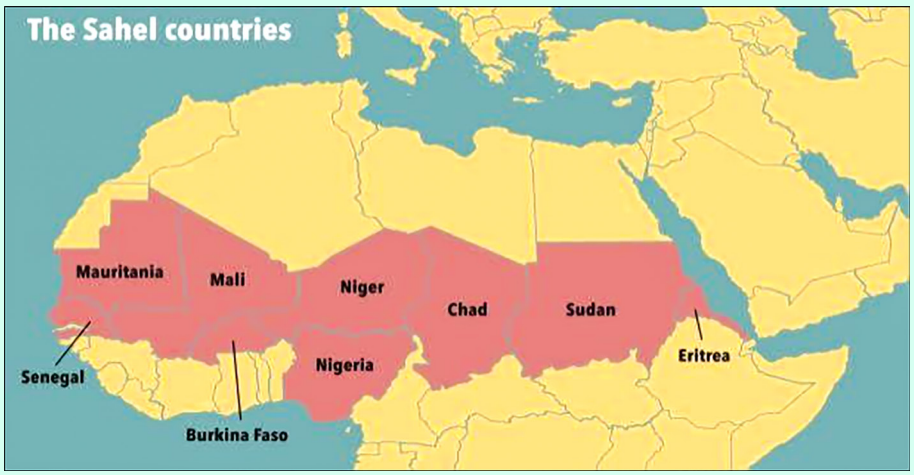
Military Coups

- **Guinea-Bissau:** Coup attempts led by the **Armed Forces General Staff**.
- **Madagascar:** Coup here was led by the CAPSAT elite military unit → The military government is currently consolidating power after forming a new government and promising elections.
- **Chad:** Power taken by **the Transitional Military Council (TMC) after the president's death.**
- **Guinea:** Coup led by **Special Forces Group**.
- **Mali:** Coups led by the National **Committee for the Salvation of the People (CNSP)**.
- **Sudan:** 2021 coup by **Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF)**.
- **Burkina Faso**: President was removed in the country's second coup of the year.
- **Niger:** The President was overthrown by the Presidential Guard.
- **Gabon:** The President was removed shortly after a disputed election



Sahel Region:

- A **semi-arid belt in western and north-central Africa** → stretches **from Africa's Atlantic Coast to the Red Sea** → Extends across **Senegal, Mauritania, Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger, Nigeria, Chad, Eritrea and Sudan** → often called ***Africa's "Coup Belt."***
- **Alliance of Sahel States (AES): Formed in 2023** → Security bloc formed by **Mali, Niger and Burkina Faso** after tensions with ECOWAS and Western powers.



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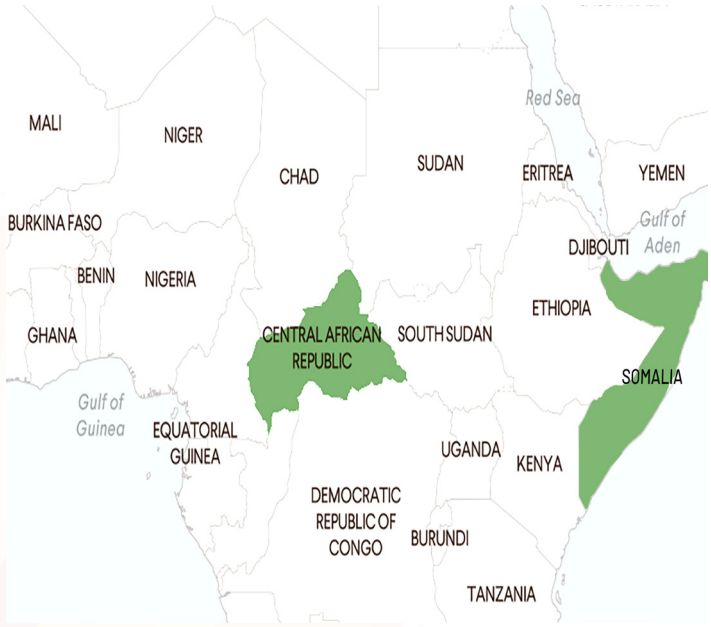
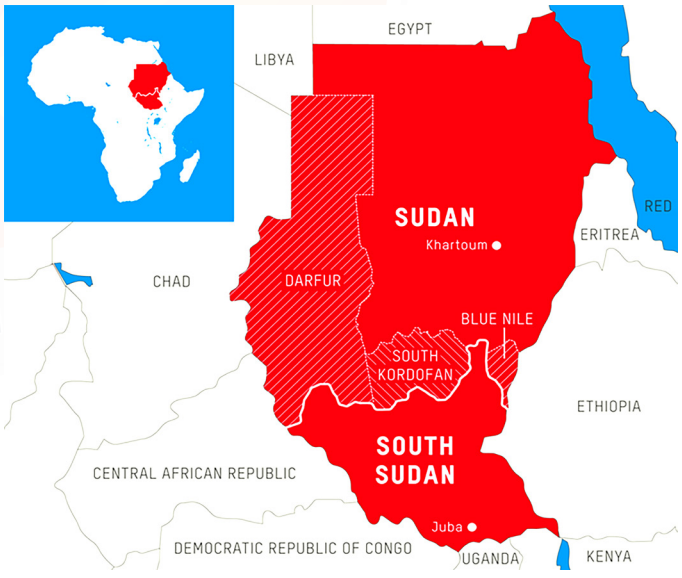
Politico-Social Unrest and Governance Crises

- **Tunisia:** The President **suspended parliament and dismissed the prime minister**.
- **Ethiopia**: **Ethnic and political tensions** due to conflicts involving the federal government and regional militias following the Ethiopian civil war.
- **Madagascar:** Massive student ***(Gen Z)*** demonstrations over persistent power and water outages.
- **Kenya:** ***Gen Z* protests** over proposed tax changes, sparking widespread anger over the high cost of living
- **Morocco:** ***Gen Z*** demanded more funding for public health and education, as well as an end to corruption.

Civil War / Conflict Between State Forces

- **Sudan: The Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF) vs. the Rapid Support Forces** (RSF) conflict.
  - ♦ Led to large-scale displacement & repeated famine conditions and severe malnutrition, especially in the Darfur region.
- **Tigray (Ethiopia)**: Recent war between the **Ethiopian federal government** and **Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF).**
  - ♦ There was a peace deal set up in 2022, but skirmishes arose in 2025.
- **Central African Republic Civil War (2012–present):** Ongoing fighting involving the government, former Séléka rebels, and Anti-balaka militias.
- **Somalia:** Experiencing an ongoing, long-term civil war that has continued in various phases since 1991, with the current phase active since 2009.





Other Conflicts, Droughts, and Famines.

- **Angola:** Experiencing its worst drought in over 40 years driven by a combination of long-term climatic shifts and recent acute weather events.
- **Nile Basin:** Experiencing intensified droughts and famines due to climate change—causing volatile rainfall and rising temperatures—combined with rapid population growth, widespread deforestation, and agricultural water overuse.
  - ♦ Located in the basin, the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam (GERD) has caused severe, ongoing diplomatic conflict with downstream neighbors Egypt and Sudan.
- **Lake Chad Basin** (Nigeria–Chad–Niger–Cameroon): **Boko Haram** (a militant group based in northeastern Nigeria, also active in Chad, Niger, and Cameroon) **insurgency** combined with a climate-driven livelihood crisis.

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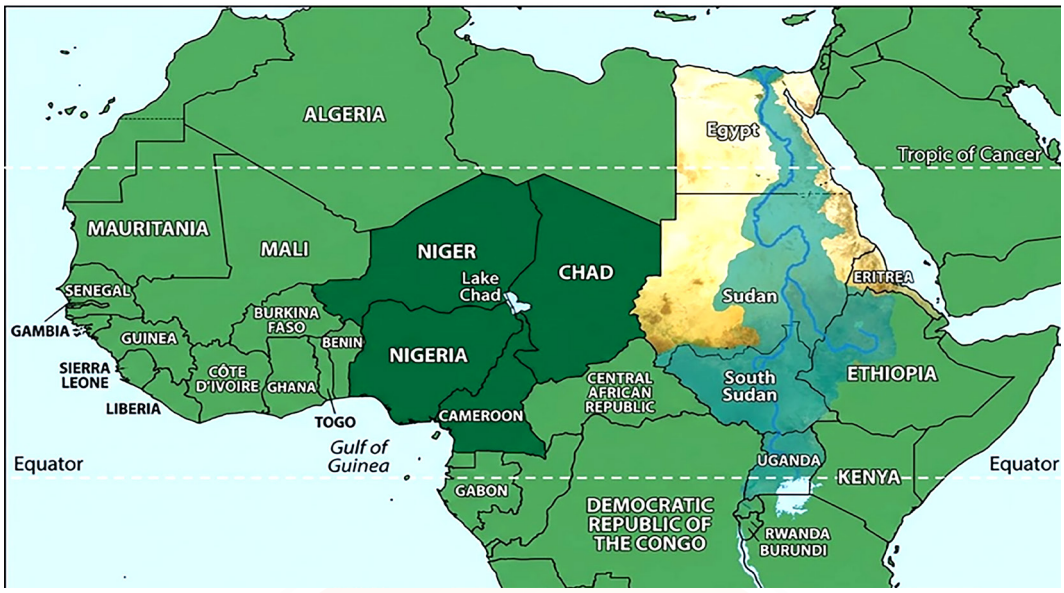
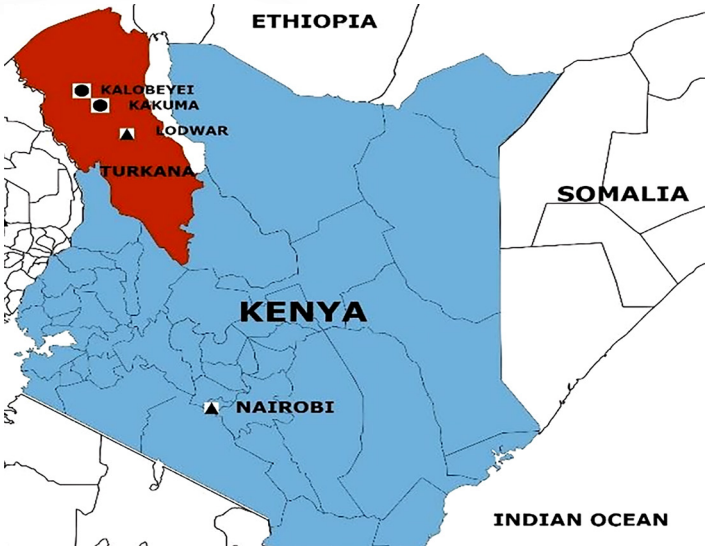
INTEGRATED MAP OF THE NILE AND LAKE CHAD BASINS OF AFRICA



Refugees Settlements

- **Bidibidi (Uganda):** One of the largest refugee settlements in the world, refugees **are mostly** people **fleeing the civil war in South Sudan**.
- **Dadaab (Kenya):** Refugees from the Somali Civil War.
- **Darfur (Sudan crisis):** Has caused large-scale displacement and refugee flows to **Chad and neighbouring countries**.
- **Kakuma Camp (Kenya):** located in northwestern Kenya's Turkana County → established in 1992 for Sudan's "Lost Boys," it is one of Africa's largest, hosting over 300,000 refugees (primarily South Sudanese, Somalis, and Congolese).
- **The Kalobeyei Settlement:** A separate, newer entity located near Kakuma → Functions under the same broader Kakuma refugee management framework.



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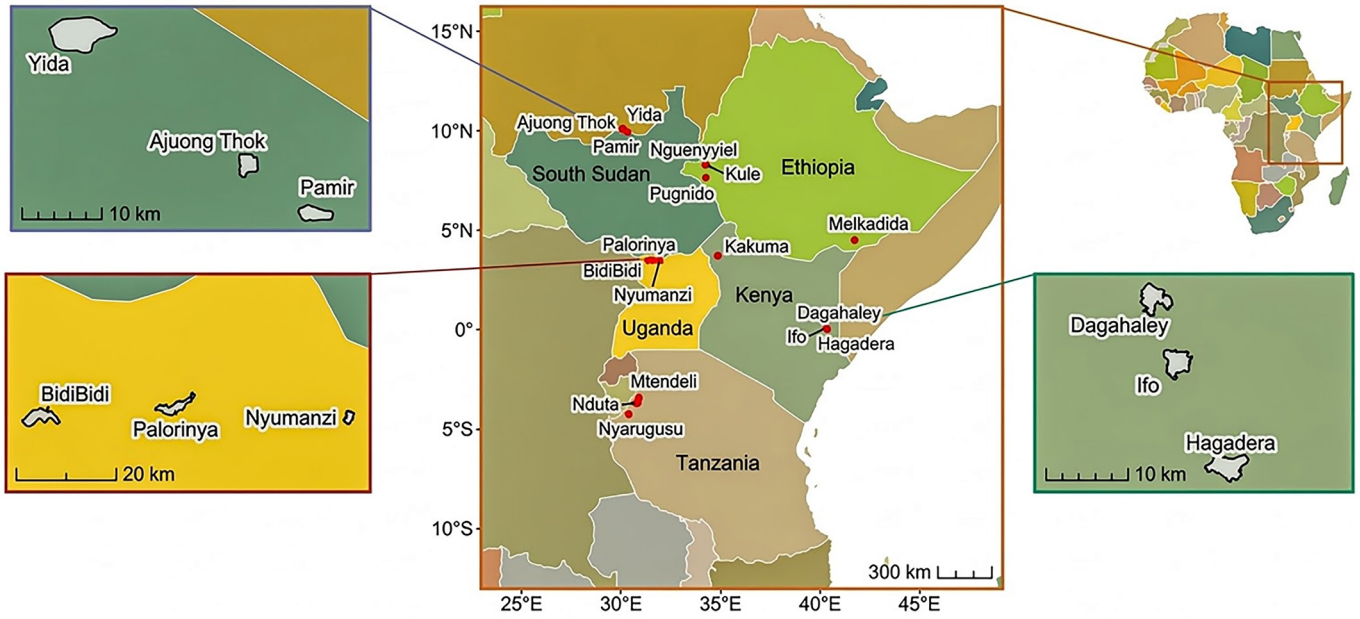
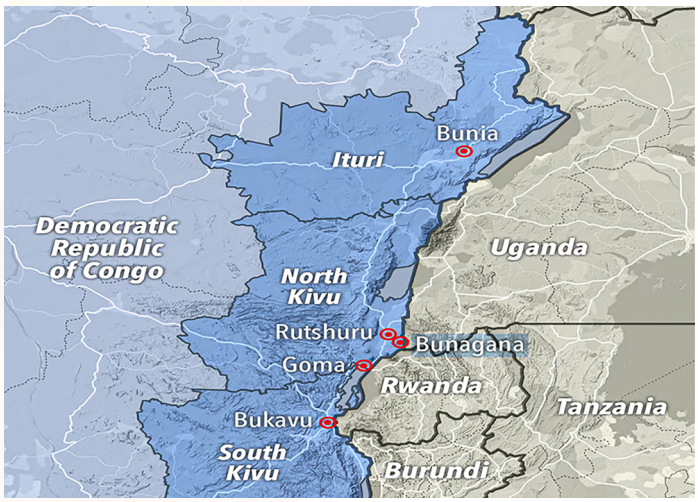


Border Issues and Disputed Territories

1. **North Kivu and Ituri (DRC):**
   - **Long-running ethnic and militia conflicts from 2022 till today,** involving groups like the **March 23 (M23).**
   - **Reason:** M23 claims to protect the **Tutsi minority** from **Hutu-aligned groups.**
   - M23 seized the strategic cities of **Goma** and **Bukavu** in early 2025. → As of early April 2026, the M23 maintains significant control over key areas in the eastern Democratic Republic of Congo.



M23 group: The **March 23 Movement (M23)** is an armed rebel group in the Democratic Republic of the Congo **(DRC) backed by Rwanda** that was in the news because it resumed a major insurgency in eastern DRC**, capturing territory in North Kivu**

2. **Abyei region (Between Sudan and South Sudan)**
   - It is a disputed region on the border of Sudan and South Sudan.
   - The UN Interim Security Force provides security for Abyei **(UNISFA).**
   - **Ngok Dinka:** Local community aligned with **South Sudan**; seeking self-rule.
   - **Misseriya:** Arab pastoralist community aligned with **Sudan.**

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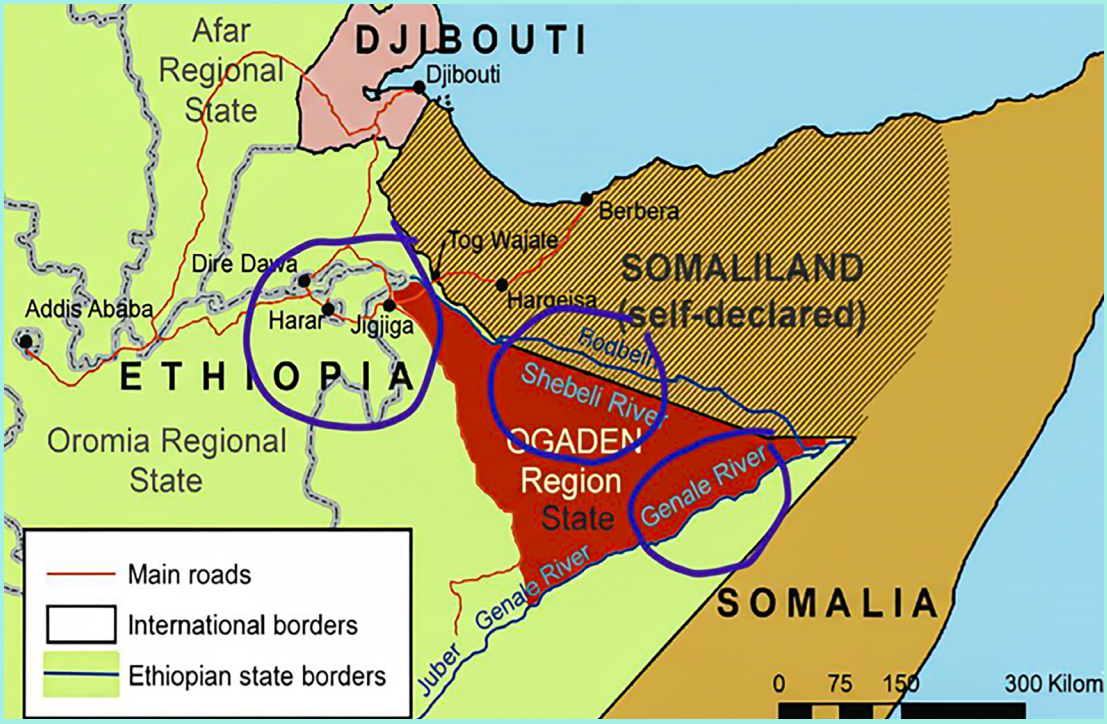
3. Ogaden (Ethiopia)

- **Ogaden** is a territory in the eastern part of **Ethiopia**, primarily disputed between Ethiopia and Somalia
- The **Shebeli and Genale (Jubba) rivers** flowing through the Ogaden are critical for both countries.
- **Jigjiga:** The capital of the Somali Region in Ethiopia.
- **Harar:** A major historic city located on the highlands just west of the Ogaden.
- **The "Haud":** A fertile grazing area within the Ogaden that has been a specific point of grazing-right disputes for centuries.



1.2. West Asia

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. The term "two-state solution" is sometimes mentioned in the news in the context of the affairs of **(2018)**

(a) China (b) Israel (c) Iraq (d) Yemen

2. The area known as 'Golan Heights' sometimes appears in the news in the context of the events related to **(2015)**

(a) Central Asia (b) Middle East
(c) South-East Asia (d) Central Africa

3. Recently, a series of uprisings of people referred to as 'Arab Spring' originally started from. **(2014)**

(a) Egypt (b) Lebanon (c) Syria (d) Tunisia

4. Consider the following pairs: **[2023]**

Area of conflict	-	Country
1. Donbas	-	Syria
2. Kachin	-	Ethiopia
3. Tigray	-	North Yemen

How many of the above pairs are correctly matched?

(a) Only one (b) Only two (c) All three (d) None

Answers: 1(b), 2(b), 3(d), 4(d)

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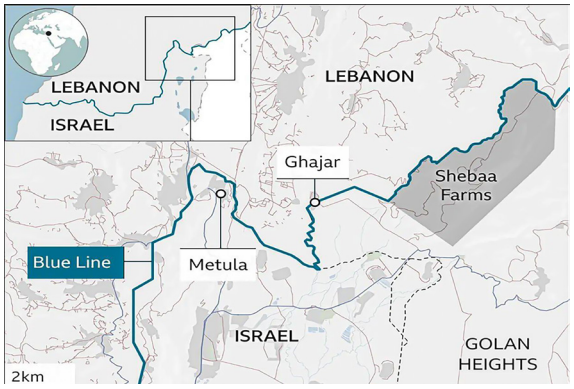
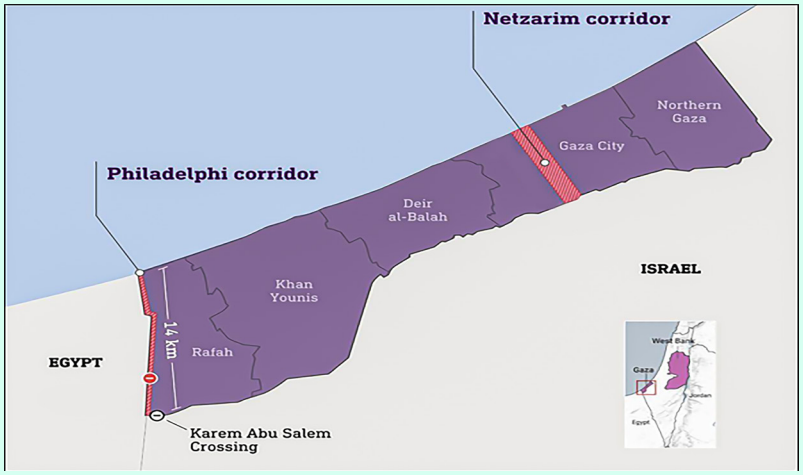
Crisis	Details
Politico - economic crisis	• **Kuwait**: In May 2024, Emir of Kuwait dissolved parliament and suspended parts of the constitution. As of March 2026, the country is ruled by decree through a royally appointed cabinet, and the "democratic experiment" remains frozen.
Regional Conflicts	• **Lebanon:** Conflict between **Israeli Defence Forces and Hezbollah** (Iran-backed group) exchanging cross-border attacks. ♦ **Blue Line:** The UN-recognised boundary between Lebanon and Israel, currently patrolled by **UNIFIL.** ♦ **Litani River** is critical for the ceasefire and disarmament zones. • **Yemen:** An ongoing, violent conflict beginning in 2014–2015 between Houthi rebels (backed by Iran) and the internationally recognized government (backed by a Saudi-led coalition).



Sheba Farms: A strip of land at the junction of southeastern Lebanon, southwestern Syria, and northern Israel. Captured by Israel from Syria in 1967, it is claimed by Lebanon.

Arab spring	• The **Arab Spring** was a wave of **pro-democracy uprisings (2010–2012)** triggered by unemployment, corruption, and authoritarian rule. • **Tunisia:** Arab Spring began in **Dec 2010** → Triggered by **street vendor Mohamed Bouazizi's self-immolation.** • **Egypt: 2011 mass protests** forced **President Hosni Mubarak to resign.** • **Syria: 2011 protests against Bashar al-Assad** escalated into a **prolonged civil war.**
Israel-Palestine	• **Golan Heights:** The plateau located between **southwestern Syria & northern Israel** → captured by Israel from **Syria in 1967**; annexed in 1981. • **Gaza Strip:** Palestinian enclave on the eastern Mediterranean coast • **Rafah crossing:** Southernmost border crossing of the **Gaza Strip**, connecting Gaza with **Egypt's Sinai Peninsula** → currently the main exit point for people and humanitarian aid. • **West Bank:** Located **between Israel to the west and Jordan to the east**. • **Philadelphi corrido r: ~14 km long demilitarised buffer zone** along the **Gaza–Egypt border**, extending from the **Mediterranean Sea to the Kerem Shalom crossing**, including the **Rafah crossing**. ♦ Established in 1979 under the **Egypt–Israel peace framework** to create a demilitarized border ♦ In 2005 Israel withdrew its military forces and settlers. ♦ **Israel recaptured the corridor in May 2024 during the Gaza war**, making it a key issue in **ceasefire negotiations and Egypt–Israel tensions**. • **Netzarim Corridor**: Israeli-built military road that bisects the Gaza Strip.

Two-state solution: It is a proposed framework for resolving the Israeli - Palestinian conflict by **establishing two separate, independent** nations living side-by-side.



Abraham Accords: U.S.-brokered normalization agreements signed in 2020 between **Israel and UAE, Bahrain and Morocco.** → Sudan officially signed the general declaration of the Accords on 6 January 2021. However, unlike other signatories like the UAE and Bahrain, Sudan has not yet ratified the agreement or signed a final bilateral peace treaty with Israel. → Kazakhstan showed intention to join the accord.

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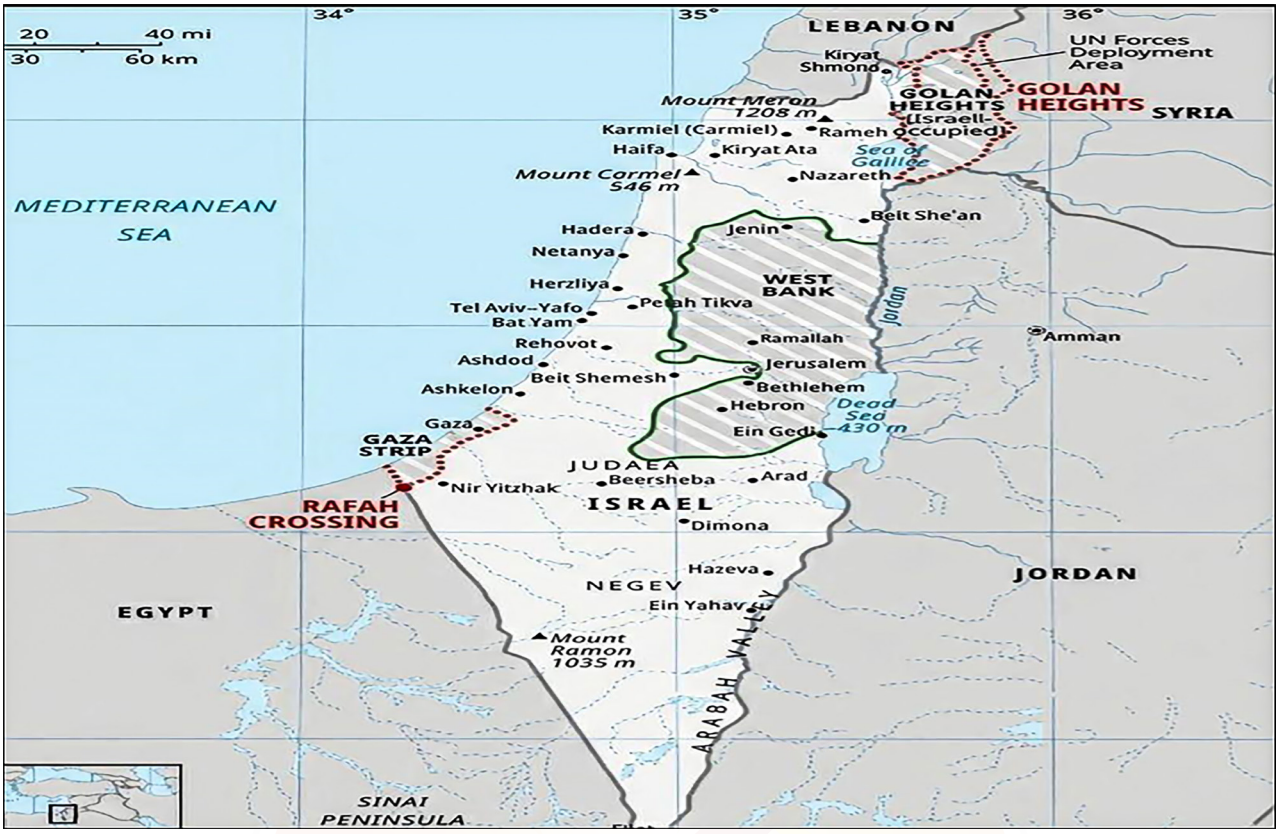
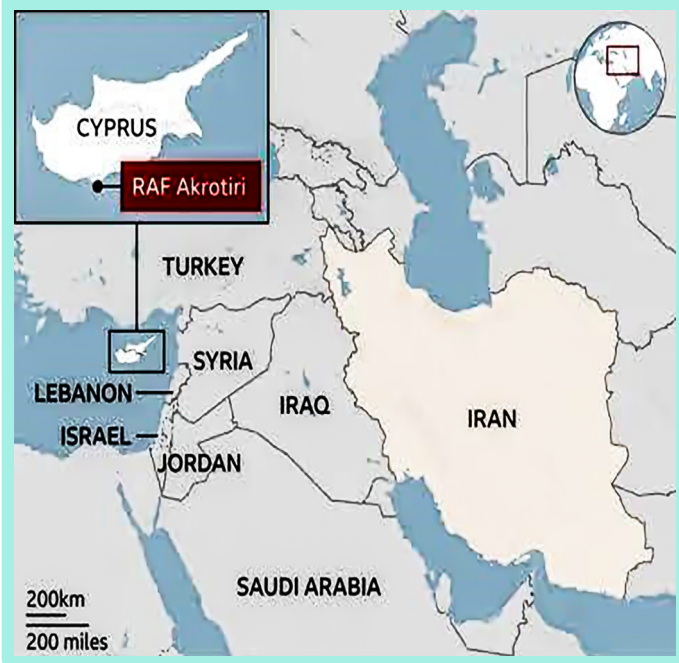


Iran vs USA and Israel

- **Iranian Nuclear Facilities:**
  - **Natanz (Esfahan Province):** Iran's primary **uranium enrichment** site; it was the first nuclear facility struck by the US-Israeli coalition.
  - **Fordow (near Qom):** A heavily fortified, underground nuclear site built into a mountain to protect against airstrikes.
- **Other important sites:**
  - **Bandar Abbas:** Iran's most strategic naval port on the Persian Gulf.
  - **Minab (Hormozgan Province):** A coastal city near the Strait of Hormuz.
  - **Kharg Island:** It is Iran's primary crude oil export hub in the northern Persian Gulf.
- **Places targeted by Iran:**
  - **RAF Akrotiri (Cyprus):** A British Sovereign Base Area in the Mediterranean.
  - **Al-Udeid Air Base (Qatar):** The largest U.S. military installation in the Middle East.



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Refugees, Humanitarian Crisis

- **Kurds:** The Kurds are a group of people who mainly live in Turkey, Iraq, Iran, and Syria.
- Some groups, like the PKK in Turkey, have fought with the government for their greater autonomy, cultural rights, and self-determination
- Kurdish groups have also played an important role in conflicts in places like Syria.

1.3 Asia

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following countries: **(2022)**

1. Azerbaijan
2. Kyrgyzstan
3. Tajikistan
4. Turkmenistan
5. Uzbekistan

Which of the above have borders with Afghanistan?

(a) 1, 2 and 5 only (b) 1, 2, 3 and 4 only
(c) 3, 4 and 5 only (d) 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5

2. Consider the following pairs: **(2016)**

Community sometimes mentioned in the news – In the affairs of

1. Kurd - Bangladesh
2. Madhesi - Nepal
3. Rohingya - Myanmar

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

(a) 1 and 2 (b) 2 only (c) 2 and 3 (d) 3 only

3. Which one of the following statements best reflects the issue with Senkaku Islands, sometimes mentioned in the news? **(2022)**

(a) It is generally believed that they are artificial islands made by a country around South China Sea.
(b) China and Japan engage in maritime disputes over these islands in East China Sea.
(c) A permanent American military base has been set up there to help Taiwan to increase its defence capabilities.
(d) Though the International Court of Justice declared them as no man's land, some South-East Asian countries claim them.

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4. Consider the following pairs: **(2014)**

Region often in news	–	Country
1. Chechnya	–	Russian Federation
2. Darfur	–	Mali
3. Swat Valley	–	Iraq

Which of the above pairs is/are correctly matched?

(a) 1 only (b) 2 and 3 only (c) 1 and 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

Answers: 1(c), 2(c), 3(b), 4(a)

Crisis	Regions and details
Politico-economic crisis	• **South Korea**: Political crisis driven by executive–legislative confrontation, low presidential approval, and repeated impeachment motions. ♦ First martial law declaration since 1980 (the Gwangju Uprising era). ♦ 2026 → Seoul court → President Yoon sent to **life imprisonment** for insurrection and attempting a self-coup. • **Sri Lanka:** Experienced a severe politico-economic crisis starting around 2022, characterized by a sovereign default, massive inflation, and shortages of essentials, which led to mass protests and a change in leadership. • **Bangladesh: Gen-Z protests** in Bangladesh caused by corruption allegations, high inflation, demand for jobs, etc. led to regime change. • **Nepal: Mass youth-led "Gen Z" protests** erupted after the government banned social media platforms, leading to the resignation of the Prime Minister. ♦ 2026 → regime shift → new government → stability → social media bill withdrawn → restoration of services. • **Saint Martin Island:** ♦ Saint Martin Island is situated near the **Myanmar - Bangladesh maritime boundary in the Bay of Bengal**. ♦ occasionally discussed in regional security and strategic debates involving **Bangladesh, Myanmar and the Indo-Pacific region**.
Various Protests	• **Indonesia:** Youth-led **(Gen Z)** protest against corruption and elite privilege in 2025. • **Philippines:** Filipinos protested against revelations of large-scale corruption in flood-control projects.

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Conflicts between state forces	• **Myanmar:** The conflict is characterized as a battle between the military junta known as the State Administrative Council (SAC) and a broad coalition of resistance forces, including newly formed People's Defense Forces (PDFs) and long-established Ethnic Armed Organizations (EAOs) such as **the Arakan Army.** • **Swat Valley (Pakistan):** Taliban insurgency, military operations, security issues. ♦ Devastating monsoon floods killed hundreds and caused widespread destruction in 2025. • **Afghanistan-Pakistan Conflict:** Tensions between Pakistan and Afghanistan's Taliban regime have sharply escalated since late February 2026, heightening regional instability and raising concerns about the risk of a prolonged conflict. • **Thailand-Cambodia:** The Thailand-Cambodia border conflict remains in a fragile, tense state following deadly clashes in December 2025. ♦ While a ceasefire holds, sporadic incidents and intense diplomatic disputes over maritime areas, including potential moves to discard the **2001 Memorandum of Understanding (MOU 44),** persist.

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Refugees, Humanitarian Crisis

- **Rohingyas:** Muslim minority in **Rakhine State (Myanmar)** displaced due to ethnic violence → mass refugee movement to **Bangladesh.**

Sagaing region (Myanmar): Instability in Sagaing frequently leads to Kuki-Zomi and Naga populations crossing into Manipur and Mizoram.

- **Madhesi:** People from the southern plains (Terai region) of **Nepal**.
  - ♦ In the news for **ethnic protests, demands for political representation, and inclusion in federal governance**.
- **The Afghanistan refugee crisis:** One of the world's largest and most protracted, with millions displaced by decades of conflict, poverty, and severe human rights restrictions, particularly following the 2021 Taliban takeover.
  - ♦ As of 2026, over 10 million Afghans are displaced internally or in neighboring countries, facing massive repatriation pressures.

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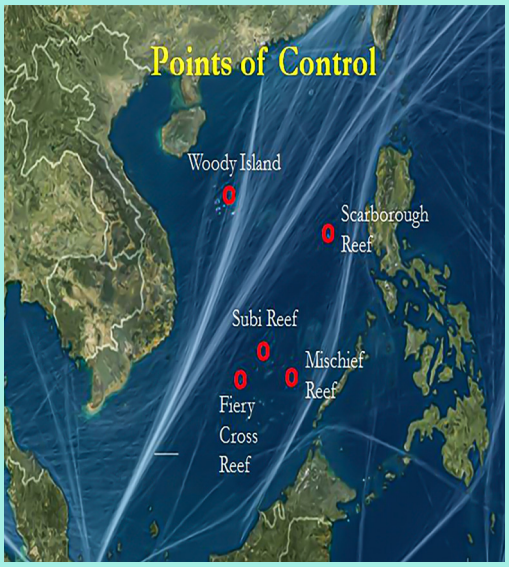
Disputed islands

- South China Sea:
  - ♦ **Spratly Islands:** A disputed region in the South China Sea between **China, Vietnam, Philippines, Malaysia, Brunei, and Taiwan.**
  - ♦ **Paracel Islands:** Dispute between **China and Vietnam** in the South China Sea.
- **East China Sea: Diaoyu / Senkaku Islands** → Administered by **Japan** but claimed by **China and Taiwan**
- **Kuril Islands:** The disputed islands between Japan and Russia → involve four islands—Iturup, Kunashir, Shikotan, and the Habomai islets—located off the coast of Hokkaido.



1.4 Americas and Europe

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following pairs: **(2025)**

	Region	-	**Country**
I.	Mallorca	-	Italy
II.	Normandy	-	Spain
III.	Sardinia	-	France

In how many of the above rows is the given information correctly matched?

(a) Only one (b) Only two
(c) All the three (d) None

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2. Consider the following pairs: **[2024]**

Country	-	**Reason for being in the news**
1. Argentina	-	Worst economic crisis
2. Sudan	-	War between the country's regular army and paramilitary forces
3. Turkey	-	Rescinded its membership of NATO

How many of the pairs given above are correctly matched?

(a) Only one pair (b) Only two pairs
(c) All three pairs (d) None of the pairs

3. Consider the following pairs: **[2022]**

	Regions	-	**Country**
1.	Anatolia	-	Turkey
2.	Amhara	-	Ethiopia
3.	Cabo Delgado	-	Spain
4.	Catalonia	-	Italy

How many pairs given above are correctly matched?

(a) Only one pair (b) Only two pairs
(c) Only three pairs (d) All four pairs

4. From which one of the following did Kosovo declare its independence? **[2009]**

(a) Bulgaria (b) Croatia (c) Macedonia (d) Serbia

Answers: 1(d), 2(b), 3(b), 4(d)

Crisis	Regions and details
Politico-economic crisis	• **El Salvador:** The legislature approved **constitutional reforms removing presidential term limits.** • **Argentina:** Economic crisis due to high inflation. • **Catalonia (Spain): In the news due to its push for independence from Spain**, including protests, legal battles, and political negotiations with Madrid. • **Kosovo:** Unilaterally declared its independence from **Serbia** in **February, 2008** but India does not recognise its independence → Recognised by 100+ countries including the USA.

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Crimes and other issues	• **Ecuador:** National emergency was declared due to gang violence and prison riots (2024). • **Costa Rica:** Facing a **rise in gang violence and homicide rates**, largely linked to **drug trafficking routes in Central America** → Also in the news for India exporting fortified rice kernels from Chhattisgarh to Costa Rica (2025).

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Other places and crises

- **Mallorca (Spain):** Residents held large-scale protests against "mass tourism."
- **Sardinia (Italy):** State of Emergency (July 2024): Sardinia declared a state of emergency due to a severe, persistent drought.
- **Normandy (France)**: D-Day 80th Anniversary → 2024 marked the 80th anniversary of the D-Day landings; world leaders gathered at Omaha Beach.

Ukraine Crisis

- **Donbas:** Russia declared annexation of Donbas region but Ukraine continues counter-offensives to reclaim territory.
- **Kherson and Zaporizhzhia:** Oblasts (administrative regions) of southern Ukraine.
- **Avdiivka:** Russian forces captured the city in 2024 after months of intense fighting.
- **Kakhovka Dam:** Collapsed amid the Russia–Ukraine war, triggering massive flooding and humanitarian displacement
- **Odessa:** Key port city for the **Black Sea Grain Initiative (BSGI).**
- **Snake Island:** It is a strategic Black Sea outpost captured by Russia in the war, as it is crucial for controlling Black Sea shipping routes. Currently Under **Ukrainian control** since 2022
- Russian forces have primarily targeted and occupied the **Zaporizhzhia Nuclear Power Plant (ZNPP)**, located in Energodar, Ukraine.

- **Note: BSGI** was a July 2022 UN-brokered agreement between Ukraine and Russia (via Turkey) to safely export grain and fertilizers from three key Ukrainian ports—Odesa, Chornomorsk, and Pivdennyi.
- Russia terminated its participation and the initiative expired on July 17, 2023

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Border issues and Disputed Territories

Essequibo region (Venezuela and Guyana)

- Venezuela claims two-thirds of Guyana's territory, which is rich in oil and gold.

Operation Absolute Resolve: The U.S. military conducted a lightning "snatch-and-grab" raid in Caracas to capture the Venezuelan President.

La orchilla island

- **Present context:** Following the U.S. military intervention in Caracas in early 2026, La Orchila has become a focal point for naval standoffs.
- A small island in the **Caribbean Sea, situated about 160 km** north of Caracas, Venezuela.
- The island is a restricted military zone and houses the **Antonio Díaz Naval Base.**

Nagorno - Karabakh (Armenia and Azerbaijan) - It was in the news due to the second Nagorno - Karabakh war (2020 and 2023).

- It is a disputed region between **Armenia and Azerbaijan.**
- Azerbaijan regained surrounding territories in the 2020 war; it took full control of Nagorno-Karabakh itself only after a brief military offensive in September 2023, triggering the mass displacement of the ethnic Armenian population.
- Ceasefires and peace talks have been intermittent; periodic tensions and mutual accusations continue.
- **The Zangezur Corridor:** a proposed transport and infrastructure route designed to connect Azerbaijan with its exclave, **Nakhchivan**, by passing through the southern **Syunik Province of Armenia.**
  - ♦ Also known as the **Trump Route for International Peace and Prosperity (TRIPP)**.

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Greenland

- World's **largest non-continental island.**
- **Political Status:** An autonomous territory within the Kingdom of Denmark.

Borders:

- **North:** Arctic Ocean (specifically the Lincoln Sea and Wandel Sea).
- **East:** Greenland Sea and Denmark Strait (separates it from Iceland).
- **West:** Baffin Bay and Davis Strait (separates it from Canada's Ellesmere Island).
- **South:** North Atlantic Ocean and Labrador Sea.
- It covers ~80% of the land and is the second largest in the world after Antarctica.
- Northeast Greenland National Park is the **world's largest national park**.

Chechnya Republic (Russia)

- A federal subject (republic) of Russia located in the **North Caucasus region of Eastern Europe.**
- It is bordered by Dagestan to the east, Georgia to the south, Ingushetia to the west, and Stavropol Krai to the northwest
- In news primarily due to its pivotal role in the Ukraine conflict, with its forces (Kadyrovtsy) fighting alongside Russia.
- There are reports of repression, enforced disappearances, and restrictions on civil liberties in this region.

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1.5 Distinct Regions

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. The term "Levant" often heard in the news roughly corresponds to which of the following regions? **[2022]**

(a) Region along the eastern Mediterranean shores
(b) Region along North African shores stretching from Egypt to Morocco
(c) Region along Persian Gulf and Horn of Africa
(d) The entire coastal areas of Mediterranean Sea.

Answers: 1(a)

New Caledonia

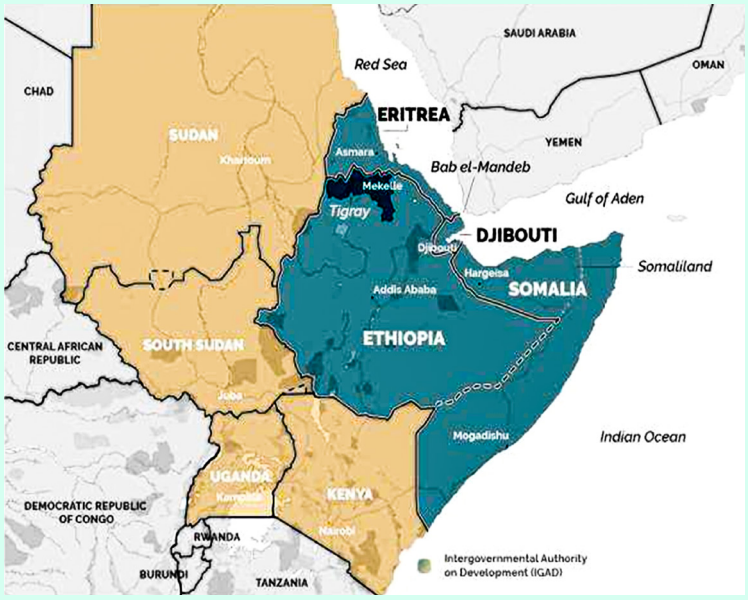
- Recently France's Parliament rejects bid to reform status of New Caledonia
- Listed by the UN as a **Non-Self-Governing Territory** since 1986.
- **Location:** Unique French territory in the **Southwest Pacific Ocean**, approximately 1,200 km east of Australia and south of Vanuatu.
- **Cultural significance: New Caledonian Barrier Reef** (the second-longest double barrier reef in the world), a **UNESCO World Heritage Site**.

Levant region

- "The Levant" specifically refers to the **lands bordering the eastern Mediterranean Sea**.
- **Countries:** Cyprus, Israel, Jordan, Lebanon, Palestine, Iraq and Syria

Horn of Africa

- This is one of the most strategically important regions in the world due to its position along the **Red Sea and Gulf of Aden**
- **Countries:** Ethiopia, Eritrea, Djibouti, and Somalia.



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2 International Institutions

2.1 UN Agencies

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. With reference to the United Nations Credentials Committee, consider the following statements: **(2022)**

1. It is set up by the UN Security Council.
2. It traditionally meets in March, June and September every year.
3. It assesses credentials of UN members and reports to the General Assembly.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 3 only (b) 1 and 3 (c) 2 and 3 (d) 1 and 2

2. With reference to the United Nations General Assembly, consider the following statements: **(2022)**

1. It can grant observer status to non-member States.
2. Inter-governmental organisations can seek observer status.
3. Permanent Observers can maintain missions at UN headquarters.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 only (b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

3. International Mother Language Day: **(2021)**

1. It was declared by UNICEF.
2. The demand for it was raised in Pakistan's Constituent Assembly.

Which of the statements given above is correct?

(a) 1 only (b) 2 only (c) Both (d) Neither

4. The non-permanent members of the UNSC are elected for a term of: **(2009)**

(a) 1 year (b) 2 years (c) 3 years (d) 5 years

5. Consider the following pairs: **(2020)**

	International agreement	-	**set-up Subject**
1.	Alma-Ata Declaration	-	Healthcare of the people
2.	Hague Convention	-	Biological and Chemical Weapons
3.	Talanoa Dialogue	-	Global Climate Change
4.	Under 2 Coalition	-	Child Rights

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

(a) 1 and 2 only (b) 4 only
(c) 1 and 3 only (d) 2, 3 and 4 only

Answers: 1(a), 2(d), 3(b), 4(b), 5(c)

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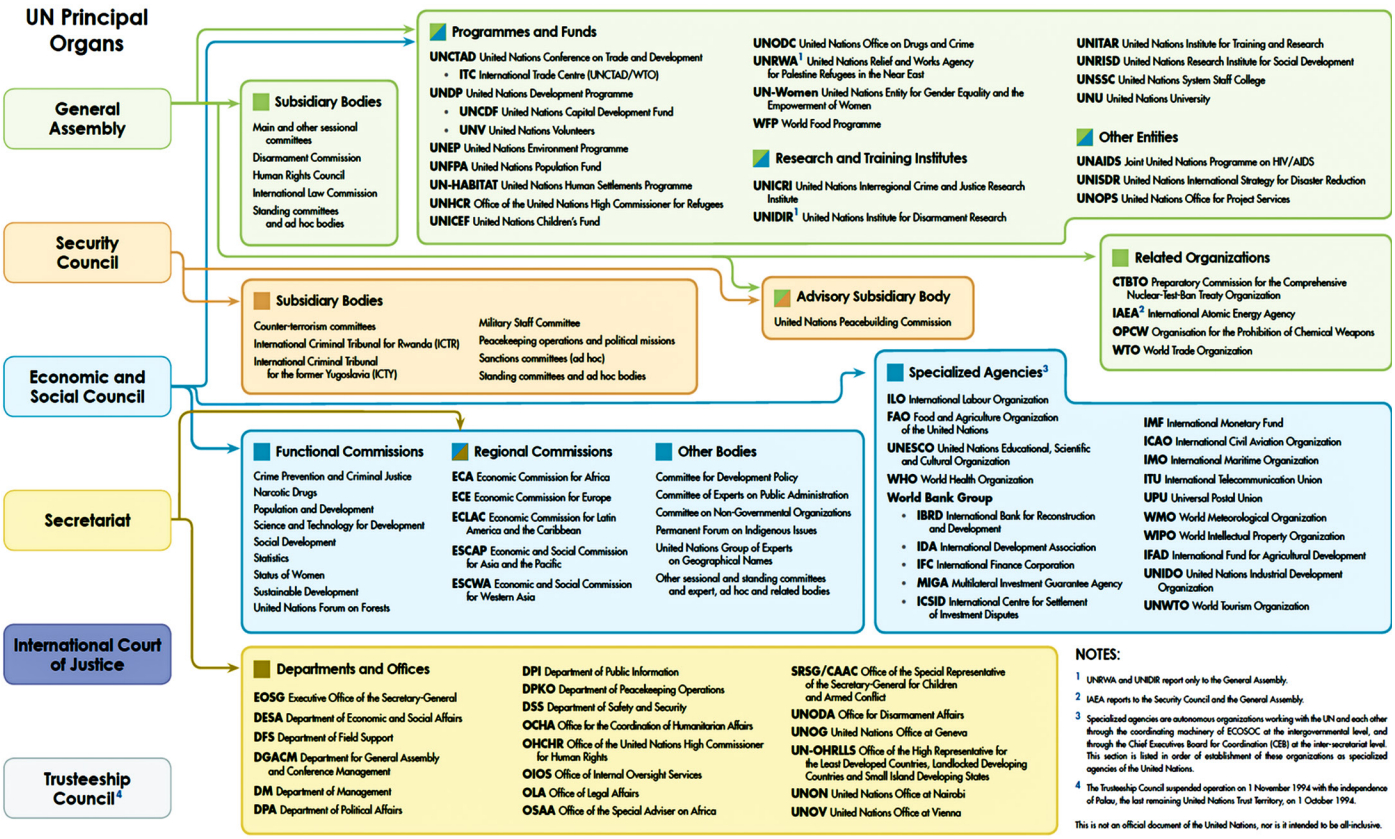
The United Nations System



UN Principal Organs

The United Nations Charter established **six principal organs** to carry out its work: the General Assembly, Security Council, the Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC), the Trusteeship Council, the International Court of Justice (ICJ), and the Secretariat. The **Trusteeship Council** suspended its operations in **1994** and is no longer active but legally exists.

UN General Assembly
- HQ: New York, USA
- Members: 193

- **Role:** Primary deliberative and policymaking arm of the UN.
- **Meetings:** Regular annual session begins in September
- **Functions:** approves the UN's budget and the financial assessments of member states.
  - ♦ It can grant observer status to **non-member States.**
  - ♦ Inter-governmental organisations can seek observer status.
  - ♦ Permanent Observers can **maintain missions at UN headquarters**.
- **UN Credentials Committee** is a vital back-end committee of the General Assembly
- **Composition:** It consists of **nine members.**
- **India is not one of the 9 members** of the committee for the current 80th session (2025–2026)
- **UN 80 Initiative: Launch:** March 2025 (80th Anniversary); **Aim➔** Streamline operations ➔ Improve efficiency ➔ Reaffirm multilateralism.
- **Three Workstreams:** Identify operational efficiencies ➔ Review mandate implementations ➔ Execute structural & programmatic realignments.
- **Coordination:** Led by UN80 Task Force (Under-Secretary-General for Policy) ➔ Drives execution across 7 thematic clusters.

United Nations Security Council
- HQ: New York, USA
- Members: 15

- **Role:** Maintaining international peace and security and Investigates acts of aggression and other threats to peace → Authority to **impose sanctions** and authorise the use of force
- **Members:** 5 (permanent) + 10 (non-permanent; elected by UNGA for a 2-year term).
  - ♦ 5/10 non-permanent seats are replaced annually on January 1st.
- 9 votes are required, including concurring votes of permanent members (i.e., no veto by any P5 member) for the Council to issue a Substantive Decisions (non-procedural).
  - ♦ For Procedural Decisions: Require nine affirmative votes (can be any nine members)
- As of Jan 2026 **non permanent members** → Bahrain, Colombia, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Denmark, Greece, Latvia, Liberia, Pakistan, Panama, and Somalia

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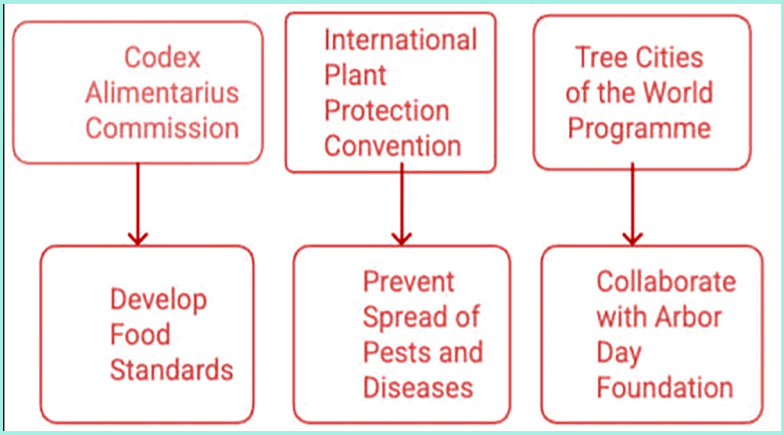
The Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) • HQ: New York, USA	• **Role:** Central forum for discussing the world's economic, social, and environmental challenges • Seats are allocated among **5 regions** to ensure **equitable geographic representation**. • **Members (54):** Elected by the General Assembly to serve overlapping **3-year terms**. • India has been elected to the UN Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) for the term of 2026–2028.
The Secretariat • HQ: New York, USA	• **Role:** UN's administrative arm → carries out the day-to-day operations of the organisation • **Secretary General:** Appointed by the **UNGA o**n the recommendation of the Security Council→ **5-year**, renewable term. • Serves as the **public face of the UN** + **principal spokesperson** for its policy initiatives
The International Court of Justice • HQ: Hague, Netherlands • Members: 15	• **Role:** UN's principal judicial organ • **Functions**: The Court adjudicates **interstate disputes.** • **No two judges from the same country** can serve simultaneously. • Seats are informally **apportioned geographically** to ensure the judges from all of the world. • Judges elected by both the UNGA and UNSC to serve nine-year terms.

UN Specialised agencies

Agency	Details
Food And Agricultural Organisation • HQ: Rome, Italy • Member: 193+ EU	**Aim:** To fight hunger and improve nutrition and food security  • **Initiatives:** ♦ **International Year of the Woman Farmer 2026** ♦ International Year of **Rangelands and Pastoralists 2026.** ♦ FAO/IAEA **"Atoms for Food."** • **Reports:** State of the World's Forests, Global Food Price Index, State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World (SOFI) and State of Food and Agriculture (SOFA)
International Civil Aviation Organization (ICAO) • HQ: Montreal, Canada • Members: 193	• Established in 1944 to develop consensus-driven international standards and practices to **facilitate safe, reliable, efficient, and sustainable international air travel.** • **Reports:** The World Civil Aviation Report, ICAO Safety Report. • **Initiative:** Launch of Carbon Offsetting and Reduction Scheme for International Aviation **(CORSIA)** Phase 1 → first global market-based scheme that applies to the aviation sector. It complements other aviation in-sector emissions reductions efforts
International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD) • HQ: Rome. • Members: 180	• Established in **1977** to work directly with the rural poor in developing countries and **empower them to improve their food security, income and resilience.** • **Report: State of Food Security and Nutrition → By** FAO + IFAD + UNICEF + WFP + WHO.
International Labour Organization (ILO) • HQ: Geneva, Switzerland • Members: 187	• Established in 1919 by the Treaty of Versailles following World War I to promote social justice and to establish internationally recognized labour standards • The **first specialized agency of the UN** officially associated with the UN in 1946. • India ratified ILO convention **138 and 182 in 2017.** • **The 6th Global Conference on the Elimination of** Child Labour was held in Marrakech, Morocco, from 11 to 13 February 2026. • **Report:** World Employment and Social Outlook (WESO).

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International Maritime Organization (IMO) • HQ: London, UK • Members: 176	• **Role:** Responsibility for the safety and security of shipping and the prevention of marine and atmospheric pollution by ships. • In December 2025, India was **re-elected to the IMO Council** under Category B. • IMO acts as the official repository for notices and certificates of sale under the Beijing Convention on the Judicial Sale of Ships, which officially entered into force on 17 February 2026 and was developed by UNCITRAL. • **Key conventions under IMO:** International Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea (SOLAS), 1974 and International Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships (**MARPOL).** • **Initiative: GloLitter Partnerships** Project by IMO and the Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) → aimed at helping developing countries reduce sea-based marine plastic litter from shipping and fisheries

- **Polar Code:** IMO mandatory framework → ensures ship safety & environmental protection in Arctic/Antarctic waters → Created by the International Maritime Organization (IMO) under the SOLAS and MARPOL conventions.
  - **Territories:** Arctic claims → guided by UNCLOS; Antarctic claims → frozen by the 1959 Antarctic Treaty → There is no single Polar Code for drawing borders. Arctic nations (like Russia and Canada) use the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) to legally claim the ocean floor. The Antarctic Treaty completely bans anyone from making new land claims in the South Pole.
- **Research:** South Pole → governed by Antarctic Treaty/Madrid Protocol; North Pole → national laws & Svalbard Treaty.

International Telecommunications Union (ITU) • HQ: Geneva, Switzerland	• **Aim:** To facilitate **connectivity in modern telecommunications** networks→ Allocates the **global radio spectrum and satellite orbits.** • It is made up of a membership of 194 member states and more than 1000 companies, universities, and international and regional organizations. • **Reports:** Global Cybersecurity Index, Global Connectivity Report.
United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) • HQ: Paris, France	• **Aim: Promotes international cooperation** in the fields of education, science, and culture. • The U.S. has officially notified UNESCO of its intent to leave for the third time, a decision that will take effect at the end of December 2026. • **Reports:** Global Education Monitoring (GEM) Report. • **Initiatives:** World Heritage Sites, Intangible Cultural Heritage, Creative Cities Network.
United Nations Industrial Development Organization (UNIDO)	• **HQ:** Vienna, Austria. • Mission of **industrial development for poverty reduction, inclusive globalization,** and **environmental sustainability in developing countries** • **Report:** Competitive Industrial Performance (CIP) Index.
UN Tourism (formerly United Nations World Tourism Organization, (UNWTO)	• HQ: Madrid, Spain • **Aim:** To promote tourism as a driver of **economic growth and development** that is inclusive and accessible to all. • **Reports/Publications :** World Tourism Barometer, Yearbook of Tourism Statistics, UN Tourism E-library.
Universal Postal Union (UPU)	• **HQ:** Bern, Switzerland. • Coordinates **global postal services** and **international mail systems**. • **Report:** Integrated Index for Postal Development (2IPD).
World Health Organization (WHO) • HQ: Geneva, Switzerland • Members: 194	• **Aim:** To improve the **health of individuals** and the provision of healthcare services. • **Pandemic agreement: Aimed to** correct COVID-19 governance weaknesses and strengthen global prevention, preparedness, and response to future pandemics. • **Reports:** World Health Statistics, Global Tuberculosis (TB) Report, World Malaria Report. • **Alma-Ata Declaration:** A landmark 1978 agreement identifying **Primary Health Care** as the central strategy for achieving "Health for All."
World Intellectual Property Organization (WIPO)	• **HQ:** Geneva, Switzerland. • **Aim**: Promotes **protection of intellectual property rights** globally. • **Reports**: World Intellectual Property Report, Global Innovation Index, WIPO Technology Trends, World Intangible Investment Highlights, World Intellectual Property Indicator
World Meteorological Organization (WMO) • HQ: Geneva, Switzerland	• **E**stablished on March 23, 1950, to facilitate international cooperation in meteorology, operational hydrology, and related geophysical sciences • **Initiatives: G3W** (Global Greenhouse Gas Watch), Early Warnings for All **(EW4All).**

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Other UN Agencies and Missions

United Nations Human Rights Council. • HQ: Geneva, Switzerland	• Consists of 47 States responsible for the promotion and protection of all human rights around the globe. • From Jan 1, 2026, India officially started its 7th term as a member of the UNHRC. (2026-28).
UN Commission on Narcotic Drugs • HQ: Vienna, Austria	• **The Commission on Narcotic Drugs (CND)** is a high-yield functional commission of **ECOSOC** and the governing body of the **UNODC.** ♦ India was elected to chair the **68th Session of the CND** for the first time in history. • **Publishes** a report on the World Situation of Drug Abuse through the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC).
United Nations Relief and Works Agency for Palestine Refugees in the Near East (UNRWA)	• **HQ:** Amman (Jordan) and Gaza City. • To provide education, healthcare, and social services to Palestine refugees across Gaza, the West Bank, Jordan, Lebanon, and Syria → **Only UN agency dedicated to refugees from a specific region/conflict** (UNHCR covers others). • **UNHCR (Established in 1950 by UNGA):** HQ: Geneva ➔ Protects rights & futures of people fleeing conflict/persecution ➔ Won Nobel Peace Prize twice (1954 & 1981).
UN Peacekeeping	• Helps countries navigate the difficult path from conflict to peace. • **Deployment:** Mandated by UN Security Council resolutions ➔ Budget & resources approved by UN General Assembly. • **Governance:** Political & executive direction provided by the Department of Peace Operations (DPO, est. 1992). • **Honour:** Awarded the Nobel Peace Prize in 1988. • **Capstone Doctrine:** Sets guiding principles and core objectives.
United Nations Interim Force In Lebanon (UNIFIL)	• HQ: Naqoura, Lebanon (near the Blue Line) • **Peacekeeping mission** established in March 1978 to confirm Israeli withdrawal from southern Lebanon and restore international peace. • India is one of **the top troop contributors;** its "Blue Berets" are highly respected for local community outreach.
United Nations Office for Project Services (UNOPS) • HQ: Copenhagen, Denmark.	• Provides **infrastructure, procurement,** and project management services to help partners in **peacebuilding, humanitarian,** and development projects. • **UNOPS Compass:** A new AI and satellite-driven internal digital infrastructure framework. • It is currently being used in **Gaza** and **Ukraine** to map structural damage in real-time. • **UNOPS** + Denmark → to support India's flagship programme, Jal Jeevan Mission in Uttar Pradesh on World Water Day. • **Reports:** Sustainability Report, Purchase for Impact, Statistical Report on UN Procurement (ASR).

UNCTAD ➔ World Investment Report ➔ Tracks global Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) trends.
World of Debt Report 2025 ➔ Analyzes external debt statistics for low- and middle-income countries.
UNFPA was Established in 1969 as UN Fund for Population Activities **➔** Renamed UN Population Fund in 1987 **➔ State of World Population 2025: The Real Fertility Crisis**.

2.2 Global Financial Institutions

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following statements in respect of the International Bank for Reconstruction and Development (IBRD): **(2025)**

I. It provides loans and guarantees to middle income countries.

II. It works single-handedly to help developing countries to reduce poverty.

III. It was established to help Europe rebuild after World War II.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

(a) I and II only (b) II and III only (c) I and III only (d) I, II and III

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2. The International Development Association, a lending agency, is administered by the: **(2010)**

(a) International Bank for Reconstruction and Development
(b) International Fund for Agricultural Development
(c) United Nations Development Programme
(d) United Nations Industrial Development Organization

3. Which of the following is NOT related to the United Nations? **(2010)**

(a) Multilateral Investment Guarantee Agency (MIGA)
(b) International Finance Corporation (IFC)
(c) International Centre for Settlement of Investment Disputes (ICSID)
(d) Bank for International Settlements (BIS)

Answers: 1(c), 2(a), 3(d)

World Bank Group

- **HQ:** Washington, DC → It aims to reduce poverty by providing financing + policy advice + technical assistance to developing countries → specialized agency of the UN System.
- **International Bank for Reconstruction and Development (IBRD)**: Established in **1944** at the **Bretton Woods Conference** to help Europe rebuild after the d**evastation of World War II.**

Bank for International Settlements (BIS)

- **HQ:** Basel, Switzerland; **two representative offices:** in Hong Kong SAR and in Mexico City.
- Goal: To **foster international monetary and financial cooperation** while serving as a bank for central banks.

IMF - International Monetary Fund

- **Headquarters:** → Washington, D.C., USA
- **Membership:** → 191 countries (Governed by and accountable to these members);
  - **Liechtenstein** recently joined as the **191st member in late 2024.**
- **Core Objective:** → Achieve sustainable growth and prosperity globally
- Core Functions:
  - **Policy Advice:** Monitors economic/financial developments and advises nations
  - **Financial Assistance:** Provides loans and financial aid to member countries
  - **Capacity Development: Offers** technical training to help governments implement sound policies.

AIIB (Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank)

- Headquarters→ Beijing, China
- **AIIB Membership → 100 Billion authorized capital → AAA-rated.**
- Total → 111 approved members worldwide.
- Scope → Both regional (Asia/Oceania) and non-regional (Europe, Africa, Americas) nations.
- Top Shareholders → China (1st), India (2nd), Russia (3rd), Germany (4th).
- Broad Participation → Includes major Western economies (UK, France, Australia, Canada).
- Notable Non-Members → USA and Japan.

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2.3 International Agencies for Strategic Resources and Non-Proliferation

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. In India, why are some nuclear reactors kept under "IAEA Safeguards" while others are not? **(2020)**
(a) Some use uranium and others thorium
(b) Some use imported uranium and others domestic supplies
(c) Some are foreign-operated
(d) Some are State-owned

2. In the Indian context, what is the implication of ratifying the 'Additional Protocol' with the IAEA? **(2018)**
(a) Civilian nuclear reactors come under IAEA safeguards
(b) Military installations come under inspection
(c) India can buy uranium from NSG
(d) India becomes NSG member

3. With reference to OPCW, consider the following statements: **(2016)**
1. It is an EU organization.
2. It monitors chemical industry.
3. It provides assistance against chemical weapons.
Which are correct?
(a) 1 only (b) 2 and 3 (c) 1 and 3 (d) All

Answers: 1. (b), 2. (a), 3. (b)

Organisation for the Prohibition of Chemical Weapons (OPCW)
- HQ: The Hague, Netherlands

- Implements and verifies the **Chemical Weapons Convention (CWC)** to ensure the **complete elimination of chemical weapons worldwide**.
- India is a signatory; **the Indian Chemical Council (ICC)** was recently honoured with the **2024 OPCW-The Hague Award**.

Chemical Weapons Convention (CWC) → A 1997 multilateral treaty that bans the development, production, acquisition, stockpiling, transfer, and use of chemical weapons, requiring their total destruction under strict international verification.

International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA)
- HQ: Vienna, Austria

- **Autonomous organization** within the United Nations system.
- **Role:** Promotes **peaceful use of nuclear energy** and ensures **nuclear safeguards and non-proliferation**.
- The organisation reports to both the **UNGA and UNSC.**

Additional Protocol (AP):
- A **voluntary legal agreement** that strengthens the **IAEA safeguards system**, allowing broader inspections and information access.
- **India:** Signed the **Additional Protocol in 2009** and **ratified it in 2014**. In India, it applies **only to civilian nuclear facilities voluntarily placed under IAEA safeguards.**

International Energy Agency

- **Origin:** 1974 Oil Crisis ➔ Founded by 17 OECD nations to ensure collective energy security.
- **Mission:** Safeguard stable oil supplies ➔ Coordinate global emergency responses to disruptions.
- **Mechanism:** Mandates minimum strategic oil reserves for members ➔ Cushions sudden supply shocks.
- **Full Members:** 32 countries ➔ A candidate country to the IEA must be a member country of the OECD.
- **Associates:** 13 non-OECD nations (like India) ➔ Can participate in discussions but lack voting rights.

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2.4 European Institutions

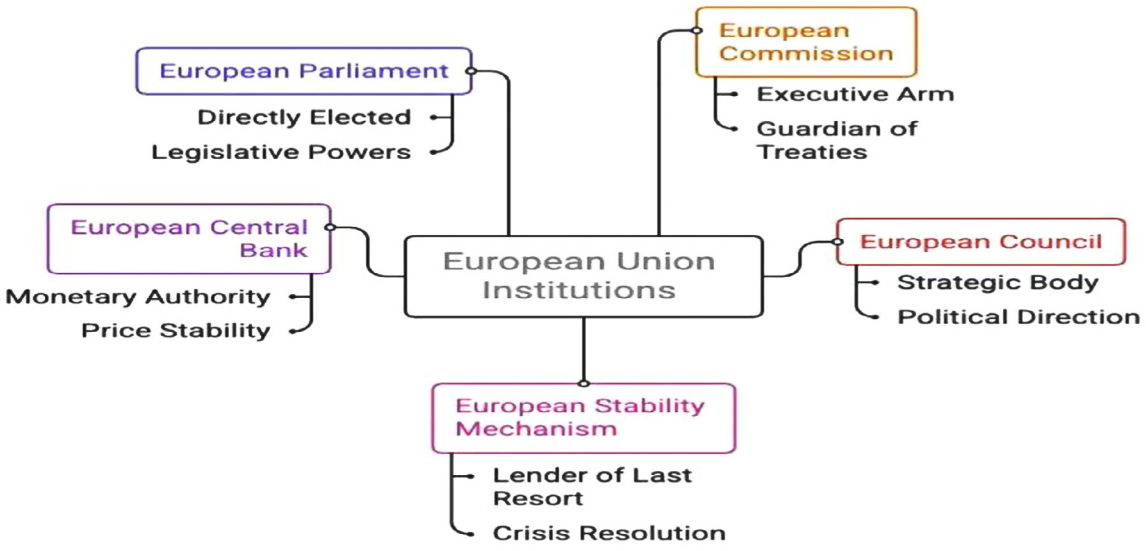
UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. 'European Stability Mechanism', sometimes seen in the news, is an: **(2016)**
   (a) Agency created by EU to deal with the impact of millions of refugees arriving from Middle East
   (b) Agency of EU that provides financial assistance to eurozone countries
   (c) Agency of EU to deal with all the bilateral and multilateral agreements on trade
   (d) Agency of EU to deal with the conflicts arising among the member countries.

Answers: 1(b)

European Union • **Main HQ:** Brussels, Belgium	• **Established:** November 1, 1993 (via Maastricht Treaty) • **Aim:** To ensure peace in post-WWII Europe by integrating economies • **Members**: 27 Countries. (The UK officially exited via Brexit on Jan 31, 2020).
European Commission	• **Functions:** Proposes **EU legislation** + Implements **EU policies and budget** • Enforces EU law as the **"Guardian of the Treaties".** • Represents **EU-wide interests (supranational)** rather than individual member states.
European Council	• **Role:** Provides **overall political direction and priorities** of the EU. • **Composition:** Heads of State or Government of EU member states, plus the President of the European Council and the President of the European Commission. • **Decision-making:** Mostly by **consensus**. • European Council ≠ Council of the European Union.
European Stability Mechanism (ESM)	• **Role: Financial crisis resolution mechanism for Eurozone countries**. • Provides **loans and bailout packages** to member states facing **severe financial distress**. • **Nature: An Intergovernmental organization**, not an EU institution. • HQ: Luxembourg City, Luxembourg
European Central Bank (ECB) • HQ: Frankfurt, Germany	• **Role:** Central bank of the Eurozone. • **Functions:** Maintain **price stability.** + Manage the **Euro currency.** ♦ Set **interest rates** and conduct **monetary policy**. • **The Reserve Bank of India** collaborates with the ECB on **CBDC research and financial regulation dialogues**.
European Parliament	• **Role: Legislative, supervisory, and budgetary authority** of the EU. • Members of the European Parliament (MEPs) are **directly elected every 5 years** by EU citizens. • Shares law-making power with the **Council of the European Union**. • **Official Seat:** Strasbourg, France → **Political Seat:** Brussels, Belgium • **Administrative Seat:** Luxembourg City, Luxembourg

Key EU Institutions and Their Roles



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2.5 International Law & Humanitarian Agencies

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Doctors Without Borders (Medecins Sans Frontieres), often in the news, is: **(2016)**
(a) A division of World Health Organization
(b) A non-governmental international organization
(c) An inter-governmental agency sponsored by European Union
(d) A specialized agency of the United Nations

Answers: 1(b)

International Criminal Court (ICC)
- **HQ:** Hague, Netherlands

- World's first permanent international criminal court governed by the Rome Statute (2002).
- To prosecute individuals for genocide, war crimes, crimes against humanity, and the crime of aggression.
- Mali, Niger, and Burkina Faso have announced their withdrawal from the ICC.
- **India:** neither signed nor ratified.

Interpol
- HQ: Lyon
- India: member since 1949.

- World's largest global police cooperation that facilitates **data sharing and investigative support** to combat transnational crime.
- India recently launched the **BHARATPOL** portal to streamline communication with Interpol.

Doctors Without Borders / Médecins Sans Frontières (MSF)
- **HQ:** Geneva

- Independent **medical humanitarian** organization providing **emergency healthcare** in conflict zones, epidemics, and disasters.
- It issued a warning regarding **"TRIPS-plus"** provisions in the **India-EU FTA** arguing that stricter patent rules could kill the **"Pharmacy of the World."**
- Nobel Peace Prize winner, 1999

2.6 Miscellaneous Organisations / Groupings

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following statements regarding World Toilet Organisation: (2024)
1. It is one of the agencies of the United Nations.
2. World Toilet Summit, World Toilet Day and World Toilet College are the initiatives of this organization.
3. The main focus of its function is to grant funds to countries to achieve the end of open defecation.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
(a) 2 only (b) 3 only (c) 1 and 2 (d) 2 and 3

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2. Consider the following statements: **(2024)**
1. India is a member of the International Grains Council.
2. A country needs to be a member of the International Grains Council for exporting or importing rice and wheat.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
(a) 1 only (b) 2 only (c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

3. Consider the following statements: **(2022)**
1. "The Climate Group" is an international non-profit organization that drives climate action by building large networks and runs them.
2. The International Energy Agency in partnership with the Climate Group launched a global initiative "EP100".
3. EP100 brings together leading companies committed to driving innovation in energy efficiency and increasing competitiveness while delivering on emission reduction goals.
4. Some Indian companies are members of EP100.
5. The International Energy Agency is the Secretariat to the "Under2 Coalition".

Which of the statements given above are correct?
(a) 1, 2, 4 and 5 (b) 1, 3 and 4 only
(c) 2, 3 and 5 only (d) 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5

4. Consider the following statements: **(2021)**
1. The Global Ocean Commission grants licences for seabed exploration and mining in international waters.
2. India has received licences for seabed mineral exploration in international waters.
3. 'Rare earth minerals' are present on the seafloor in international waters.

Which of the statements given above are correct?
(a) 1 and 2 only (b) 2 and 3 only (c) 1 and 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3.

5. Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action is: **(2015)**
(a) Anti-terror strategy
(b) Asia-Pacific economic plan
(c) UN agenda for women's empowerment
(d) Wildlife trafficking declaration

6. Stiglitz Commission dealt with: **(2010)**
(a) The challenges posed by the impending global climate change and prepare a road map
(b) The workings of the global financial systems and to explore ways and means to secure a more sustainable global order.
(c) Global terrorism and prepare a global acting plan for the mitigation of terrorism.
(d) Expansion of the United Nations Security Council in the present global scenario.

Answers: 1. (a), 2. (a), 3. (b), 4. (b), 5. (c), 6. (b)

Beijing Declaration & Platform for Action

- Adopted in 1995 at the **Fourth World Conference on Women** held in Beijing, China → A global policy framework for women's empowerment and gender equality.
- It is a landmark UN policy document managed by UN Women with monitoring led by the Commission on the Status of Women (CSW) at the UN Headquarters in New York.
- The 30th-anniversary review takes place in 2025 at UN Headquarters, New York.
- **Focus areas: 12 critical areas of concern,** including poverty, education, health, violence against women, political participation, and economic empowerment.

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Stiglitz Commission

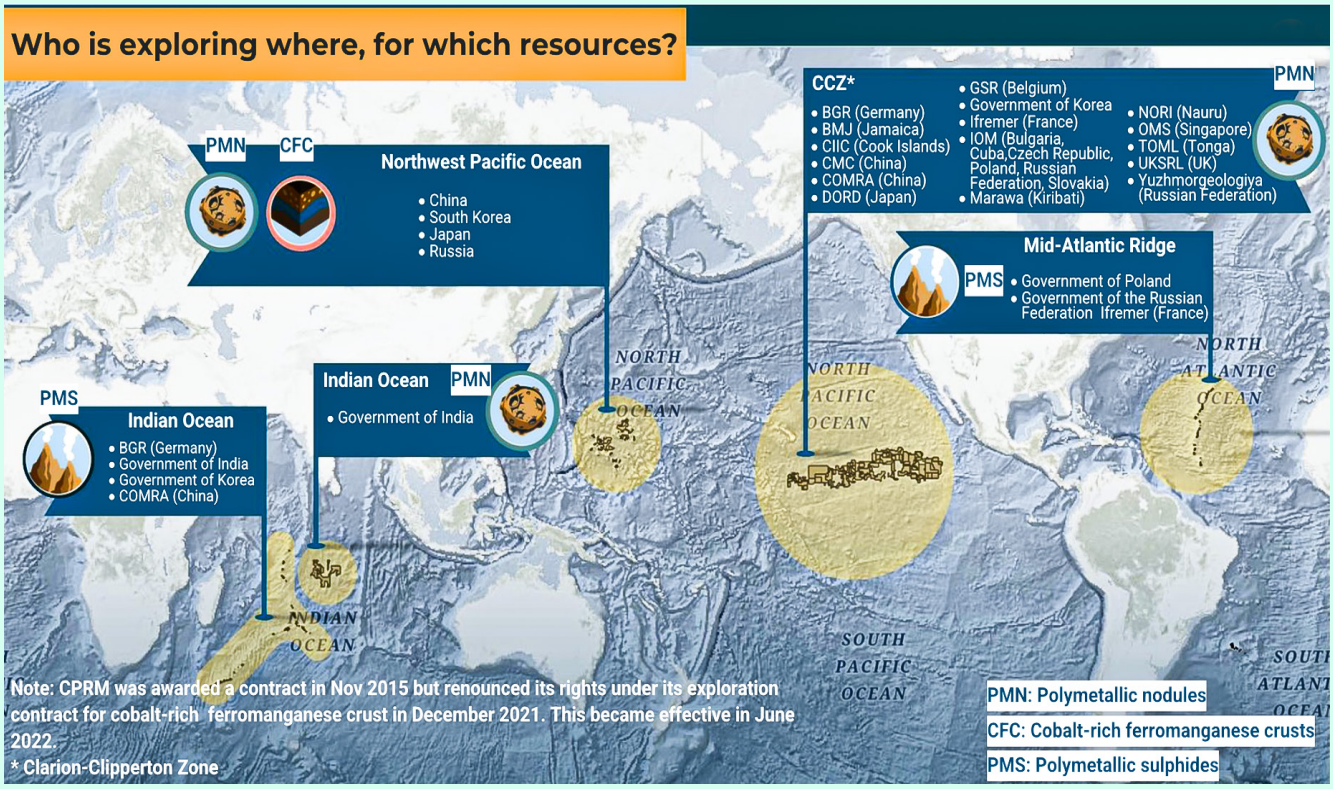
- **Established: In** 2008 by the Government of France under President Nicolas Sarkozy.
- Earlier known as the Commission on the Measurement of Economic Performance and Social Progress → **Chaired by** Nobel laureate economist Joseph Stiglitz.
- **Purpose:** To **develop better indicators beyond GDP** for measuring **economic performance, well-being, and sustainability**.
- **Nature:** Temporary high-level commission.

World Toilet Organisation

- **HQ:** Singapore → **Founded: 2001** by **Jack Sim** (nicknamed "Mr. Toilet").
- **Aim:** Promote **sanitation awareness and end open defecation by breaking social taboos around toilets**.
- **Key initiatives: World Toilet Day** (19 November; recognized by the UN in 2013).
  - ♦ **World Toilet College** for sanitation training.
- **Status: Not a UN agency**, but has held **consultative status with ECOSOC since 2013**.
- **Recent context: World Toilet Summit 2025 in New Delhi**, hosted with **Sulabh International**.

International Seabed Authority

- **HQ:** Kingston, Jamaica.
- Established in 1994 under the **United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea** (1982) to regulate, organize, and control all mineral-related activities in the international deep seabed area beyond national jurisdiction (the "Area").
  - ♦ Its primary mandate is to manage these resources for the benefit of humankind while ensuring effective protection of the marine environment.
- **Members:** As of 6 February 2026, ISA has 172 Members, including 171 Member States and the European Union.
- **Principle:** Deep seabed resources are the **"Common Heritage of Mankind."**
- **Focus points: Membership:** All UNCLOS parties automatically become ISA members.
  - ♦ **Non-member example:** United States (has not ratified UNCLOS).
- ISA grants exploration contracts (usually 15-year contracts) for minerals like **polymetallic nodules** and sulfides and also promotes marine scientific research and technology transfer to developing countries



International Grains Council (IGC)

- Established in 1949 as the International Wheat Council with headquarters in London, UK.
- India is a member; classification as exporter/importer is situational, not a fixed category.
- An intergovernmental organization that oversees the **Grains Trade Convention** of 1995.
- It provides market transparency + promotes cooperation in the global trade of grains, rice, and oilseeds.

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- **Hague Convention:** A series of treaties primarily focused on the **Laws of War** (conduct of soldiers) and international legal cooperation like **Child Abduction** issues.
- **Talanoa Dialogue:** A participatory process introduced at COP23 (2017) to help countries review and improve their **Climate Change** targets.
- **Under2 Coalition:** A global community of state and regional governments committed to ambitious **Climate Action** to keep warming well below 2°C.
  - Climate Group acts as the Under2 Coalition's secretariat.
- **The Climate Group (Founded 2003)** → International non-profit organization.
  - **Goal:** Net-zero carbon by 2050 → Greater global prosperity.
  - **Strategy:** Builds networks → Unlocks collective action and influence.
- **EP100 Initiative** → Led by The Climate Group → NOT the International Energy Agency (IEA).
  - Focus: Bringing together over 100 energy-smart businesses to drive climate action.
  - Impact: Reduces emissions → Improves corporate competitiveness.
  - Mahindra & Mahindra, Godrej Industries, JSW Cement, and UltraTech Cement are part of it.

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3 Connectivity

3.1. Important Corridors

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. India is one of the founding members of the International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC), a multimodal transportation corridor, which will connect **(2025)**
(a) India to Central Asia to Europe via Iran
(b) India to Central Asia via China
(c) India to South-East Asia through Bangladesh and Myanmar
(d) India to Europe through Azerbaijan

2. With reference to India's projects on connectivity, consider the following statements: **(2023)**
1. East-West Corridor under Golden Quadrilateral Project connects Dibrugarh and Surat.
2. Trilateral Highway connects Moreh in Manipur and Chiang Mai in Thailand via Myanmar.
3. Bangladesh- China- India- Myanmar Economic Corridor connects Varanasi in Uttar Pradesh with Kunming in China.
How many of the above statements are correct?
(a) Only one (b) Only two (c) All three (d) None

3. Belt and Road Initiative is related to the affairs of **(2016)**
(a) African Union (b) Brazil (c) European Union (d) China

Answer: 1. (a), 2. (d), 3. (d)

Belt and Road Initiative

- **Launched in 2013** by China → Global Infrastructure connectivity → trade routes (land + sea) → economic integration across Asia–Europe–Africa → strategic expansion of China's influence → utilisation of surplus industrial capacity.
- **Components:**
  - **Silk Road Economic Belt (SREB)** → Land corridors across Eurasia.
  - **21st Century Maritime Silk Road (MSR)** → Sea routes across the Indian Ocean → Europe.
  - Concerns: debt sustainability → transparency issues → strategic influence.
- **India's Position:** India is **not a part of BRI** → main objection: the China–Pakistan Economic Corridor passes through **Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK)** → violates sovereignty & territorial integrity.
- **String of Pearls** → Chinese development of ports/infrastructure across the Indian Ocean region → secure **Sea Lines of Communication (SLOCs).**

- **Related Corridor:** Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar Economic Corridor → proposed **Kunming–Kolkata corridor** → largely inactive after China subsumed it under BRI.

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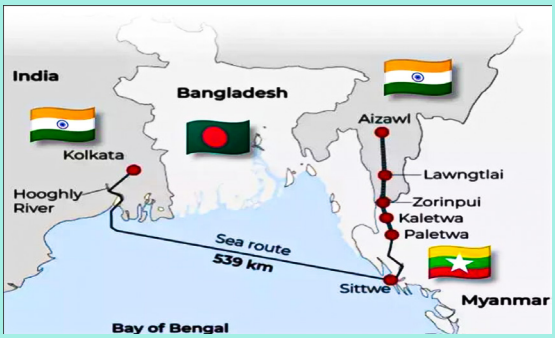
Kaladan Multimodal Transit Transport Project

- **Aim:** Alternative to **Siliguri Corridor** (Chicken's Neck) → sea-river-road link → faster cargo to **Mizoram/NE India**.
- **Route:** Kolkata Port → Sittwe Port (Myanmar) → Kaladan River inland waterway → Paletwa (Myanmar) → Road link → Zorinpui (Mizoram, India).
- Enhances **India–Myanmar connectivity** and access to **Northeast development**.



BIMSTEC Transport Connectivity

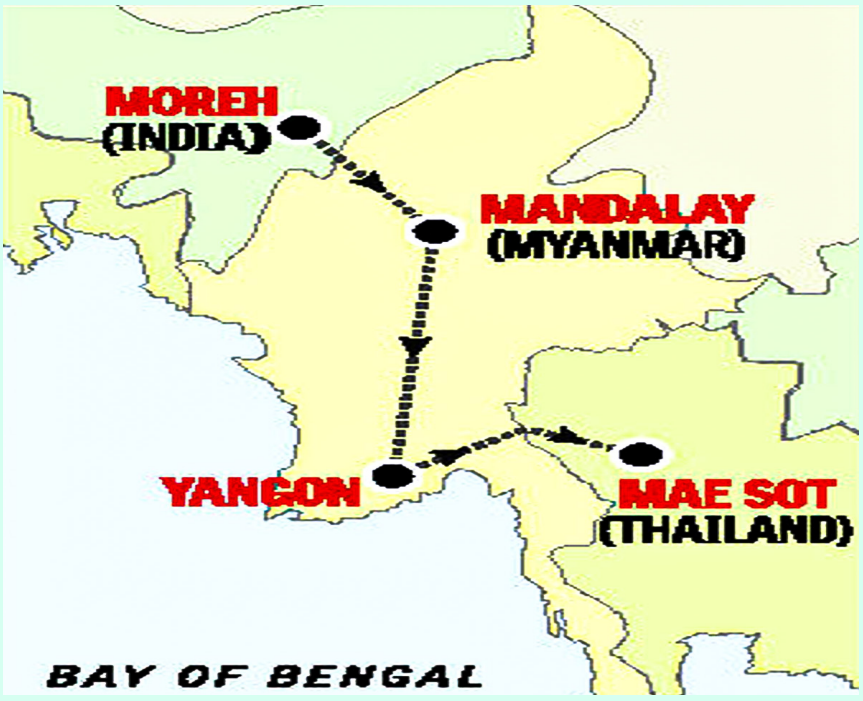
- **Aim:** To improve regional connectivity among **7 member countries** (Bangladesh, Bhutan, **India,** Myanmar, Nepal, Sri Lanka, and Thailand).
- **Master Plan for Transport Connectivity (2022) → 267 infrastructure projects** covering **road, maritime, rail, air and digital connectivity**.
- **Objective:** Act as a **connectivity bridge between South Asia and ASEAN**.
- The Kaladan Multimodal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand (IMT) Trilateral Highway **align with the goals of BIMSTEC connectivity goals.**

BBIN Motor Vehicle Agreement

- **Signed in 2015 (Thimphu)** → sub-regional transport pact among **Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal**.
- **Aim:** Facilitate **seamless cross-border movement of passenger, personal and cargo vehicles** → reduce transit time and logistics costs → eliminate **trans-shipment (unloading/reloading) at borders**.
- **India–Bangladesh–Nepal** implementing cargo movement through interim arrangements/trial runs while Bhutan's ratification remains pending.

India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway

- **Aim:** Provide **land connectivity between India and Southeast Asia** → boost trade and integration with **ASEAN markets** → support India's **Act East Policy**.
- **Route:** Moreh (Manipur, India) → **Tamu → Kalewa → Mandalay → Naypyidaw → Myawaddy (Myanmar) → Mae Sot (Thailand)**
- India is pushing for **India–Myanmar–Thailand Motor Vehicle Agreement (MVA)** → enabling seamless passenger & cargo movement → proposing **India–Thailand bus connectivity** once operationalised.



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Trans-Asian Highway Network

- **Aim:** Initiative of United Nations Economic and Social Commission for Asia and the Pacific **(UN-ESCAP)** initiative→ develop a **continent-wide highway system across Asia** spanning 32 countries, connecting Tokyo to Istanbul and St. Petersburg to Jakarta → standardized road infrastructure → promote regional and intercontinental trade.
- **India is** a core participant → **AH1, AH2, AH42, AH43, AH45, AH46, AH47 and AH48 routes pass through India**. → Recent upgradation of **AH48 (Jaigaon–Phuentsholing)** corridor has been aimed to strengthen **India–Bhutan connectivity and trade**.

Trans-Asian Railway Network

- **UN-ESCAP initiative** to create a continent-wide integrated rail network across Europe and Asia, often called the **"Iron Silk Road."**
- **Aim:** To facilitate freight movement between **Europe and Pacific ports** and improve connectivity of **landlocked countries (Laos, Mongolia, Central Asia)**.
- **India participated through** (Istanbul-Tehran-Islamabad-Delhi-Kolkata-Dhaka-Yangon) → **Akhaura–Agartala rail link (India-Bangladesh)** enhancing regional connectivity.
- **Note: No active rail transit** between **Islamabad and Delhi** due to suspension of Samjhauta Express and freight trains

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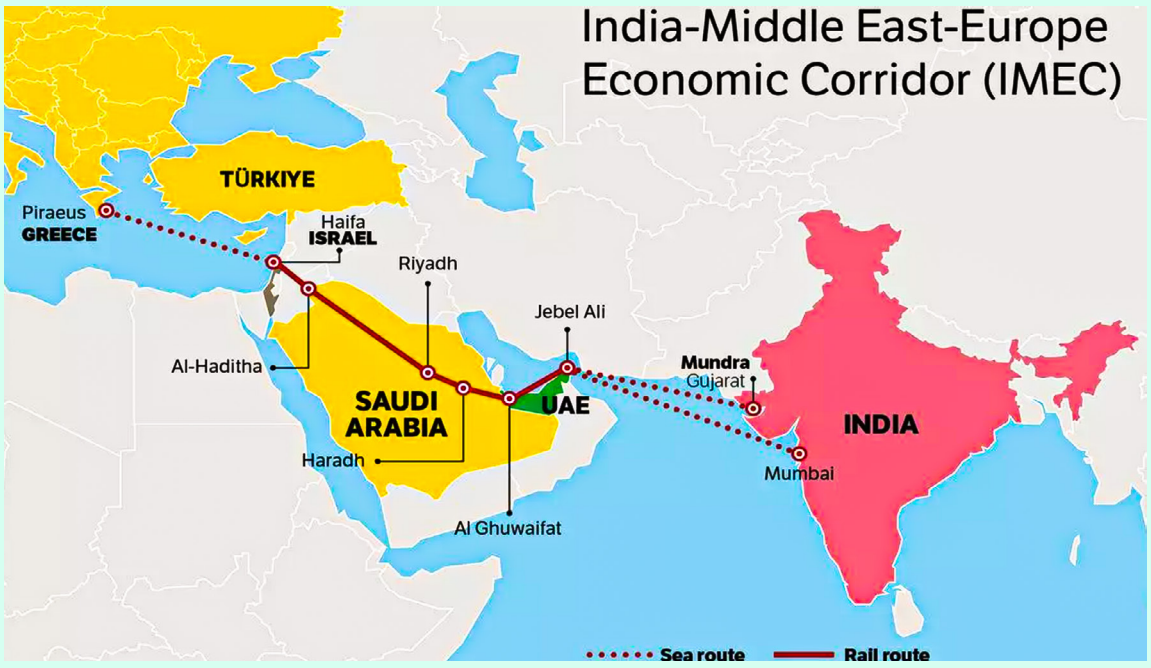
Chennai-Vladivostok Eastern Maritime Corridor (EMC)

- **Aim:** Connect **India's East Coast with Russia's Far East** → reduce shipping time to **~24 days from over 40 days** via the traditional Mumbai–St. Petersburg route → facilitate trade in **crude oil, coal, metals, fertilizers and other cargo**.
- **Route:** Chennai (India) → Andaman Sea → Strait of Malacca → South China Sea → Vladivostok (Russia).
- **The Corridor became operational in 2024**.

India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC)

- **Launched** during India's G20 presidency in 2023.
- **Aim:** Multi-modal ship-to-rail transit → integrates Asia, the Arabian Gulf, and Europe → considered counter to China's BRI.
- **Route:** Mumbai/Mundra → UAE (Jebel Ali) → Saudi Arabia → Jordan → Israel (Haifa) → Greece (Piraeus) → Europe.
- Goal: Expected to **reduce the transit time between its eastern and western nodes by 40%**, and **costs by 30%,** compared to transportation via the Suez Canal.
- **India's Role:** India is a **key eastern node**, connecting its ports with the Gulf region and Europe.
- India & UAE signed a deal to operationalize a **Virtual Trade Corridor** → digital tracking to reduce paper-based delays.
  - ♦ G7 leaders reaffirmed funding via the **PGII (Partnership for Global Infrastructure and Investment) -** initiative to mobilize $600 billion for global infrastructure in developing countries as an alternative to BRI.



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International North - South Transport Corridor (INSTC)

- **Aim:** Multimodal transport corridor connecting **India with Russia and Europe via Iran and the Caspian region** → designed to **reduce transit time and logistics cost compared to the Suez Canal route**.
- **Route:** Mumbai (India) → Bandar Abbas / Chabahar (Iran) → Caspian Sea → Baku (Azerbaijan) → Astrakhan → Moscow / St. Petersburg (Russia). (It combines ship, rail and road transport.)
- India is a **founding member** of INSTC (agreement signed in **2000 by India, Iran and Russia**).
- **Goal:** ~40% shorter and ~30% cheaper than the traditional Suez Canal route.
- **Recent update:** India signed a 10-year agreement (2024) to operate Shahid Beheshti terminal at Chabahar Port, strengthening INSTC connectivity.

Trans-Caspian International Transport Route (Middle Corridor)

- **Aim:** Eurasian trade corridor linking **China–Central Asia–Caucasus–Europe**, bypassing Russia's **Northern Corridor**.
- **Route:** China → Kazakhstan → Caspian Sea → Baku (Azerbaijan) → Tbilisi (Georgia) → Turkey → Europe.
- **Recent update:** Cargo volumes rising as Europe shifts away from Russian rail routes after the Russia-Ukraine war; infrastructure upgrades underway in Kazakhstan, Azerbaijan and Georgia.

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Asia-Africa Growth Corridor (AAGC)

- **Aim:** India-Japan joint initiative → provide an alternative to China's BRI → focus on Quality Infrastructure & Capacity Building in Africa.
- **Four Pillars:** Capacity & Skills; Quality Infrastructure; Development Projects (Health, Agri); People-to-People Partnership.
- **Recently,** new India–France–UAE cooperation in clean energy and infrastructure across the Indo-Pacific and Africa aligns with AAGC principles, though it is not formally part of the corridor.

Arctic Northern Sea Route (NSR)

- **Aim:** Shortcut maritime route linking **East Asia and Northern Europe via the Arctic Ocean** → can reduce distance and travel time by **about 30–40% compared with the Suez Canal route**.
- **Route:** Kara Sea → Laptev Sea → East Siberian Sea → Chukchi Sea → **Bering Strait** (ships often start from **Murmansk via the Barents Sea**).
- **India's Part: YES** (Stakeholder/Investor in Arctic resources).
- **Recent News:** India & Russia launched a joint dialogue on using **the NSR for the Chennai-Vladivostok Maritime Corridor.**
  - ♦ India's **Murmansk port cargo** share reached **35% in 2023.**

3.2. Important Pipelines

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following statements: **(2024)**

Statement-I: SUMED pipeline is a strategic route for Persian Gulf oil and natural gas shipments to Europe.

Statement-II: SUMED pipeline connects the Red Sea with the Mediterranean Sea.

Which one of the following is correct?

(a) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct and Statement-II explains Statement-I

(b) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct, but Statement-II does not explain Statement-I

(c) Statement-I is correct, but Statement-II is incorrect

(d) Statement-I is incorrect, but Statement-II is correct

Answer: 1. (a)

India-Bangladesh Friendship Pipelines (IBFP)

- **Aim:** Energy security for Northern Bangladesh → high-speed diesel transport → eco-friendly & cost-effective bypass to rail.
- **Route: Numaligarh Refinery Limited (Assam, India) → Siliguri Marketing Terminal (West Bengal) → Parbatipur Depot (Dinajpur, Bangladesh).**
  - ♦ *(Pipeline section runs from Siliguri to Parbatipur.)*
- Built under India's Grant-in-Aid assistance to Bangladesh.
- Bangladesh is importing **45,000 tonnes of additional diesel from India via the India–Bangladesh Friendship Pipeline and** acts as a "strategic energy buffer" for Dhaka.

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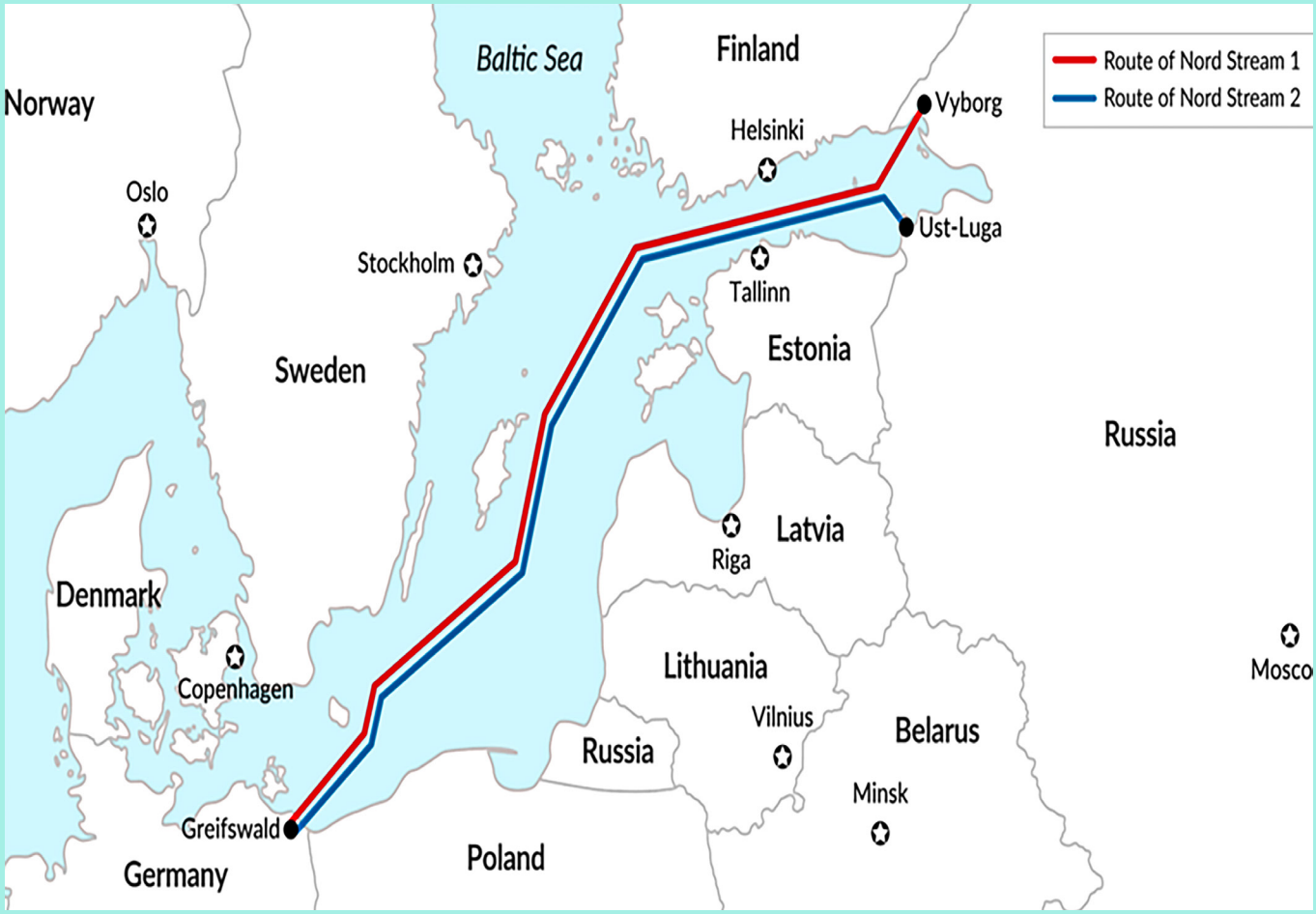
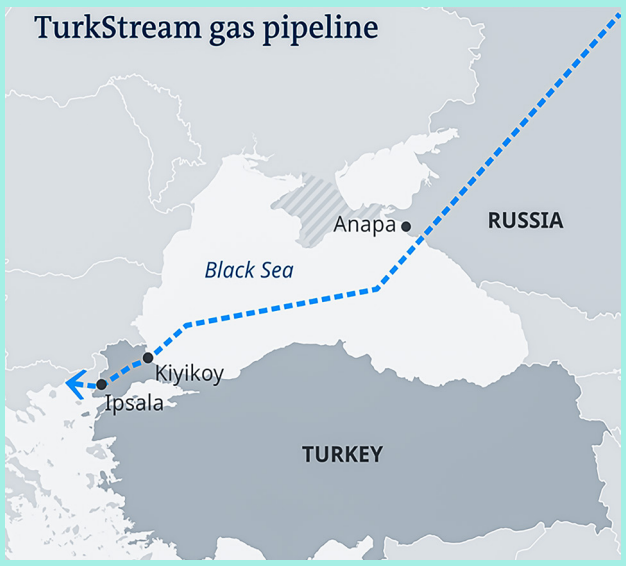
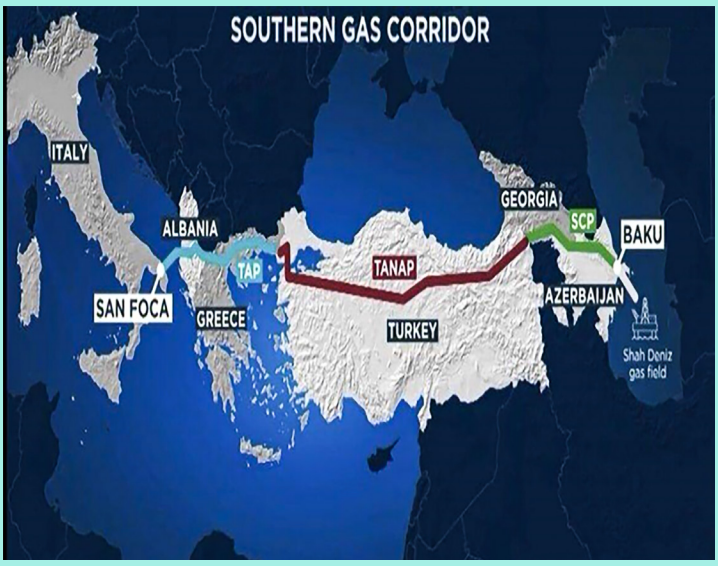
European Pipeline Network (Nord Stream, TurkStream,)

- **Nord Stream (I & II): Russia → Germany (under the Baltic Sea)**.
  - ♦ **Status:** Inactive/Damaged after 2022 sabotage.
- **TurkStream: Russia → Turkey (under the Black Sea).**
  - ♦ **Aim:** Gas supply to SE Europe, bypassing Ukraine.
- The Southern Gas Corridor (SGC): A chain of pipelines delivering natural gas from the Caspian Sea to Europe, aimed at reducing dependency on Russian energy.
  - ♦ It connects Shah Deniz 2 in Azerbaijan through Georgia (South Caucasus Pipeline), Turkey (TANAP), and Greece/ Albania (TAP) to Italy.







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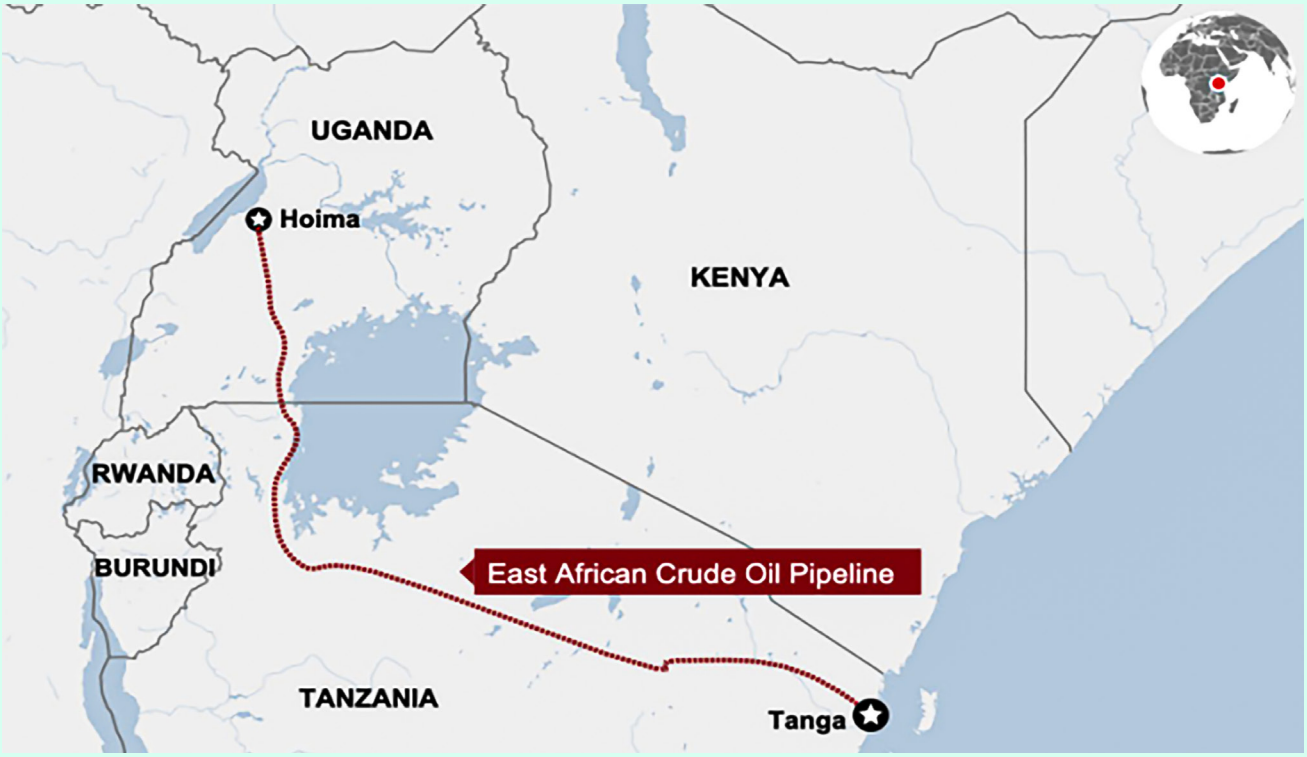
Baku-Tbilisi-Ceyhan (BTC) Pipeline

- **Baku-Tbilisi-Ceyhan (BTC):** Azerbaijan → Georgia → Turkey.
  - ♦ **Aim:** Caspian crude supply to the Mediterranean.
  - ♦ **India Part: ONGC Videsh** has a stake in the feeding fields.

East African Crude Oil Pipeline (EACOP)

- **Aim:** Transport crude oil from Uganda's landlocked fields to the global market→ **World's longest "Heated" pipeline** (due to waxy crude) → **India has no direct stake.**
- **Route:** Kabaale (Hoima, Uganda) → Tanzania → Port of Tanga (Indian Ocean).
- **Developed by:** Total Energies (operator), CNOOC, UNOC (Uganda), TPDC (Tanzania).
- **Construction has been** progressing since 2023–2024 after financing agreements, though the project faces environmental and climate concerns due to its route near the Lake Victoria basin.



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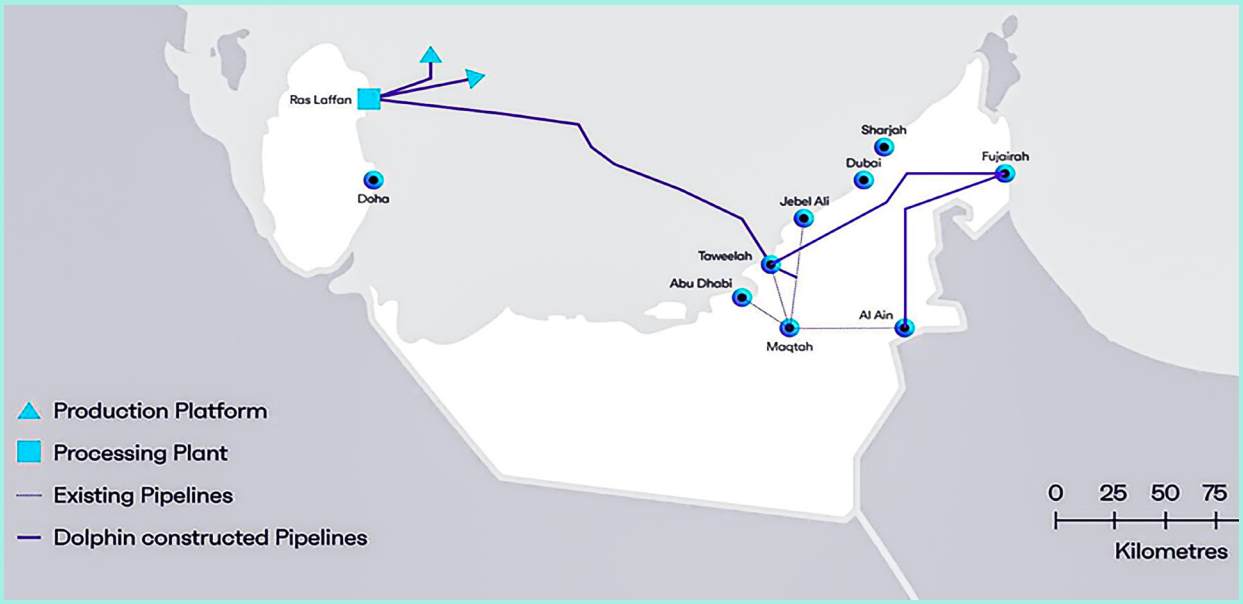
Energy Pipelines in West Asia

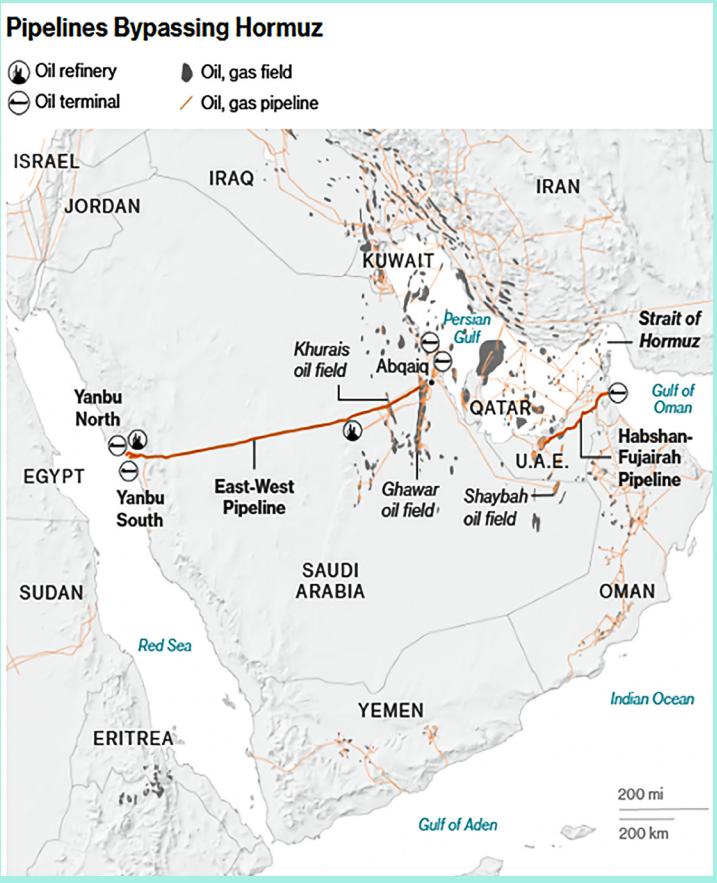
Natural Gas Pipelines:

- **Arab Gas Pipeline:**
  - ♦ **Route:** Egypt → Jordan → Syria → Lebanon.
  - ♦ **Role/Status:** Partially operational → affected by regional instability.
- **Dolphin Gas Pipeline**
  - ♦ **Route:** Qatar → UAE → Oman.
  - ♦ **Role/Status:** Operational → key Gulf regional gas network.

Crude Oil Pipeline:

- East-West Crude Oil Pipeline (Petroline):
  - ♦ **Route:** Abqaiq → Yanbu (Saudi Arabia).
    - ❑ **Role/Status:** Operational → strategic alternative export route.





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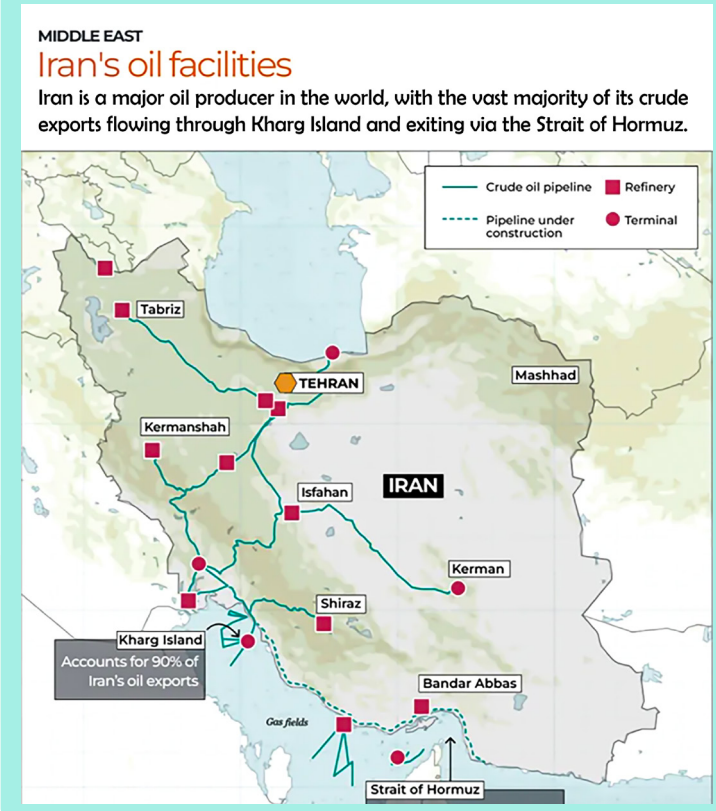

3.3. Important Straits

Strait of Hormuz

- A narrow, vital waterway situated between Iran to the north and the Musandam Peninsula of Oman (and the UAE) to the south → connects Persian Gulf to Gulf of Oman **(Arabian Sea)**.

- **Significance: World's most critical oil chokepoint → ~20 million barrels/day** pass through it (≈ **25% of global crude shipments**).
- **India:** About **~50-60% of India's crude oil imports through this route** → disruption could sharply raise oil prices impacting **CAD, inflation, and fuel prices**.

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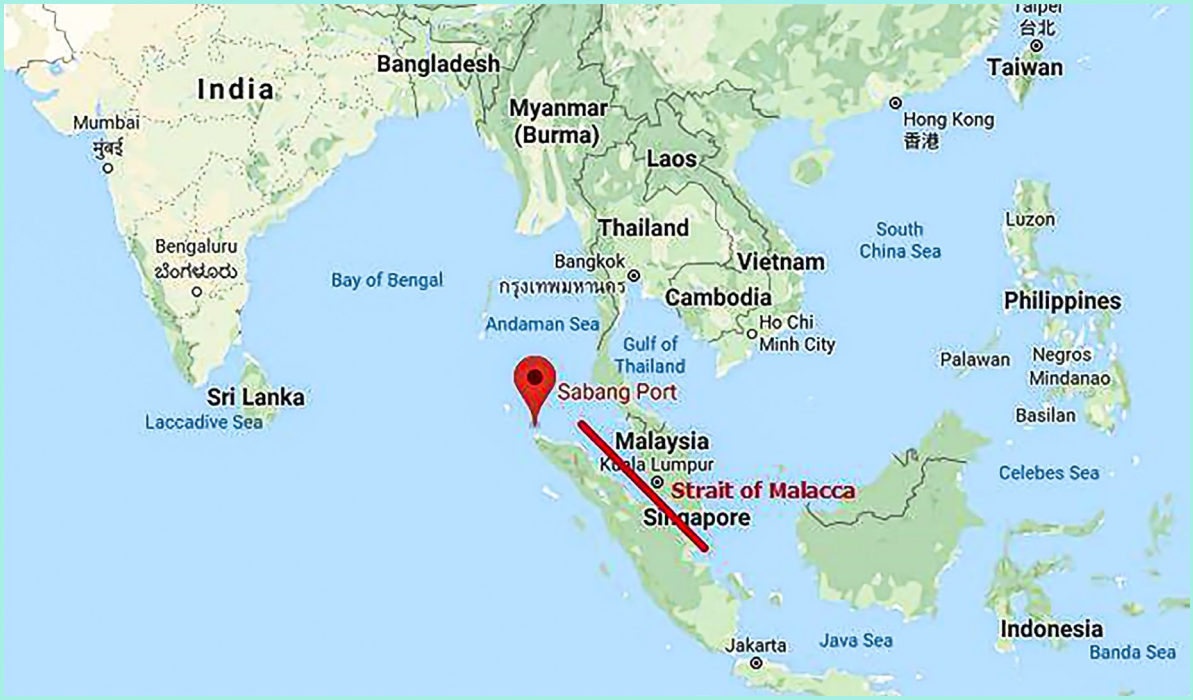
Bab-el-Mandeb

- Also called the **"Gate of Tears"** → between Yemen & Djibouti/Eritrea → links **the Red Sea to the Gulf of Aden.**

- **Strategic chokepoint for Suez–Asia trade.**
- **Recently, the** Indian Navy has maintained a permanent presence (**Op Sankalp**) to protect merchant vessels from drone and missile threats in this high-risk zone.

Strait of Malacca

- **Aim:** Shortest sea link between **the Indian Ocean** & **Pacific Ocean** → **connects West Asia, Africa and South Asia to East Asia** → vital for global energy security.



- **Route:** Andaman Sea → Strait of Malacca → Singapore Strait → South China Sea.
- **Bordered by Indonesia** (Sumatra), **Malaysia** (Peninsular) and **Singapore**.
- The extreme southern part of **Thailand** is also adjacent to the northern entrance of the strait.
- **India's Part: Strategic User & Security Provider. Over 55% of India's maritime** trade passes ***through the South China Sea and Malacca Straits.***"

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4 International Groupings

4.1. Political and Emerging Groupings

UPSC Prelims PYQs

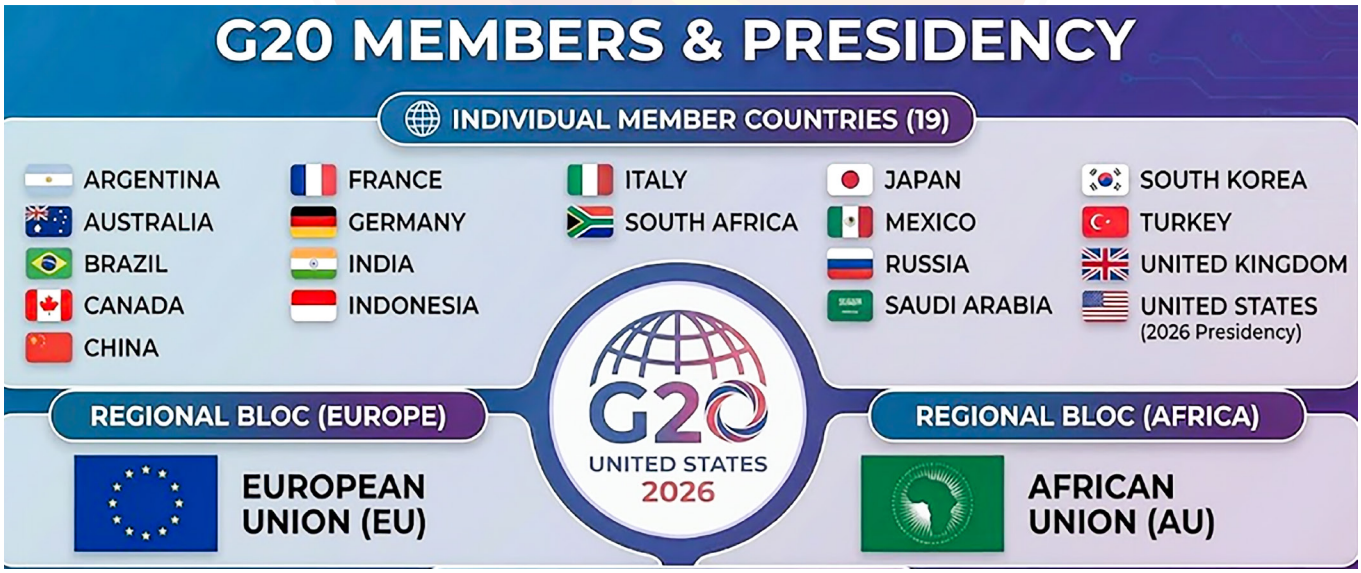
1. Consider the following statements with regard to BRICS: **(2024)**
I. The 16th BRICS Summit was held under the Chairship of Russia in Kazan.
II. Indonesia has become a full member of BRICS.
III. The theme of the 16th BRICS Summit was "Strengthening Multiculturalism for Just Global Development and Security".
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
(a) I and II (b) II and III (c) I and III (d) I only

2. With reference to the "G20 Common Framework", consider the following statements: **(2022)**
1. It is an initiative endorsed by the G20 together with the Paris Club.
2. It is an initiative to support Low Income Countries with unsustainable debt.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
(a) 1 only (b) 2 only (c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

3. In which one of the following groups are all four countries members of the G20? **(2020)**
(a) Argentina, Mexico, South Africa and Turkey
(b) Australia, Canada, Malaysia and New Zealand
(c) Brazil, Iran, Saudi Arabia and Vietnam
(d) Indonesia, Japan, Singapore and South Korea

Answer: 1. (a), 2. (c), 3. (a)

G20 (Group of Twenty) and G7



Overview:

- Founded in 1999 (Post-Asian Financial Crisis) → Initial forum for Finance Ministers & Central Bank Governors.
- Upgraded to Heads of State/Government → Designated "premier forum for international economic cooperation."
- Annual Summit (since 2008) → Guided by a rotating Presidency → No formal HQ or secretariat.
- Members account for **around 85% of the world's GDP, 75% of** total international trade, and more than **two-thirds of the global population.**
- **G20 Troika for 2026 Presidency:** South Africa (2025), the United States (2026), and the United Kingdom (2027).

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Organizational Structure

- **Agenda Setting:** Managed by current Presidency + **Troika** (Previous, Current, & Incoming Presidencies).
- **Execution:** Led by Sherpas (Personal emissaries of Leaders) → Oversee year-round negotiations & coordinate substantive work.
- **Operational Tracks:** Divided into two main paths:
  - ♦ Finance Track + Sherpa Track → Working Groups: Thematically aligned within the two tracks → Comprise member ministries, guest nations, & international organizations.
- A multi-year mandate ensures agenda continuity based on past agreed goals and current economic developments.

Highlights of the G20 Summit 2025 (Johannesburg)—1st African Nation to Host G20

- Scale up **climate adaptation support** and technical assistance for vulnerable countries.
- Strengthen **debt sustainability frameworks** and creditor coordination.
- Boost **food security efforts** and support smallholders and supply chains.
- Support **digital public infrastructure** and AI governance dialogues.
- Advance industrialisation and value chain development for critical minerals.
- **Spirit of Ubuntu:** Emphasizes shared global responsibility & interconnectedness → Calls for stronger multilateral cooperation to address conflicts + inequality + humanitarian suffering.
- Launched **Cost of Capital Commission** (to reform credit ratings & reduce "African risk premium") → Highlighted Africa's $1.8 trillion debt burden (spending more on debt interest than public services).
- **Mission 300:** Initiative by World Bank + African Development Bank → Provide electricity to 300 million people in Sub-Saharan Africa by 2030 → Received strong support and backing from G20 leaders
- **Nelson Mandela Bay Target:** Reduce youth NEET (Not in Employment, Education, or Training) rate by 5% by 2030 and achieve 25% gender parity in labor force participation by 2030.

G7 → Founded in 1975, it is an informal bloc of seven industrialized democracies (Canada, France, Germany, Italy, Japan, the UK, and the US), with the EU participating annually.

- Russia's membership (1998–2014) briefly formed the G8 ➔ it was suspended after the annexation of Crimea, reverting the group to the G7.
- **Operations & Agenda:** Lacking a permanent structure, a rotating Presidency sets the agenda for annual summits focusing on global economic governance, security, and energy policy.

Paris Club → Informal group of creditor governments

- **Function:** Multilateral debt rescheduling → debt reduction → managing arrears
- **Target:** Developing countries owing debt to creditor governments.
- The Paris Club and G20 collaborate through the "Common Framework for Debt Treatments" (established 2020) to restructure bilateral debt for low-income countries.

BRICS / BRICS+

Overview:

- **11** major emerging markets & developing countries → Platform for global/regional consultation + political & economic governance.
- **Member Countries (11):** Brazil + China + Egypt + Ethiopia + India + Indonesia (latest member) + Iran + Russia + Saudi Arabia + South Africa + UAE.
- **Partner Countries (10) 2025:** Belarus + Bolivia + Cuba + Kazakhstan + Malaysia + Nigeria + Thailand + Uganda + Uzbekistan + Vietnam.
- **Global Share:** ~50% population + 40% GDP + 26% global trade share.
- India will chair **BRICS (18th) for the fourth time in 2026**, having previously held the chair in **2012, 2016, and 2021.**
- **BRICS 2026: India** → Theme is "Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation, and Sustainability."
- **3 Core Pillars:** Political & Security + Economy & Finance + Cultural & People-to-People Exchanges

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Evolution Timeline

- **2006:** BRIC formalised → 1st Foreign Ministers' Meeting (sidelines of UNGA, NY).
- **2009:** 1st BRIC Summit (Yekaterinburg, Russia).
- **2010–2011:** Agreement to include South Africa (2010) → Attends 3rd Summit in Sanya (2011) → Evolves into BRICS.
- **Jan 2024:** 5 new members join → Egypt + Ethiopia + Iran + Saudi Arabia + UAE.
- **Jan 2025:** Indonesia joined with 10 new partner countries.

Major BRICS Initiatives

- **Contingent Reserve Arrangement (CRA):** Signed 15 July 2014 (Fortaleza, Brazil) → Agreement among BRICS central banks + Mutual support during sudden currency crisis.
- **New Development Bank (NDB):** Signed 15 July 2014 → Operations started 21 July 2015 → Funding for founding members + emerging/developing economies → Authorised Capital: USD 100 Billion
  - **Eligibility:** Open to all UN members → Borrowing + Non-borrowing members.
  - **Founding Members** (Jul 2015): Brazil + Russia + India + China + South Africa
  - **New Members:** Bangladesh (Sep 2021) + UAE (Oct 2021) + Egypt (Feb 2023) + Algeria (May 2025).
  - **HQ: Shanghai, China**.

Voice of Global South Summit (VOGSS)

Overview:

- Established in 2023 → **Organiser:** India
- **Purpose:** Foster development + exchange ideas + unite on socio-economic challenges.
- **Global South:** Socio-economically & politically disadvantaged nations → Primarily Africa + Latin America + developing Asia.

3rd Voice of Global South Summit 2024 (VOGSS)

- **Theme:** An Empowered Global South for a Sustainable Future.
- **Key Outcomes:**
  - **Trade Promotion:** $2.5M fund by India (to boost trade) + $1M fund (training officials in trade negotiations/policy).
  - **Health & Agriculture:** Sharing cheap generic medicines + Technology sharing in Natural Farming.
  - **DAKSHIN Centre:** Global South Centre of Excellence → Focus on skilling + knowledge sharing.
  - **Social Impact Fund:** $25M (focused on DPI - Digital Public Infrastructure).

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4.2. Economic, Trade Groupings

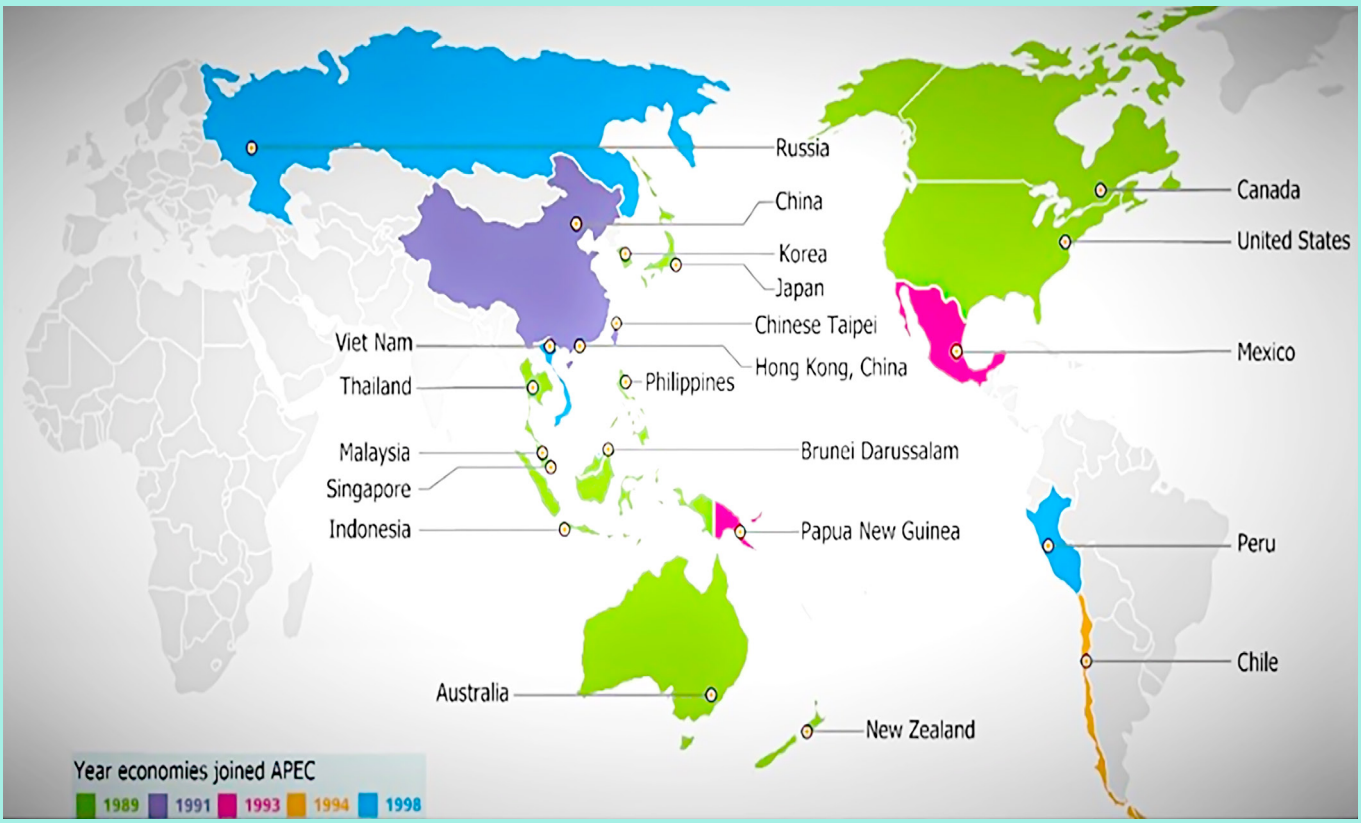
UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. The term 'Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership' often appears in the news in the context of the affairs of a group of countries known as: **(2016)**

(a) G20
(b) ASEAN
(c) SCO
(d) SAARC

Answer: 1. (b)

APEC (Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation)



Overview:

- **Established:** 1989 → Regional economic forum → Aim to leverage Asia-Pacific interdependence → Create prosperity via regional economic integration.
- **Focus & Terminology:** Trade & economic issues → members are explicitly termed "economies" (not countries).
- **Operational Model:** Non-binding commitments → decisions by consensus → actions undertaken on a voluntary basis.
- **Membership Criterion:** Must be an independent economic entity → does not require being a sovereign state.
- **Current Members (21 Economies):**
  - **Americas:** Canada + Chile + Mexico + Peru + United States.
  - **Asia:** Brunei + China + Hong Kong + Indonesia + Japan + Malaysia + Philippines + Singapore + South Korea + Taiwan + Thailand + Vietnam.
  - **Oceania & Eurasia:** Australia + New Zealand + Papua New Guinea + Russia.
- India is not a member of APEC.
- **APEC Host Economies:** 2024 (Peru) → 2025 (Korea) → 2026 (China) → 2027 (Vietnam) → 2028→ 2029 (To Be Confirmed) → 2030 (Singapore).

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RCEP (Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership)

Overview:

- Negotiations launched in Nov 2012 → Signed in 2020 and enforced in 2022.
- **Scale:** World's largest trading bloc → Covers ~30% of global population & ~28-30% of global GDP & 28-29% of global trade.
- **Global Context:** Represents the "eastern flank" of emerging comprehensive FTAs (alongside TPP on the west and TTIP in the centre).

Membership	• **15 Members:** 10 ASEAN Nations + 5 FTA Partners (China, Japan, South Korea, Australia, New Zealand). • **India's Status:** India withdrew from negotiations → Driven by concerns over the protection of domestic industries
Structure	• **Apex Body:** RCEP Trade Negotiating Committee (TNC) → Replaced earlier **(Senior Economic Officials Meeting)** SEOM process in 2013. • **Guiding Principles:** Broader/deeper engagement than existing FTAs + Facilitate global/regional supply chains + Acknowledge diverse development levels among members. • Institutional Framework: 7 Working Groups + 4 Sub-Working Groups reporting to the TNC. ♦ Core Working Groups: Trade in Goods (WGTIG) + Trade in Services (WGTIS) + Investment (WGI). ♦ Later Additions (2014): Competition + Intellectual Property + Economic & Technical Cooperation (ECOTECH) + Legal & Institutional Issues. ♦ Sub-Groups (under WGTIG): Rules of Origin (ROO) + Customs Procedures & Trade Facilitation (CPTF) + SPS (Sanitary/Phytosanitary) + STRACAP (Standards/Technical Regulations).

IPEF (Indo-Pacific Economic Framework)

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Overview

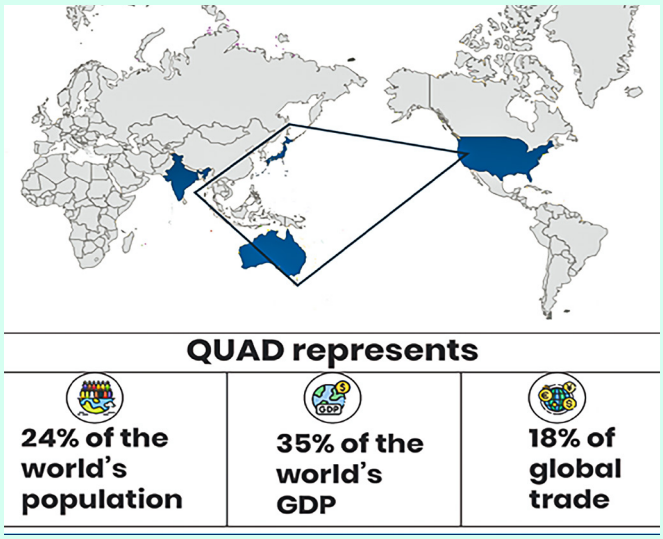
- **Launched:** 2022 by the US & Indo-Pacific partners.
- **Scale:** 14 Members → 40% Global GDP | 28% Global Trade.
- **Objective:** Enhance regional economic resilience, sustainability, and growth.
- **Nature:** Not a Free Trade Agreement (FTA) → Offers flexible, opt-in negotiations.
- **14 Member Nations:** Australia, Brunei, Fiji, India, Indonesia, Japan, South Korea, Malaysia, New Zealand, Philippines, Singapore, Thailand, Vietnam and USA.
- **The 4 Negotiation Pillars**
  - **Trade (Pillar I):** Fair & resilient trade practices.
  - **Supply Chain Resilience (Pillar II):** Enhancing resilience and security.
  - **Clean Economy (Pillar III):** Clean energy, decarbonization & infrastructure.
  - **Fair Economy (Pillar IV):** Taxation & anti-corruption.
- India formally decided to opt out of the trade pillar of the IPEF in September 2022.

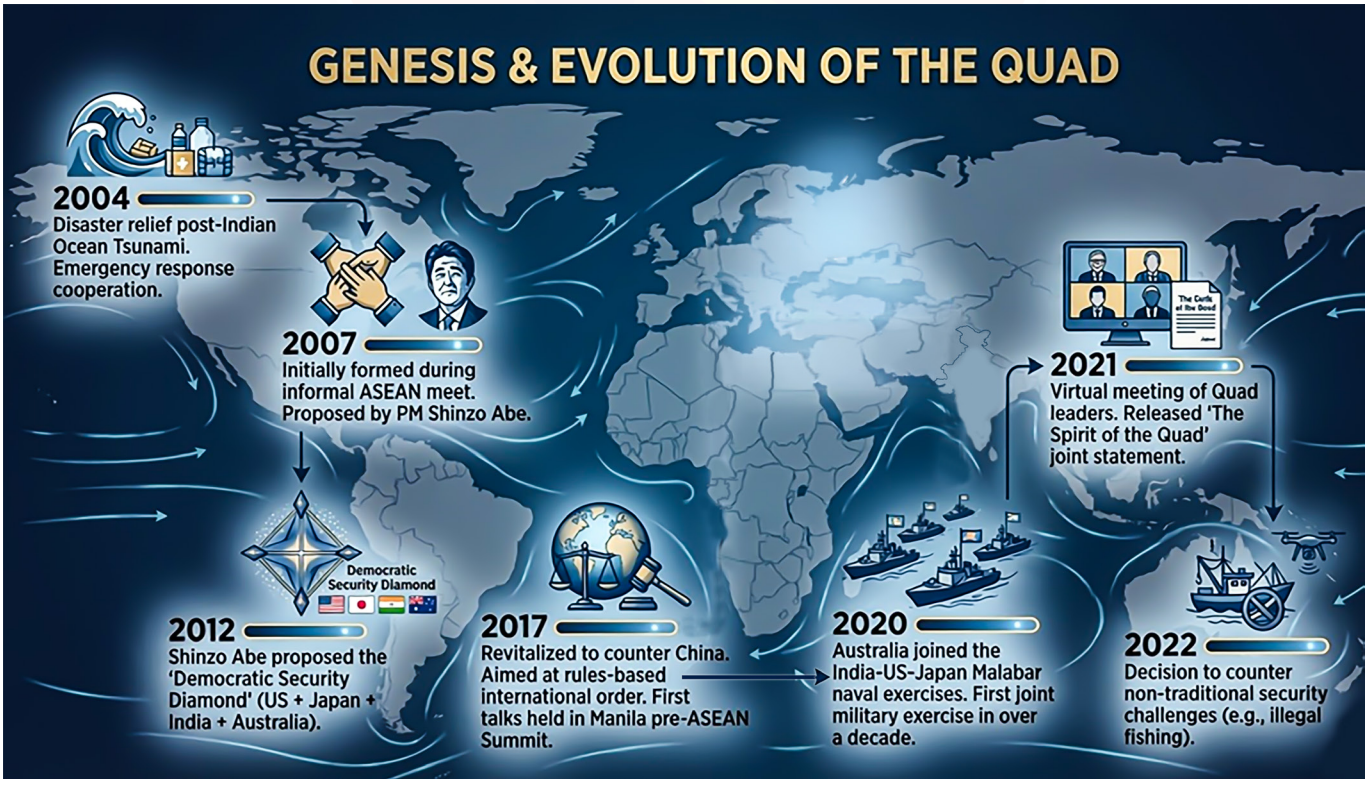
4.3. Strategic & Security

QUAD (Quadrilateral Security Dialogue)

Overview:

- **Nature:** Strategic forum (Not a military alliance) → Open to nations with shared values.
- **Members:** USA + Japan + India + Australia
- **HQ:** None (No permanent base).
- **Aim:** Ensure a Free and Open Indo-Pacific → Regional Security + Economic Cooperation.
- **Core Focus:** Countering China's expanding influence, promoting democracy, human rights, rule of law, maritime security, infrastructure, and supply chain resilience.
- **Joint Exercise:** MALABAR (Naval drill).
- **Wilmington Declaration (2024):** Outcome of the QUAD Summit (USA) ➔ accompanied by the launch of the **QUAD Critical Minerals Initiative**.
  - **Initiative Focus:** Secure & diversify global supply chains ➔ promote e-waste recovery and critical mineral reprocessing.





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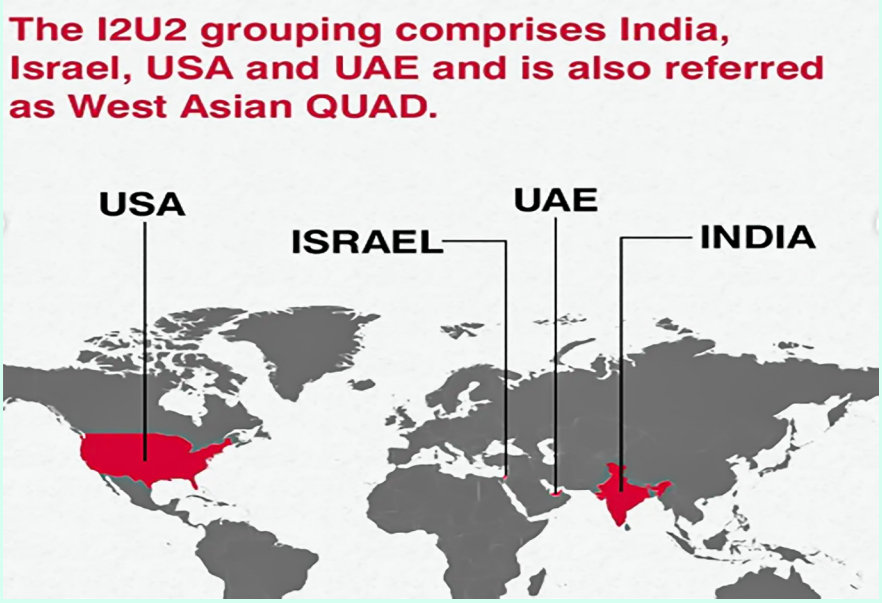
Key QUAD Initiatives

- **Education:** QUAD Fellowship → For STEM
- **Health:** Quad Cancer Moonshot + Quad Vaccine Partnership + Covid-19 Global Action Plan + Vaccine Experts Group.
- **Cybersecurity:** Quad Senior Cyber Group → Shared cyber standards.
- **Space:** Cooperation via sharing satellite data.
- **Environment: Q-CHAMP** (Quad Climate Change Adaptation and Mitigation Package) + Quad Climate Working Group → Adaptation & capacity building in Indo-Pacific.
- **Tech:** Focus on critical/emerging tech for digital economies.

I2U2 (West Asian Quad/ Middle East Quad / New Quad)

Overview

- **Establishment:** Conceptualized in 2021 (originally named the International Forum for Economic Cooperation).



- **HQ:** None.
- **Aim:** Tackle global challenges via joint investments & private sector mobilization (Focus: Infrastructure & low-carbon development).
- **Milestone:** First virtual Leaders' Summit held in 2022.
- **7 Focus Areas:** Water + Energy + Transportation + Space + Health + Food Security + Technology (often implicitly grouped with Space/Infrastructure).

Key Initiatives

- **Food Security:** The UAE's $2 billion investment in a Food Park project in India.
- **Clean Energy:** A 300 MW hybrid (wind/solar) renewable energy project in Gujarat, India, backed by the I2U2.

AUKUS (The "Indo-Pacific Security Pact")

Overview:

- **Established in** 2021 → **Members:** Australia + UK + USA (India is NOT a member); **HQ:** None
- **Aim:** Maintain a "free & open Indo-Pacific" → Enhanced trilateral defense/security cooperation.
- **Core Focus:** Advanced technology sharing in the Indo-Pacific.
- The Two Pillars of AUKUS:
  - **Pillar 1:** Australia acquiring a conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarine fleet.
  - **Pillar 2:** Cooperation in advanced military capabilities.

The Geelong Treaty

- **Signatories:** Australia + UK (recent agreement), also known as Nuclear-Powered Submarine Partnership & Collaboration Treaty.
- **Goal:** Security & stability in the Indo-Pacific & Euro-Atlantic regions.
- **Key Objectives:** Robust trilateral supply chains.
  - Collaboration on the design, construction, maintenance & disposal of SSN-AUKUS submarines.
- **Compliance:** Aligns with AUKUS Naval Nuclear Propulsion Agreement (ANNPA) + international nuclear non-proliferation rules.

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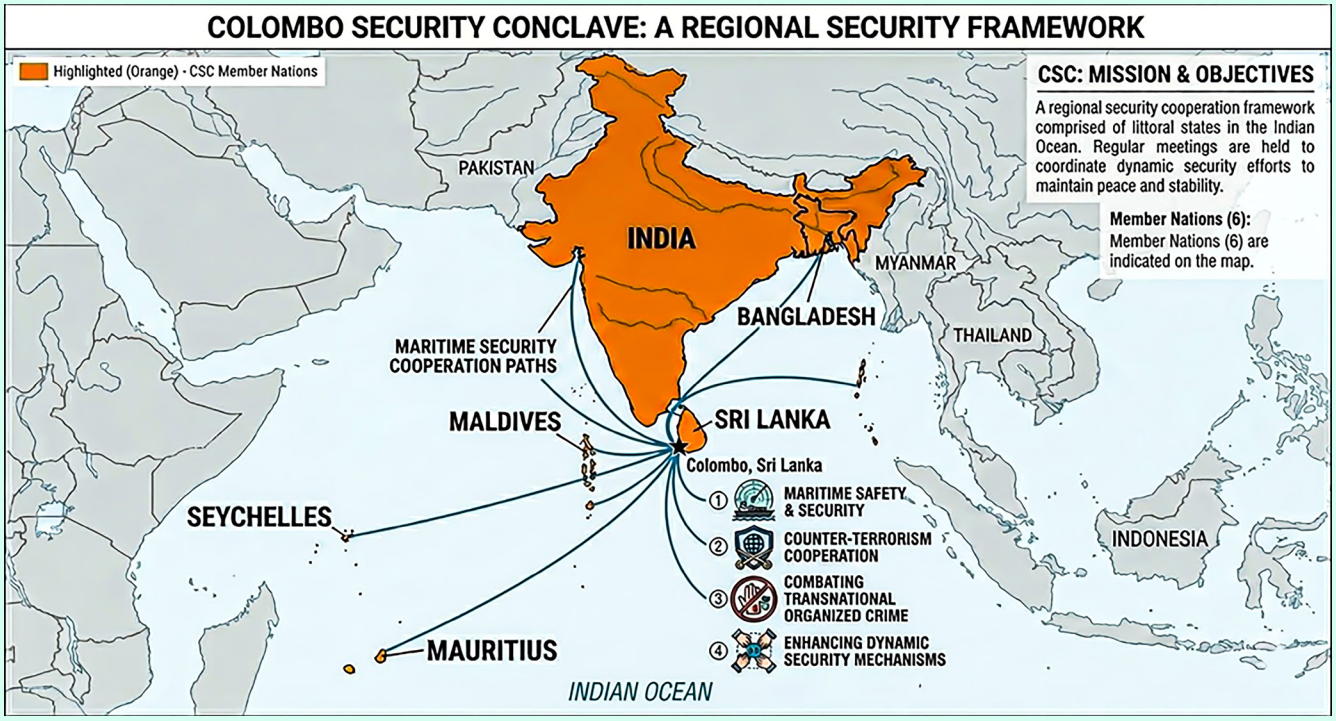
Colombo Security Conclave

Overview:

- **Established in** 2011 → Originally started as Trilateral Maritime Security Cooperation between NSAs/Deputy NSAs of India, Sri Lanka, and the Maldives; has a permanent HQ in Colombo, Sri Lanka.
- **Primary Aim:** Promote a Safe, Secure, and Stable Indian Ocean + Tackle Traditional, Non-Traditional, and Hybrid Threats.
- **Strategic Significance for India:** Solidifies India's role as a "Net Security Provider" in the region.
  - ♦ Acts as a counter to China's "String of Pearls" strategy.
  - ♦ Implements India's SAGAR (Security and Growth for All in the Region) vision.
- **Recent Developments:** 7th NSA Meeting (Nov 2025): → Held in New Delhi → Focus: Reviewed the roadmap for ongoing and future cooperation.



SCO (Shanghai Cooperation Organisation)

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Overview:

- **Established:** 15 June 2001 (Shanghai).
- **Members:** 10 Permanent (China + Russia + Kazakhstan + Kyrgyzstan + Tajikistan + Uzbekistan + India (Joined 2017) + Pakistan (Joined 2017) + Iran (Joined 2023) + Belarus **(Joined 2024).**
  - **SCO Partners:** Mongolia, Afghanistan, Azerbaijan, Armenia, Cambodia, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Turkey, Egypt, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, Maldives, Myanmar, UAE, Bahrain and Laos.
- **Founders:** China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan.
- **Permanent Secretariat:** Beijing, China → **Official Languages:** Russian & Chinese.
- **Scale:** Represents ~40-42% Global Population | ~25-26% Global GDP.
- **Permanent Bodies:** Secretariat (Beijing, China) + RATS (Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure) (Executive Committee in Tashkent, Uzbekistan).
- **Framework:** 29 charter bodies + over 40 working mechanisms.
- **Key Treaties/Agreements:**
  - SCO Charter (2002)
  - Treaty on Long-Term Good-Neighbourliness, Friendship and Cooperation (2007)
- **Non-Governmental Bodies:** SCO Business Council + Interbank Consortium + Youth Council + SCO Forum.
- **Partnerships:** Cooperates with UN, Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS), Collective Security Treaty Organization (CSTO), ASEAN, Economic Cooperation Organization (ECO), Conference on Interaction and Confidence-Building Measures in Asia (CICA), Eurasian Economic Union / Commission (EAEU / EEC), League of Arab States (LAS), International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC).
- **Goals:** Strengthen mutual trust & good-neighborliness + Ensure regional peace, security & stability + Address new challenges & threats jointly. + Promote economic, social & cultural growth.

25th SCO Summit (2025, Tianjin, China)

- **Tianjin Declaration:** Explicitly condemned the April 2025 Pahalgam terror attack in India.
- Approved "Development Strategy 2035" → Reduce trade barriers + Boost Regional Value Chains.
- **China** Proposed SCO Development Bank → Focus on infrastructure & sustainable growth.
- **Security Infrastructure:** 4 New Specialized Centres created to tackle → Security Threats, Organized Crime, Cybersecurity, and Narcotics.
- **India's** SCO Vision: Security + Connectivity + Opportunity → Emphasized the theme: *"One Earth, One Family, One Future."*
- **Future Summits:** 2026 → Kyrgyzstan, Bishkek ; 2027 → Pakistan, Islamabad.

East Asia Summit

Overview:

- **Established:** 2005 (ASEAN-led initiative).
- **First Summit:** Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia (Dec 14, 2005).
- **Members:** 18 Countries → 11 ASEAN + 8 Dialogue Partners.
- **Scale:** Represents 53% of Global Population | 60% of Global GDP.
- ASEAN is India's **fourth largest trading** partner.

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20th East Asia Summit (2025: Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia)

- **Kuala Lumpur Declaration on Peace and Stability** (20th Anniversary):
  - Reaffirmed EAS as the premier leaders-led forum.
  - **Core Focus:** ASEAN Centrality and UN Charter principles.
- **Membership Expansion: Timor-Leste participated as a full member** for the first time (post-ASEAN accession in late 2025).
- **Disaster Resilience:**
  - Adopted the "Statement on Localization of Anticipatory Action".
  - Goal: Local-level disaster preparedness → Shift from "Response" to "Prevention."
- **Strategic Roadmap:** EAS Plan of Action (2024–2028).
  - **Focus:** Implementing the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific.

North Atlantic Treaty Organisation (NATO)

- **Establishment year:** April 4, 1949.
- **Members:** 32 (Sweden 2024, Finland 2023)
- **Founding members:** (12) Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom, and the United States.
- **EU members** that are **not a part:** Austria, Cyprus, Ireland and Malta.
- **Aim:** Political + military alliance after World War II by 12 countries from Europe and North America
- **HQ:** Brussels, Belgium.
- **Genesis:** Washington Treaty → **Article 5 of the NATO** → Collective defence.
- **India's Status: India is NOT a member** and has consistently declined "NATO Plus" offers to maintain its strategic autonomy.

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Normandy Format

- **Established:** June 6, 2014 → Formed on the sidelines of the 70th anniversary of D-Day in Normandy, France.
- **Members:** France + Germany + Russia + Ukraine.
- **Nature:** Informal diplomatic grouping → Aimed at resolving the conflict in Eastern Ukraine.
- **Key Distinction:** Excluded the USA and UK → Positioned France and Germany as the primary European mediators.
- **Trilateral Contact Group (TCG):** Russia + Ukraine + OSCE → Acted as the operational body negotiating the peace plans under the political guidance of the Normandy Format.

The OSCE Minsk Group (Nagorno-Karabakh)

- **Minsk Group Established in** 1992 by the OSCE (Organization for Security and Cooperation in Europe).
- **Purpose:** Encourage a peaceful, negotiated resolution to the conflict between Armenia and Azerbaijan over the Nagorno-Karabakh region.
- **The Co-Chairs:** Known as the "Triple Co-Chairmanship" → France + Russia + USA.
- **Current Status: Dissolved** → Following a joint appeal by Armenia and Azerbaijan (brokered by the US), the OSCE officially closed the Minsk Process and its related structures on **December 1, 2025**.

Arctic Council

- **8 Members:**
  - Canada,
  - Denmark (including Greenland and the Faroe Islands),
  - Finland,
  - Iceland,
  - Norway,
  - Russia,
  - Sweden, and
  - The United States.
- Focus → on environment & sustainable development → explicitly excludes military/security matters.
- Formed by the 1996 Ottawa Declaration.

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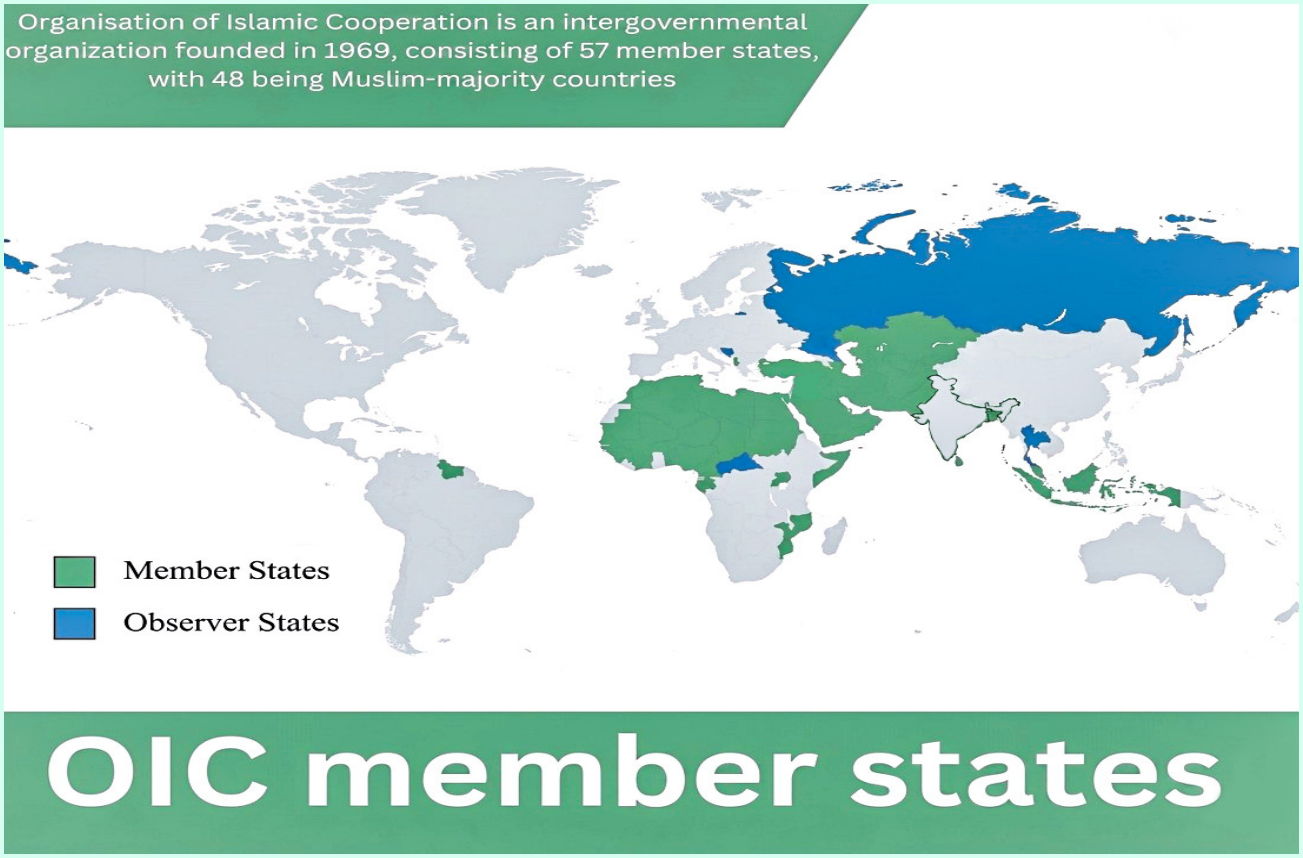
Five Eyes Alliance

- **Origins (WWII):** UK + USA → Shared intelligence after breaking German & Japanese codes.
  - ♦ Later joined by **Canada, Australia, and New Zealand**.
- **2010:** Alliance formally acknowledged.
- **Founding Treaty:** The **UKUSA Agreement** (Multilateral agreement for cooperation in **Signals Intelligence (SIGINT)**).
- **Nature:** It is an **intelligence-sharing** alliance, not a military one like NATO.

Organisation of Islamic Cooperation (OIC)



- **Overview:** Founded on September 25, 1969 (Rabat Summit, Morocco).
  - ♦ The 2nd largest intergovernmental organisation in the world (after the UN).
  - ♦ **Membership:** 57 states across 4 continents.
    - ❑ Following a 13-year suspension since August 2012, the OIC reinstated Syria's membership on March 7, 2025
  - ♦ **Core Aim:** Acts as the collective voice of the Muslim world → Safeguards interests + promotes international peace & harmony.
  - ♦ **Global Role:** Combats discrimination against Muslims + maintains consultative/cooperative relations with the UN.
- **Structure:**
  - ♦ **Main Organs:** The Islamic Summit
    - ❑ Council of Foreign Ministers (CFM)
    - ❑ General Secretariat
  - ♦ **Committees:** Al-Quds Committee + 3 Permanent Committees (Science & Tech | Economy & Trade | Information & Culture).
  - ♦ **Specialized Organs:** Islamic Development Bank + Islamic Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization.
- **Establishment & Evolution:**
  - ♦ **Secretariat:** Established in 1970 → Permanent **HQ in Jeddah.**
  - ♦ **Leadership:** Hissein Brahim Taha is the 12th Secretary General (since Nov 2021).
  - ♦ Charter: 1st Charter adopted in 1972 → Present Charter adopted in **March 2008 (Dakar Summit)** to meet 21st-century requirements.

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Coalition of the Willing

- **Origin:** Announced March 2, 2025 (London Summit) → also known as Reassurance Force.
- **HQ:** Fort Mont-Valérien (Paris) → Co-led by UK & France, with a coordination cell planned for Kyiv.
- **Objective:** Provide robust, post-war security guarantees for Ukraine outside the formal NATO framework to ensure a lasting ceasefire/peace deal.
- Over 30 European, Commonwealth, and other nations, including Japan, are part of it.

E3 Countries

- **Origin:** Established in 2003 → Triggered by the fallout of the Iraq War & emerging concerns over Iran's nuclear program (post-2002 revelations).
- **Members:** France + Germany + United Kingdom.
- **An** informal, "minilateral" diplomatic grouping.
- **Objective:** Present a unified European position in nuclear negotiations with Iran.
- **Contribution:** Initiated diplomacy → evolved into **P5+1 → led to JCPOA (Iran Nuclear Deal)** in 2015.

Weimer Triangle

- **Established:** August 29, 1991, in Weimar, Germany.
- **Members:** France, Germany, and Poland.
- **Nature:** An informal, non-institutionalised regional grouping (no permanent secretariat or HQ).
- **Aim:** To support Poland's transition from communism and facilitate its integration into NATO (1999) and the EU (2004) by leveraging the Franco-German reconciliation model.
- **Current Focus:** The format has been revived to address modern security challenges in Europe, particularly focusing on strengthening defense cooperation and developing a strong European pillar within NATO.

- For the **first time ever, India's External Affairs Minister p**articipated as a guest in a Weimar Triangle meeting in Paris.

Pax Silica

- This is a high-level US-led strategic coalition often described as the Technological Quad.
- India formally joined the coalition in February 2026 during the AI Impact Summit in New Delhi.
- Aim to control everything from critical minerals (lithium, cobalt) to chip fabrication (fabs) and AI data centers and reduce weaponized dependency on Chinese supply chains.

4.4. Regional and Sub-Regional Groupings

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following statements regarding BIMSTEC: **(2025)**

I. The BIMSTEC had seven members as of January 2025.
II. It was established through the Dhaka Declaration of 1999.
III. Nepal is a founding member of BIMSTEC.
IV. The tourism sector of BIMSTEC is led by India.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) I and II
(b) II and III
(c) I and IV
(d) I only

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2. Consider the following countries: **(2022)**
1. Armenia
2. Azerbaijan
3. Croatia
4. Romania
5. Uzbekistan

Which of the above are members of the Organization of Turkic States?
(a) 1, 2 and 4 (b) 1 and 3 (c) 2 and 5 (d) 3, 4 and 5

3. Consider the following countries: **(2018)**
1. Australia
2. Canada
3. China
4. India
5. Japan
6. USA

Which of the above are among the 'free trade partners' of ASEAN?
(a) 1, 2, 4 and 5 (b) 3, 4, 5 and 6
(c) 1, 3, 4 and 5 (d) 2, 3, 4 and 6

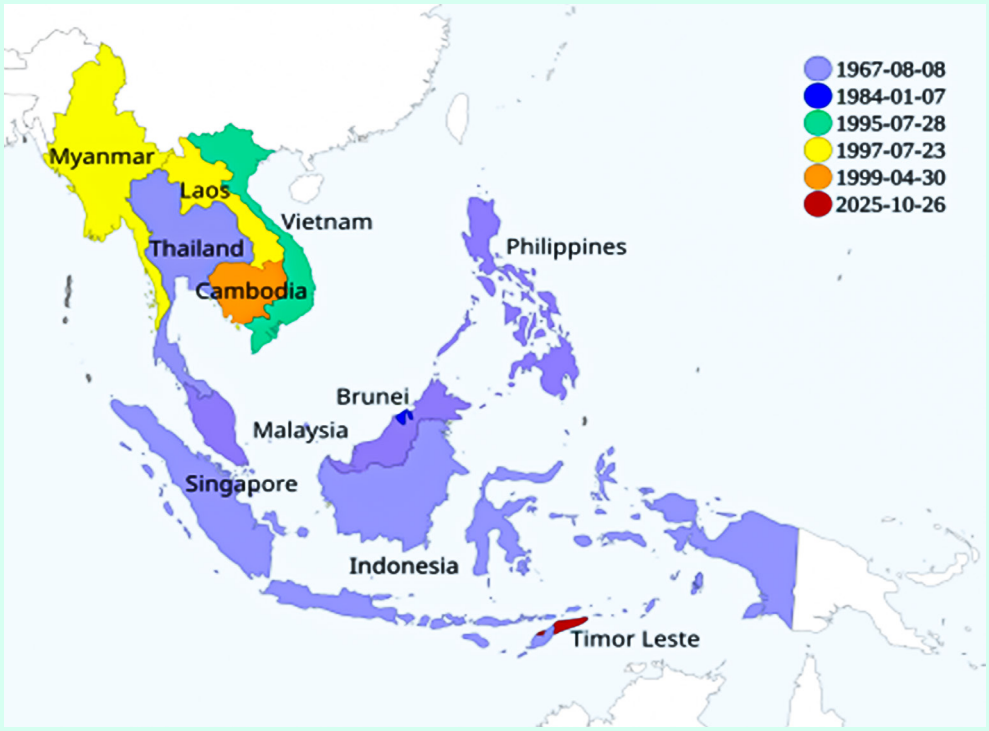
4. Which of the following is NOT a member of the Gulf Cooperation Council? **(2016)**
(a) Iran (b) Saudi Arabia (c) Oman (d) Kuwait

5. India is a member of which among the following? **(2015)**
1. Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation
2. Association of South-East Asian Nations
3. East Asia Summit

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:
(a) 1 and 2 only (b) 3 only (c) 1, 2 and 3 (d) None of them

Answer: 1.(d), 2.(c), 3. (c), 4.(a), 5.(b)

Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN)



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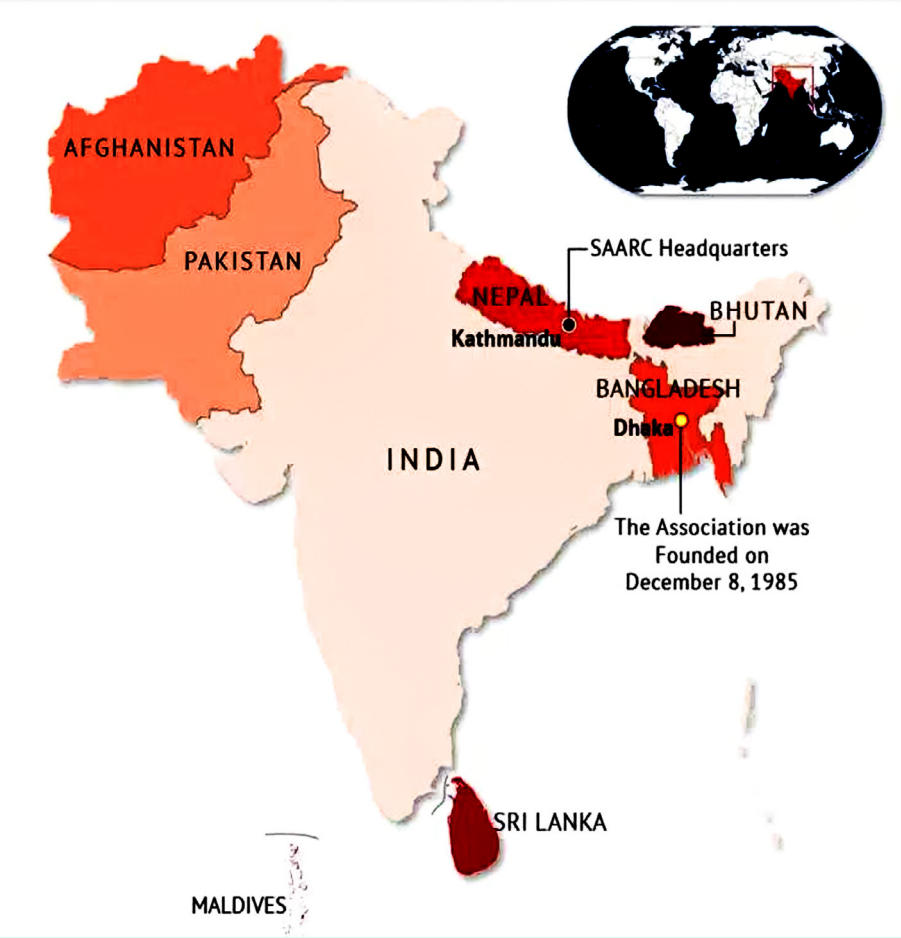
Establishment year: 1967 (Bangkok Declaration)

- **Members:** 11
- India is not a member but a full dialogue partner of ASEAN.
- **Aim:** Economic growth, social progress, cultural development, and regional peace/stability
- **HQ:** Jakarta, Indonesia.

22nd ASEAN-India Summit (Kuala Lumpur).
Theme: Inclusivity and Sustainability
Outcomes:

- Reaffirmed India's Act East Policy and India's vision for the Indo-Pacific (SAGAR).
- **Timor-Leste:** Welcomed as the 11th member state of ASEAN.
- **2026 -** Year of Maritime Cooperation
- AITIGA (ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement) to address India's trade deficit and non-tariff barriers.
- 1st ASEAN-India Track 1 Cyber Policy Dialogue and deepening DPI.

SAARC (South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation)



- Establishment year: 8th December 1985 (Dhaka Charter)
- **Members:** 8
  - **Observers: 9** (Australia, China, the European Union, Iran, Japan, the Republic of Korea (South Korea), Mauritius, Myanmar, and the United States)
- **Aim:** Welfare of South Asians, collective self-reliance, and mutual trust.
- **HQ:** Kathmandu, Nepal.
- **Initiatives:** SAFTA (Free Trade Agreement); SATIS (Trade in Services); SDF (SAARC Development Fund).
  - Focus points: 21% of the world's population, 3% of the world's area and 3.8% of the world economy.
    - ❑ All member countries are equal in status, regardless of their size or power.
    - ❑ Decisions are taken jointly by all members.
  - **Specialised bodies:**
    - ❑ SAARC Arbitration Council (SARCO) – Pakistan + SAARC Development Fund (SDF) – Bhutan.
    - ❑ South Asian University (SAU) – India + South Asian Regional Standards Organisation (SARSO) – Dhaka

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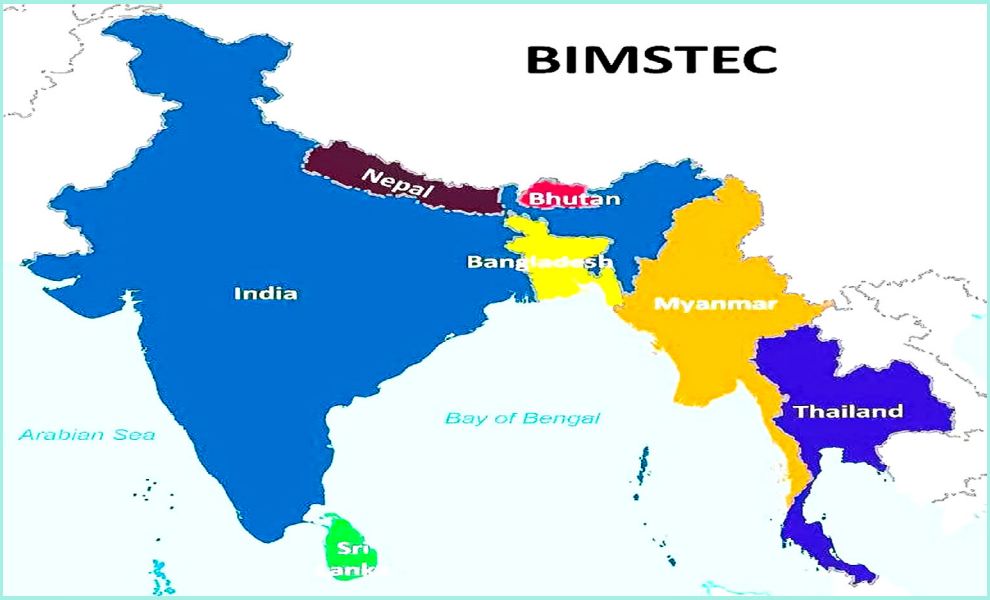
BIMSTEC (Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation)

- **Establishment year:** 1997 (Bangkok Declaration)



- **Members:** 7
- **Aim:** Bridge between South and Southeast Asia; rapid economic development in the Bay of Bengal region.
- **HQ:** Dhaka, Bangladesh.
- BIMSTEC Charter was finalised in 2022 Colombo summit.
- BIMSTEC is seen as the extension of India's **Neighbourhood First Policy**.
- **Focus point:** ~22% of the global population.
- **GDP: Approx. $4 trillion**.

6th BIMSTEC Summit 2025

- Held in Bangkok, Thailand. Under the **theme of** "BIMSTEC: Prosperous, Resilient, and Open."
- **Chairmanship:** Passed from Thailand to Bangladesh.
- **India-Led Initiatives**
  - **BODHI Program:** New skilling program for youth and professionals.
  - **Centres of Excellence in India:** Disaster Management (India-led) + Sustainable Maritime Transport + Traditional Medicine.
  - **Digital Connectivity:** Link India's UPI with regional payment systems + study on Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI).
  - **BIMSTEC Athletics Meet (2025)** and the first BIMSTEC Games (2027)

Bangladesh Trade, Investment and Development **Sub-sectors:** Blue Economy	Bhutan Environment & Climate Change **Sub-sectors:** Mountain Economy	India Security **Sub-sectors:** Counter-Terrorism and Transnational Crime, Disaster Management, Energy	Myanmar Agriculture and Food Security **Sub-sectors:** Agriculture, Fisheries & Livestock
Nepal People-to-People Contact **Sub-sectors:** Culture, Tourism, Poverty Alleviation, People-to-People Contact (forums of think tanks, media etc.)	Sri Lanka Science, Technology & Innovation **Sub-sectors:**Technology, Health, Human Resource Development	Thailand Connectivity	

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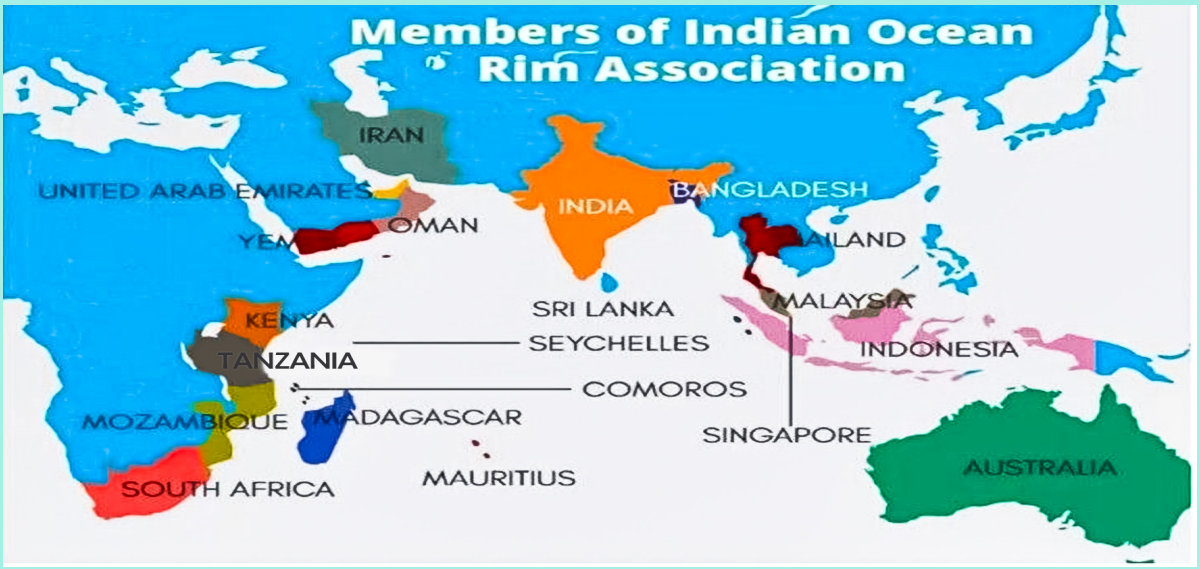
Indian Ocean Rim Association (IORA)

- An intergovernmental organisation established in 1997 (envisioned by Nelson Mandela).
- **Members:** 23 Member States + 12 Dialogue Partners. (**Note:** Myanmar and Pakistan are NOT members).
- Aim: Open Regionalism"—promoting economic cooperation without forming an exclusive "bloc."
- **HQ:** Ebène, Mauritius.
- 24th Council of Ministers' meeting of the Indian Ocean Rim Association: Virtual
- Host: Sri Lanka
- Theme: "Sustainable Indian Ocean for Future Generations."

Outcomes:

- The Colombo Communiqué (2025): It reiterated the "Indian Ocean Identity."
- IORA Guidelines on IUU Fishing: A landmark set of guidelines was adopted to combat Illegal, Unreported, and Unregulated (IUU) Fishing.
- IORA's Climate Agenda: Climate change adaptation and mitigation across the rim
- New Dialogue Partner: The European Union (EU)
- India is the **current Chair** of the Indian Ocean Rim Association (IORA) for the 2025–2027 term



GCC (Gulf Cooperation Council)

- **Establishment year:** 1981 (Abu Dhabi)

- **Members:** 6 (Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and the United Arab Emirates.
- **Aim:** Political and economic integration; collective security.
- **HQ:** Riyadh, Saudi Arabia.
- **Focus point:** GCC Common Market; Unified Customs Union; India-GCC FTA negotiations.

46th GCC Summit (Manama, Bahrain) Outcomes:

- **Sakhir Declaration:** Reaffirmed that GCC security is "indivisible." **Any threat to one member** is a threat to all.
- **Unified Tourism Visa:** To boost the non-oil economy.
- Approved the establishment of a Gulf Civil Aviation Authority for airspace management.
- **India-GCC FTA (Terms of Reference):** To resume Free Trade Agreement negotiations.

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Organisation of Turkic States (OTS)

Established in 2009 (as the Turkic Council) to promote comprehensive cooperation among Turkic-speaking nations; renamed OTS in 2021.

- **Members:** 5 - Azerbaijan, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Türkiye, and Uzbekistan.
- **Observers:** Hungary, Turkmenistan and the Turkish Republic of Northern Cyprus (TRNC).
- **HQ:** Istanbul, Türkiye.
- **Focus point: "Turkic World Vision 2040";** Development of the Middle Corridor (Trans-Caspian International Transport Route).

12th OTS Summit (Gabala, Azerbaijan)

Outcomes:

- **Gabala Declaration.**
- Adopted "OTS+" format for cooperation with third countries.
- **Ankara is named "Capital of Tourism 2026".**
- Focus on a Turkic Large Language Model (AI).

Three Seas Initiative

Established: 2015-2016 (Initiated by Poland and Croatia).

- **The "Three Seas":** Baltic, Adriatic, and Black Seas.
- **Membership (13 EU Nations):** Austria, Bulgaria, Croatia, Czech Republic, Estonia, **Greece (joined 2023)**, Hungary, Latvia, Lithuania, Poland, Romania, Slovakia, and Slovenia.
- **Note:** All members are part of the European Union.
- **Strategic Partners:** USA, Germany, European Commission, Japan, **Spain (2025)**, and Türkiye **(2025)**.
- **Associated Participating States:** Ukraine, Moldova, **Albania (2025)**, and **Montenegro (2025)**.
- **3 pillars:**
  - **Economic Growth:** To attract private investment
  - **Energy Security:** To decrease dependence on Russian fossil fuels
  - **Geopolitics & Resilience:** To strengthen the "Eastern Flank" of the EU and NATO.

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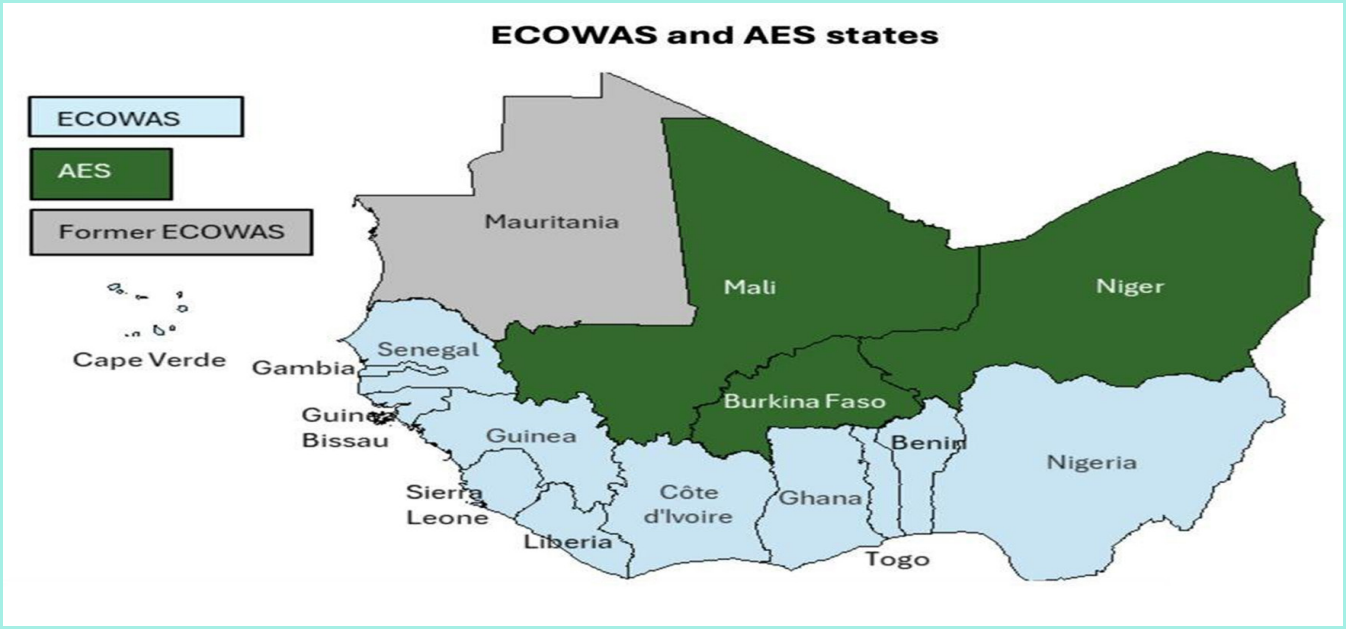
African Union

- **Established:** 2002 (replaced the Organisation of African Unity, OAU).

- **Headquarters:** Addis Ababa, Ethiopia.
- **Members:** 55 member states (entire African continent).
- **Vision:** "An Integrated, Prosperous, and Peaceful Africa" (Agenda 2063).
- The **African Continental Free Trade Area** (the world's largest FTA by number of countries).
- **India-AU Strategic Relations:**
  - **G20 Milestone:** India was the primary architect of the AU becoming a Permanent Member of the G20 in 2023.
  - **Key Pillars:** Focus on DPI (Digital Public Infrastructure - India Stack), Healthcare (Pharmacy of the World) and Critical Minerals (Lithium/Cobalt).
  - Pan-African e-Network (India-backed tele-education/telemedicine).

Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS)

- **Established:** May 28, 1975 (via the **Treaty of Lagos**).



- **Headquarters:** Abuja, Nigeria.
- **Members:** 12; originally 15
- **2026 Crisis/Status: Mali, Niger, and Burkina Faso** announced their withdrawal and formed a separate confederation called the **Alliance of Sahel States (AES)**.
- **Official Languages:** English, French, and Portuguese.

India and ECOWAS

- India has held **Observer Status in ECOWAS** since 2004.
- India→ Line of Credits → $250 million → ECOWAS Bank for Investment and Development **(EBID).**
- ECOWAS formally joined India-led **Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure (CDRI)**
- ECOWAS has consistently supported **India's bid for a permanent seat in the UN Security Council (UNSC)**

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Arab League

Established: March 22, 1945 (Treaty: **Alexandria Protocol** / Cairo Pact).

- **Headquarters:** Cairo, Egypt.
- **Members: 22 Member States** (including Palestine).
- **Official Language:** Arabic.
- **Aim:** To strengthen ties among member states, coordinate their policies, and direct them towards a common good.
- India has been an observer since 2007 and recently a permanent observer.
- **2nd India-Arab Ministerial Meeting 2026:** Held in New Delhi.

Delhi declaration: A joint commitment by India and the 22-member Arab League to safeguard regional sovereignty, ensure Red Sea maritime security, and achieve a two-state solution for Palestine through the Arab Peace Initiative.

4.5. Multilateral Export Control Regimes

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. 1. What is/are the consequence/consequences of a country becoming the member of the 'Nuclear Suppliers Group'? **(2018)**
1. It will have access to the latest and most efficient nuclear technologies.
2. It automatically becomes a member of the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (NPT).

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
(a) 1 only (b) 2 only (c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

2. Consider the following: **(2022)**
1. Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank
2. Missile Technology Control Regime
3. Shanghai Cooperation Organisation

India is a member of which of the above?
(a) 1 and 2 only (b) 3 only (c) 2 and 3 only (d) 1,2 and 3

3. Recently, the USA decided to support India's membership in the "Australia Group" and the "Wassenaar Arrangement". What is the difference between them? **(2011)**
1. The Australia Group is an informal arrangement which aims to allow exporting countries to minimize the risk of assisting chemical and biological weapons proliferation, whereas the Wessenar Arrangement is a formal group under the OECD holding identical objectives
2. The Australia Group comprises predominantly Asian, African and North American countries, whereas the member countries of Wassenaar Arrangement are predominantly from the European union and American continents.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
(a) 1 only (b) 2 only (c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: 1. (a), 2. (d), 3. (d)

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GLOBAL EXPORT CONTROL REGIMES: A COMPARATIVE OVERVIEW

ASPECTS	NUCLEAR SUPPLIERS GROUP (NSG)	AUSTRALIA GROUP (AG)	WASSENAAR ARRANGEMENT (WA)	MISSILE TECHNOLOGY CONTROL REGIME (MTCR)
ESTABLISHED YEAR	1974 (Response to India's 'Smiling Buddha' nuclear test)	1985 (Formed after chemical weapons use in the Iran-Iraq war)	1996 (Successor to the Cold War-era COCOM)	1987 (G7 initiative)
MEMBERS	48 (India is NOT a member; China is a member)	43 (including India and the European Union)	42 (including India)	35 (including India) China not a member
HQ (HEADQUARTERS)	No formal permanent HQ; Secretariat Point of Contact in Vienna, Austria	No formal HQ; managed by the Australian Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade (DFAT) in Canberra	Vienna, Austria (Permanent Secretariat)	Informal; Point of Contact (Secretariat) is in Paris, France
AIM (PRIMARY GOAL)	Prevent nuclear proliferation by controlling exports of materials, equipment, and technology that can be used to manufacture nuclear weapons	Ensure exports of certain chemicals, biological agents, and dual-use equipment do not contribute to the spread of chemical or biological weapons (CBW).	Promote transparency and greater responsibility in transfers of conventional arms and dual-use goods and technologies to prevent destabilizing accumulations.	Limit the proliferation of missiles, complete rocket systems, unmanned air vehicles (UAVs), and related technology for systems capable of carrying a >500kg payload for >300km, and systems intended for WMD delivery.
FOCUS OR INITIATIVE	Operates on Consensus; Adheres to Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT) guidelines. Not legally binding.	Maintains Common Control Lists (chemicals, pathogens, toxins, dual-use production facilities). Informal arrangement, not legally binding.	Not a legally-binding treaty. Obligations Include sharing critical information on transfers of listed items. Includes new controls on emerging technologies.	Not a legally-binding treaty. Partners agree on common export policy guidelines and a common Annex of controlled items. Includes controls on green propellants like Hydroxylammonium Nitrate (HAN).

4.6. Specialised & Thematic Initiatives

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. In the Mekong–Ganga Cooperation, an initiative of six countries, which of the following is/are not a participant/participants? **(2015)**

1. Bangladesh
2. Cambodia
3. China
4. Myanmar
5. Thailand

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

(a) 1 only (b) 2, 3 and 4 (c) 1 and 3 (d) 1, 2 and 5

Answer: 1. (c)

Mekong – Ganga Cooperation

A sub-regional initiative that **bridges India with the Mekong region** through shared civilizational and cultural ties.

- **Est. Year: 2000** (Launched in Vientiane, Laos).
- **Members (6):** India + 5 ASEAN countries (Cambodia, Laos, Myanmar, Thailand, Vietnam).
- **Aim:** To foster cooperation in culture, commerce, and connectivity between the Ganga and Mekong river basins.
- **HQ/Secretariat:** No permanent HQ.
- The **Chairmanship rotates alphabetically**; the Chair country acts as the temporary secretariat.
- **Original 4 Areas:** Tourism, Culture, Education, and Transport & Communications.
- **New Areas Added (2012):** Health, MSMEs, Agriculture (Rice Germplasm), and Science & Technology.

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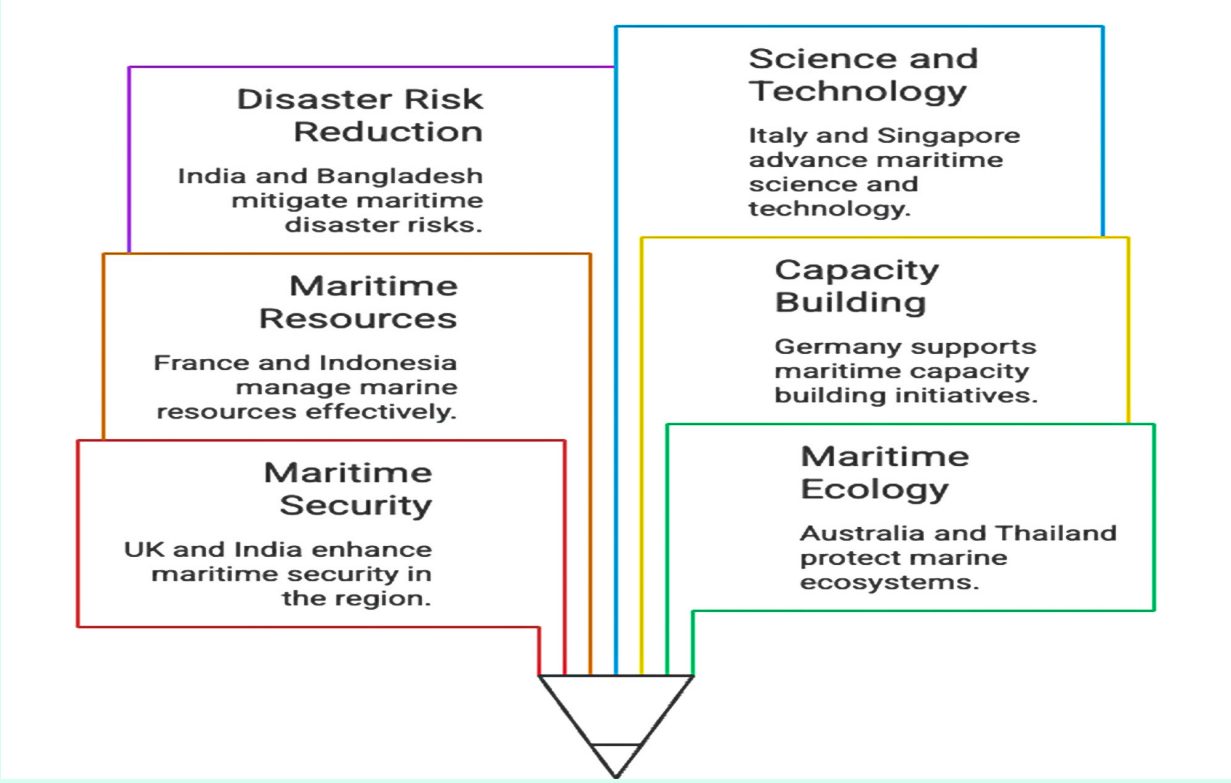
Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative

An **India-led, open, and voluntary framework** to address maritime challenges in the Indo-Pacific.



- **Established in 2019** (Announced by India at the **14th East Asia Summit in Bangkok**).
- **Members:** Not a closed grouping; it is an **open, non-treaty-based** initiative.
- **Aim:** To promote a **Free, Open, and Inclusive** Indo-Pacific by operationalizing India's **SAGAR** (Security and Growth for All in the Region) vision.
- **HQ:** None. It leverages existing regional structures like the **East Asia Summit (EAS)** and **IORA**.
- Focus point: It is a non-treaty-based voluntary arrangement.
- 7 pillars of the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative (IPOI) and their respective lead countries:
  - **Maritime Security** → India & UK
  - **Maritime Ecology** → Australia & Thailand
  - **Maritime Resources** → France & Indonesia
  - **Capacity Building & Resource Sharing** → Germany
  - **Disaster Risk Reduction & Management** → India & Bangladesh
  - **Science, Technology & Academic Cooperation** → Italy & Singapore
  - **Trade, Connectivity & Maritime Transport** → Japan & USA.

COSP 11 to the United Nations Convention against Corruption (UNCAC)

- **Aim:** UNCAC offers a comprehensive framework for preventing and combating corruption worldwide
- **The only legally obligatory** universal anti-corruption instrument.
- It tackles corruption in both the **public and commercial sectors.**
- **Adoption and Status:** In October 2003, the UN General Assembly adopted it → came into effect in 2005.
- **Secretariat:** Run by the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC).
- **Host & Date: Doha, Qatar**, 2025.
- **Theme:** Shaping Tomorrow's Integrity.
- **Primary Outcome (Doha Declaration 2025): Harnessing of Artificial Intelligence (AI)** and digital technologies to **detect and combat corruption** while ensuring ethical safeguards and human oversight.
- **New Private Sector Platform:** Co-led by **UNODC** and the **UN Global Compact**.

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5 Reports, Indices, and Summits

5.1 Global Economy And Financial Outlook

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. The Global Competitiveness Report is published by **(2019)**
   (a) International Monetary Fund
   (b) United Nations Conference on Trade and Development
   (c) World Economic Forum
   (d) World Bank

2. Global Financial Stability Report is prepared by the **(2016)**
   (a) European Central Bank
   (b) International Monetary Fund
   (c) International Bank for Reconstruction and Development
   (d) Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development

3. Which one of the following issues the Global Economic Prospects report periodically? **(2015)**
   (a) Asian Development Bank
   (b) European Bank for Reconstruction and Development
   (c) US Federal Reserve Bank
   (d) World Bank

4. Which organization brings out the publication known as World Economic Outlook? **(2014)**
   (a) International Monetary Fund
   (b) United Nations Development Programme
   (c) World Economic Forum
   (d) World Bank

Answers: 1(c), 2 (b), 3 (d), 4 (a)

REPORT / INDEX	PUBLISHER	KEY INDICATORS	INDIA'S RANK / SCORE (2025/26)	TOPPED BY
World Economic Outlook (WEO)	International Monetary Fund (IMF)	GDP growth, inflation, Unemployment, Current account balance.	**Rank:** 2nd largest driver of global growth (2026). **Growth:** 7.3% (FY25-26).	China (Highest growth contribution)
Global Financial Stability Report	IMF	Risk in banking/non-banking sectors, Market liquidity, Debt conditions.	Not a ranking; highlights India's resilient banking sector and strong forex reserves.	N/A (Analytical Report)
Global Economic Prospects	World Bank	Global GDP trends, Regional outlooks, Commodity prices.	**Projection:** India remains the fastest-growing major economy (estimated ~7%).	India (Fastest growth among major peers)
World Competitiveness Report	World Economic Forum (WEF)	Economic performance, Government efficiency, Business efficiency, Infrastructure.	**Rank:** 41/69 countries (2025/26)	Switzerland
Ease of Doing Business	World Bank Note: Replaced by Business-READY project.	11 indicators like starting business, taxes, credit.	New B-READY report for India is scheduled for 2026. (Last rank: 63 in 2019).	New Zealand (2019)
UNCTAD Trade and Development Report 2025	United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD)	Trade partnership diversity, Economic resilience, Global South trends.	**Rank:** 3rd among Global South economies in trade partnership diversity.	China (1st), UAE (2nd) (for Global South)

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5.2. Urbanisation and Human Settlement

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. As per UN-Habitat's Global Report on Human Settlements 2009, which region has shown the fastest growth of urbanization in the last three decades? **(2010)**
(a) Asia
(b) Europe
(c) Latin America and Caribbean
(d) North America

Answers: 1(a)

Report / Index

Global Report on Human Settlements	World Cities Report
• **Published by** UN-Habitat • **Key Indicators** ♦ Urban housing, ♦ Slum populations, ♦ Sustainable urban development • Not a country-wise ranking; focuses on policy trends. • According to 2009 report, Asia has shown the fastest growth rate of urbanization in the preceding three decades.	• **Published by** UN-Habitat • **Key Indicators** ♦ Liveability, ♦ Prosperity ♦ Sustainability. • As per the 2024 report, titled "Cities and Climate Action," highlights that cities are both primary victims and offenders of climate change, requiring urgent action.

5.3. Poverty And Gender

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Which of the following gives the Global Gender Gap Index ranking? **(2017)**
(a) World Economic Forum
(b) UN Human Rights Council
(c) UN Women
(d) World Health Organization

2. Which of the following indicators are used by IFPRI to compute the Global Hunger Index? **(2016)**
1. Undernourishment
2. Child stunting
3. Child mortality

Select the correct answer using the code given below:
(a) 1 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1, 2 and 3
(d) 1 and 3 only

3. The Multidimensional Poverty Index covers **(2012)**
1. Education, health, assets and services
2. Purchasing Power Parity (PPP)
3. GDP growth and fiscal deficit

Select the correct answer using the code given below:
(a) 1 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: 1(a), 2(c), 3(a)

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Report / Index	Publisher	Key Indicators	India's Rank / Score (2025/26)	Topped By
Global Gender Gap Index	World Economic Forum	• Economic participation • Education • Health • Political empowerment.	Rank: 131st/148 Countries (2025) Score: 0.641	Iceland
Global Hunger Index (GHI)	Welthungerhilfe & Concern Worldwide	• Undernourishment, • Child Wasting, • Child Stunting, • Child Mortality.	Rank: 102nd (2025) Score: 25.8 (Serious category)	Countries 1-25 (Score < 5)
Multidimensional Poverty Index (MPI)	Oxford Poverty and Human Development Initiative (OPHI) & UNDP	• Health (Nutrition), • Education (Schooling), • Living Standards (Water, Assets).	India's multidimensional poverty rate fell from 55.1% in 2005-06 to 16.4% in 2019-21.	2025 report shows that 1.1 billion people live in acute poverty, with the highest concentration in Sub-Saharan Africa and South Asia

5.4 Governance And Legal Frameworks

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. "Rule of Law Index" is released by **(2018)**
(a) Amnesty International
(b) International Court of Justice
(c) Office of UN High Commissioner for Human Rights
(d) World Justice Project

Answers: 1(d)

Report / Index	Publisher	Key Indicators	India's Rank / Score (2025/26)	Topped By
Rule of Law Index	World Justice Project (WJP)	• Constraints on Government • Absence of Corruption, • Open Govt, Fundamental Rights.	Rank: 86th (2025) / 143 countries Score: 0.49	Denmark
Responsible Nations Index (RNI)	World Intellectual Foundation (WIF) + Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) and IIM Mumbai.	• 3 Pillars: • Internal Responsibility (Welfare/Justice), • Environmental Responsibility, and • External Responsibility (Global Peace).	Rank: 16th Score: 0.5515 Ahead of the U.S. (66th) and China (68th).	1. Singapore (Score: 0.6194) 2. Switzerland 3. Denmark

5.5 Global Technology Governance Summits

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following statements regarding the AI Action Summit held in Grand Palais, Paris in February 2025: **(2025)**
I. Co-chaired with India, the event builds on the advances made at the Bletchley Park Summit in 2023 and the Seoul Summit in 2024.
II. Along with other countries, the US and UK also signed the declaration on inclusive and sustainable AI.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
(a) I only (b) II only (c) Both I and II (d) Neither I nor II

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2. To integrate cultural leaders into its meetings, which organization gives the Crystal Award? **(2009)**

(a) Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation
(b) International Bank for Reconstruction and Development
(c) World Health Organization
(d) World Economic Forum

Answer: 1. (a), 2. (d)

Feature	AI Action Summit 2025	AI Impact Summit 2026 (New Delhi)
Host & Role	Paris, co-chaired by India and France. India was a co-host & Global South advocate.	New Delhi, India India (Ministry of Electronics and IT - MeitY).
Background	It was built on the AI Safety Summit held in Britain in Bletchley Park in 2023 and a smaller meeting in Seoul in 2024.	It was built on the background of **the AI Action Summit 2025 held in Paris.**
Theme	Inclusive and Sustainable Artificial Intelligence for People and the Planet	"Sarvajan Hitaya, Sarvajan Sukhaya" (Welfare for all).
Main Focus	Making AI **usable in real sectors** (jobs, climate, public services)	Using AI for **inclusive development** (economy, society, governance)
Approach	Shift from **AI risks → practical use** (post-Bletchley Park AI Safety Summit)	Inclusive, development-oriented AI guided by 3 Sutras (People, Planet, Progress) + **M.A.N.A.V.** framework.
Structure	No fixed structure	**7 Chakras (thematic pillars)** + structured cooperation platforms
Key Result	Agreement on need for **fair and sustainable AI**	AI Impact Declaration (92 countries supported)
Key Initiatives	General cooperation of AI in health, ethical standards, global governance, etc.	AI Commons, Trusted AI Commons, AI for Science Network, Democratic AI Charter
Overall Significance	Shift from **risk debate → practical implementation of AI**	Establishes inclusive, scalable, Global South-led AI governance with institutional mechanisms.

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Bletchley Declaration → The first global pact on Artificial Intelligence (AI) safety, signed on November 1, 2023, by 29 nations—including the UK, US, China, and India—and the EU at Bletchley Park. It focuses on managing risks from "frontier AI," emphasizing international cooperation for safe, ethical development.

5.5.1 World Economic Forum – Crystal Award 2025

The Crystal Award is **given to cultural leaders** who use their platform for social/environmental change → **Chairmanship / Host:** The award is presented **during the WEF Annual Meeting in Davos,** Switzerland → **2025 Theme: "Collaboration for the Intelligent Age ".**

- **2025 Winners:**
  - **David Beckham (UK):** For his work with **UNICEF on children's rights.**
  - **Diane von Furstenberg (USA):** For empowering **women and gender equality.**
  - **Riken Yamamoto (Japan):** (Architect) For community **regeneration and sustainable design.**

5.5.2 GPAI (Global Partnership on AI)

Feature	Details
About	Launched in June 2020, a **multi-stakeholder** initiative (like a G7 for AI) **hosted by the OECD. As of March 2026,** it currently consists of 44 member countries. **China is not a member.**
India's Role	India is one of the founding members of GPAI. As Lead Chair, I**ndia hosted the Global IndiaAI Summit 2024** in **New Delhi.**
New Delhi Declaration, 2024	Adopted unanimously. It shifted the global focus from **just "Safety" to "AI for All"** and "Global South inclusivity."
Key Outcome	**GPAI-OECD Integrated Partnership:** A landmark merger of GPAI's multi-stakeholder expertise with OECD's policy standards to create a unified global AI governance framework.
Key information	GPAI works on four themes: Responsible AI, Data Governance, Future of Work, and Innovation / Commercialization.

5.6 Civil Liberties and Human Rights

Report / Index	Publisher	Key Indicators	India's Rank / Score (2025/26)	Topped By
World Press Freedom Index 2025	Reporters Without Borders (RSF)	♦ Pluralism, ♦ Media independence, ♦ Safety of journalists.	Rank: 151st (Slight rise from 159th) Score: 32.96	Norway
Corruption Perception Index (CPI) 2025	Transparency International	• Perceived levels of public sector corruption.	Rank: 91st Score: 39	Denmark (Score: 89)
Human Development Index (HDI) 2025	UNDP	• Life expectancy, • Expected years of schooling, • GNI per capita.	Rank: 130 (out of 193 countries).	Iceland

5.7 Mobility and Soft Power

Report / Index	Publisher	Key Indicators	India's Rank / Score (2026)	Topped By
Henley Passport Index 2026	Henley & Partners	• Number of destinations accessible without a prior visa.	Rank: 76th / Score: 56 destinations	Singapore (192 destinations)
Global Soft Power Index 2026	Brand Finance	• Familiarity, Reputation, Influence. • Culture, • International Relations.	Rank: 32nd (Steady growth in 2025/26).	USA
QS world rankings	Quacquarelli Symonds (QS), a British company	• Academic Reputation, • Employer Reputation, • Citations per Faculty, • Sustainability, • Employment Outcomes.	Highest Rank: IIT Delhi (123rd globally).	MIT (USA) (14th consecutive year)

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5.8 Defence and Expenditure

Report / Index	Publisher	Key Indicators	India's Rank 2026	Topped By
SIPRI Yearbook: Military Expenditure	Stockholm Intl. Peace Research Inst.	Total annual defense spending in USD and % of GDP.	Rank: 5th	USA
Arms Transfers Report	SIPRI	Imports and exports of major conventional weapons.	Rank: 2nd Largest Importer	Ukraine (1st)
Top 100 Arms Companies	SIPRI	Revenue from defense contracts for private and state companies.	3 Indian firms in Top 100: HAL, BEL, and Mazagon Dock.	Lockheed Martin (USA)

5.9 Additional summits

Summit	Details
Global Digital Compact (GDC)	• A UN-led initiative (2024-25) to **close the digital divide.** • India pushes its **DPI (Digital Public Infrastructure)** model here.
Gaza peace summit	• **Established in 2025**, in Sharm El-Sheikh, Egypt. → Chaired by the **U.S.** and **Egypt**, with **Qatar** and **Turkey** as primary guarantors. • **Nature:** An emergency summit to formalize the **"Trump Peace Plan"** (a 20-point framework) and end the two-year Israel-Hamas war. • **Initial Aim:** To implement a phased ceasefire, facilitate a complete hostage-prisoner exchange, and establish a framework for the "New Gaza."

5.10 Dialogues

Dialogue	Details
Quad Critical & Emerging Technology Working Group	• Focuses on Open RAN (5G/6G) and undersea cables. • Crucial for maritime and digital security.
Kimberley Process	• India has assumed the chair of the Kimberley Process (KP) for the year 2026. • It is an international certification scheme (KPCS) where India is a founding member; it defines conflict diamonds • specifically as rough diamonds used by rebel movements to finance wars against legitimate governments.

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6 Bilateral Initiatives in News

6.1 Technological Cooperation

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following statements: **(2023)**

1. Statement-I: Recently, the United States of America (USA) and the European Union (EU) have launched the 'Trade and Technology Council.'
2. Statement-II: The USA and the EU claim that through this they are trying to bring technological progress and physical productivity under their control.

Which one of the following is correct in respect of the above statements?

(a) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct and Statement-II is the correct explanation for Statement-I
(b) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct and Statement-II is not the correct explanation for Statement-I
(c) Statement-I is correct but Statement-II is incorrect
(d) Statement-I is incorrect but Statement-II is correct

Answer: 1(c)

Initiative	Description
The U.S.-EU Trade and Technology Council (TTC)	• **Aim:** Strategic coordination on trade, economy, and tech; countering non-market economies. • **Recent outcomes (2024): Cooperating on AI Safety,** 6G vision, and a 3-year extension for semiconductor supply chains. • **Significance:** Sets global standards (AI, 6G) that India must align with or influence **to avoid "Pax Silica" (tech exclusion).**
India-US	• **Aim:** Deepen strategic partnership in critical/emerging tech **(iCET) and trade.** • Recent outcomes: ♦ **U.S.-India TRUST:** Govt + Academia + Private Sector → Secure & advance critical tech (AI, Defense, Semiconductors). → Successor and expansion of the Initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology (iCET) → While iCET established the foundation for technology cooperation in AI, semiconductors, and defense, TRUST broadens this scope to include critical minerals, biotechnology, and space while strengthening the AI Infrastructure Roadmap for India. ♦ **INDUS Innovation:** INDUS-X model → Joint investments and partnerships in Space, Energy, and Emerging Technology. • **Munitions Supply Chain** Roadmap, allowing **Indian private firms** to manufacture parts for US Stryker vehicles.

6.2 Bilateral Free Trade & Economic Agreements

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. 'Broad-based Trade and Investment Agreement (BTIA)' is sometimes seen in the news in the context of negotiations held between India and **(2017)**

(a) European Union
(b) Gulf Cooperation Council
(c) Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development
(d) Shanghai Cooperation Organization

Answer: 1(a)

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1. Types of trade agreements:

Characteristic	Scope	Negative List
Free Trade Agreement (FTA)	Preferential trade terms	Yes
Preferential Trade Agreement (PTA)	Preferential entry for certain products	No
Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CECA/CEPA)	More comprehensive than FTA	Yes
Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement (CECA)	Covers trade tariffs and TQR rates	No
Framework Agreement	Defines scope and provisions	No

2. Recent Trade Agreements

Agreement	Key Outcomes & Highlights	Details
India-EU FTA, 2026	A comprehensive FTA covering goods, services and digital trade → A maximum of Indian exports (textiles and leather) get duty-free access	India secured Most-Favored-Nation assurance; any flexibility the EU gives to others on the "Carbon Tax" must be given to India.
India–Oman CEPA, 2025	Almost 100% duty-free market access in Oman Includes a joint vision for maritime security.	Oman's first FTA since 2006. Focus on **Green Hydrogen and Green Steel investments.**
India–EFTA TEPA, 2024	EFTA Nations → **Switzerland, Norway, Iceland, Liechtenstein.** Commitment of a $100 billion investment into India over 15 years; 1 million jobs.	Gold is excluded from the zero-duty list (to protect Indian forex).
India–UAE CEPA 2022	A $100 billion target set for non-oil bilateral trade to be achieved by 2030. Setup of Bharat Mart in Dubai (Jebel Ali) for Indian exporters.	Utilizes **Local Currency Settlement (LCS)** (Rupee-Dirham) to bypass the US Dollar.
India–Mauritius CECPA (2021)	First trade deal with an African nation. A recent update added Automatic Safeguard Mechanisms.	Acts as a launchpad for Indian firms to access the **AfCFTA (African Continental FTA).**
India–South Korea CEPA 2009	Focus on reducing India's trade deficit and improving market access for Indian Steel & Pharma.	Main focus: **Renegotiating Rules of Origin (RoO)** to stop circumvention of Chinese goods.
India–Australia ECTA / CECA (2022)	Duty-free access for 100% of Indian goods. Australia provides Critical Minerals (Lithium/ Cobalt).	Includes Post-study work visas for Indian students and **Double Taxation** relief for IT firms.

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6.3 Summit / Partnerships / Treaties / Initiatives

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following statements: **(2016)**
1. The India-Africa Summit held in 2015 was the third such Summit.
2. The India-Africa Summit was actually initiated by Jawaharlal Nehru in 1951.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?
(a) 1 only (b) 2 only (c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Answers: 1(a)

India-Africa Forum Summit (IAFS)

- **Aim:** Structured mechanism for cooperation (Trade, Tech, Security).
- **Summits:** IAFS is supposed to be held **once every three years,** however the rule has not been strictly followed.
- **It was first held in New Delhi (2008).**
- Three IAFS have been held previously in 2008, 2011 and 2015
- **Latest:** The Union Cabinet approved 18 new missions in March 2018 to be opened over 2018–2021. As of late 2025, reports indicate 17 have actually been opened, with one not yet operational.
  - ♦ Focus shifted to **Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) and Green Hydrogen (2025)** → India is now a top-5 investor.

India-Russia Annual Summit

- **23rd Summit (Dec 2025):** Held in New Delhi.
- **Outcomes:** Programme 2030 for economic cooperation; target of $100B trade by 2030.
  - ♦ New Consulates in Kazan & Yekaterinburg.
  - ♦ Work on the India-EAEU (Eurasian Economic Union) FTA fast-tracked.

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Consider the following in respect of Indian Ocean Naval Symposium (IONS): **(2017)**
1. Inaugural IONS was held in India in 2015.
2. It seeks maritime cooperation among navies of Indian Ocean littoral states.

Which of the above statements is/are correct?
(a) 1 only (b) 2 only (c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

2. The "New START" treaty was in the news. What is this treaty? **(2011)**
(a) A bilateral strategic nuclear arms reduction treaty between the USA and the Russian Federation.
(b) A multilateral energy security treaty of the East Asia Summit.
(c) A Russia-EU energy security treaty.
(d) A BRICS trade promotion treaty.

Answer: 1. (b), 2. (a)

Indian Ocean Naval Symposium (IONS)	• Voluntary initiative that seeks to increase maritime cooperation among navies of the littoral states of the Indian Ocean Region. • The inaugural edition of IONS was held in Feb 2008 at New Delhi. • India assumed Chairmanship (2025–2027) in Feb 2026 after 16 years. • Focus points: IMEX (IONS Maritime Exercise), HADR, and Information Sharing. • Philippines added as Observer; Oman joined HADR working group.
New START Treaty	• It was the last remaining major nuclear arms control treaty **between the US and Russia.** • **Status: Expired in February 2026**
ACITI (Australia Canada India Technology and Innovation Partnership)	• **Established: November 22, 2025**, on the sidelines of the **G20 Summit in Johannesburg**, South Africa → A **trilateral technology and innovation framework**." • **Initial Aim:** To build a **"Democratic Tech Bloc"** that serves as an alternative to authoritarian-led tech ecosystems. The partnership focuses on: ♦ **Critical and Emerging Technologies:** AI, quantum computing, and semiconductors. ♦ **Clean Energy:** Decarbonization and green hydrogen. ♦ **Supply Chain Resilience:** Particularly in **Critical Minerals** (Lithium, Cobalt, Nickel) to reduce dependency on China.

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Plutonium Management and Disposition Agreement	• Russia's lower house approved formal withdrawal from the PMDA ➔ Follows their initial 2016 suspension citing US sanctions. • **About PMDA (2000):** Commits the US & Russia to irreversibly dispose of ≥34 metric tons of weapons-grade plutonium each ➔ **Goal:** Convert to safer forms (MOX fuel or reactor irradiation).

6.5 Sector-Specific Multilateral Cooperation

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. With reference to Asia-Pacific Ministerial Conference on Housing and Urban Development (APMCHUD), consider the following statements: **(2017)**

1. The first APMCHUD was held in India in 2006.
2. India hosts all the annual conferences in partnership with ADB, APEC and ASEAN.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only (b) 2 only (c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: 1. (a)

Asia-Pacific Ministerial Conference on Housing and Urban Development (APMCHUD) (Housing & Urban Development)

- **Aim:** Sustainable human settlements in Asia-Pacific.
- The **first meeting of APMCHUD was held in Delhi in 2006.**
- The meeting is h**osted under the aegis of UN-HABITAT** not in collaboration with ADB, APEC or ASEAN.
- There is a **rotating chairmanship a**mong Asia-Pacific nations.
- Focuses on slum upgrading and climate-resilient urban planning.
- **Iran currently leads the sub-regional working group on "urban slum upgrading".**

6.6 Critical Mineral Partnerships: India & Other Countries

Partner	Strategic Outcome
Brazil, 2026	India-Brazil MoU on Cooperation in Rare Earths and Critical Minerals → Signed a Rare Earth & Mining Agreement during President Lula's visit. Focus on Rare Earth Elements (REE) and Iron Ore supply.
USA, 2026	The Pax Silica Declaration → Critical Minerals MoU signed during the Interim Trade Deal. Includes "Pax Silica" (US-led tech-mineral alliance) and joint R&D on Sodium-Ion alternatives.
Saudi Arabia, 2025	India-Saudi Arabia MoU for critical minerals. Both signed a landmark deal for Joint Exploration in third countries (specifically in Africa) and technology transfer for mineral processing.
Australia	**2025-26** → The Australia-India Critical Minerals Investment Partnership finalized 5 target projects (2 lithium, 3 cobalt).
Zambia, 2025	India committed a significant investment to the Zambian mining sector. Zambia allocated 9,000 sq km for Indian firms (KABIL) to explore Copper and Cobalt.
Argentina, 2024	KABIL-CAMYEN Exploration and Development Agreement KABIL's first major success—mining started at 5 Lithium Brine blocks in Catamarca province.

6.7 Major Critical Mineral Agreements: Other Countries

Partner 1	Partner 2	Date	Strategic Focus
USA	**Argentina**	2026	Strategic Framework to Strengthen Critical Minerals Supply Chains Joint goal of high-standard markets and benchmark pricing for lithium.
USA	**Brazil**	2026	DFC-Serra Verde Rare Earths Financing Agreement; $565 million US financing for Serra Verde Rare Earth Project (ionic clay deposit).
Australia	**Japan**	2026	Framework for Strategic Defence Coordination (FSDC) Deepening of Energy Security to Economic Security.
Canada	**Germany**	2025	Joint Declaration of Intent on Critical Minerals Cooperation (2025) Strategic alignment for Nickel, Lithium, and REE to support Germany's industrial transition.

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6.8 India's Major Trade Partners

Rank	Country	Nature of Trade
1	**China**	India's largest source of imports. Massive trade deficit. Imports focused on electronics, APIs (pharma), and machinery. Bilateral trade reaching **$151.1 billion in 2025-26.**
2	**USA**	India's largest export destination. Largest trade surplus. Bilateral trade reached $149.4 billion in 2025. The 2026 Interim Trade Deal reduced tariffs to 18%.
3	**UAE**	Third-largest partner. CEPA (2022) success; non-oil trade grew 20% in 2025. Bilateral trade reaching ~$100 billion in FY25 (April 2024–March 2025).
4	**Russia**	Huge import surge since 2022 (crude oil). Major trade deficit. Currently diversifying energy sources away from Russia in early 2026. Bilateral trade reached $68.7 billion in FY 2024-25.
5	**EU (Block)**	Largest goods trading partner if taken as a single block. India-EU FTA (Jan 2026) is the current milestone. Bilateral merchandise trade reached ~$136.54 billion in 2024-25.

6.9 India-U.S Military Agreements

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement (COMCASA), recently seen in news relates to: **(2017)**

(a) USA (b) European Union (c) SAARC (d) ASEAN

Answer: 1. (a)

- **GSOMIA** (General Security of Military Information Agreement, 2002) → Protects shared classified intelligence
- **LEMOA** (Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement, 2016) → Reciprocal base access for refueling & repairs → This is an India-specific pact; it explicitly does *not* allow the stationing of US troops on Indian soil.
- **COMCASA** (Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement, 2018) → Secure, encrypted military comms → Enables real-time "interoperability" between US and Indian platforms (allowing Indian P-8I aircraft or ships to plug into US secure data networks).
- **BECA** (Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement, 2020) → Sharing of classified geospatial & satellite data → **Value Add:** This is the backbone for precision strikes, providing the exact coordinates needed for automated systems, armed drones, and cruise missiles.

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7 Defence Exercises and Operations

7.1. Defence Exercises

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Which of the following statements about 'Exercise Mitra Shakti-2023' are correct? **(2024)**

1. This was a joint military exercise between India and Bangladesh.
2. It commenced in Aundh (Pune).
3. Joint response during counter-terrorism operations was a goal of this operation.
4. Indian Air Force was a part of this exercise.

Select the answer using the code given below:

(a) 1, 2 and 3 (b) 1, 2 and 4 (c) 1, 3 and 4 (d) 2, 3 and 4

Answer: 1(d)

India's Bilateral Defence Exercises

Exercise Name (Date)	Countries/Force	Location	Type
Dustlik-VII (12-25 April, 2026)	India and Uzbekistan	Gurumsaray Field Training Area, Uzbekistan	Joint Military Exercise
Cyclone IV (09 to 17 April 2026)	India and Egypt	Anshas, Egypt	Joint Special Forces Exercise
LAMITIYE (March 10 to 22, 2026)	India–Seychelles	Seychelles Defence Academy	Joint Military Exercise
Khanjar-XIII (04 to 17 February 2026)	India-Kyrgyzstan	Misamari, Assam	Joint Special Forces Exercise
Dharma Guardian (24 February to 9 March 2026)	India and Japan	Foreign Training Node, Chaubattia in Uttarakhand	Joint Military Exercise
Vajra Prahar 16th Edition (24 Feb to 16 March 2026)	India and the USA	Special Forces Training School, Bakloh, Himachal Pradesh	Joint Special Forces Exercise
Varuna 2025 (March 19–22, 2025)	India and France	Arabian Sea	Bilateral Naval Exercise
Bongo Sagar 2025 (March 10 to 12, 2025)	India and Bangladesh	Northern Bay of Bengal.	Bilateral Naval Exercise
Exercise MITRA SHAKTI-2025	India and Sri Lanka	Foreign Training Node, Belagavi, Karnataka	Joint Military Exercise
Shakti-VIII (June 18 to July 1, 2025)	India and France	Camp Larzac, La Cavalerie, France.	Joint Military Exercise
Maitree-XIV (Sept. 1-14, 2025)	India and Thailand	Joint Training Node in Umroi, Meghalaya	Joint Military Exercise
Indra (March 28 to April 2, 2025)	India and Russia	Bay of Bengal	Bilateral Naval Exercise
Tiger Triumph (01 to 12 April 2025)	India and USA	Two phases in Visakhapatnam and Kakinada	Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief
Ekuverin 2025 (14th Ed.) 02-15 Dec. 2025	India and Maldives	Thiruvananthapuram , Kerala	Joint Military Exercise
Yudh Abhyas (21st Ed.) 1st-14th Sept. 2025	India and USA	Fort Wainwright, Alaska, USA	Joint Military Exercise
VINBAX-2025 (6th Ed.) (Nov 11–27, 2025)	India and Vietnam	Mieu Mon Training Centre in Hanoi, Vietnam	Joint Military Exercise
HOPEX 2024 June 21 – 26, 2024	India and Egypt	Egypt	Air Force

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Multilateral Exercises Involving India			
Exercise Name (Date)	**Countries/Force**	**Location**	**Type**
Sea Dragon 2026 (March 2026)	USA (Host), India, Australia, Japan, South Korea	Guam, USA	US-led multinational anti-submarine warfare
Milan 2026 (Feb 15-25, 2026)	India (Host), Participation by 70+ countries, including USA and Russia	Visakhapatnam	Multinational Naval
La Perouse 2025 (January 16 to 24, 2025)	France (Host) + Royal Australian Navy, Indian Navy, Royal Navy, United States Navy	Malacca Straits	Multinational Naval
INIOCHOS-25 (March 31 to April 11, 2025)	Greece (Host) + India, USA, France, Israel, Qatar, etc.	Andravida, Greece	Multinational Air
Pitch Black (July 12 to August 2, 2024)	Australia (Host) + 20 Countries	Darwin, Australia	Multinational Air
Tarang Shakti, 2024 Phase 1: August 6-14 Phase 2: Sept 1-14	India (Host) + 51 Countries → held in two phases	Tamil Nadu and Rajasthan	Multinational Air

7.2 Domestic Defence Exercises

Exercise Name (Date)	Forces Involved	Location	Type
Vayu Shakti 2026 (February 27, 2026)	Indian Air Force	Pokhran range in Rajasthan	Domestic Air Power
Sanjha Shakti 2026 (January 8–9, 2026)	Indian Army, Maharashtra Police, Force One, NDRF, CISF, etc.	Dighi Hills, Pune, Maharashtra	Military-Civil Fusion (MCF) exercise.
Prachand Prahar Mar 25 – 27, 2025	Indian Army	Arunachal Pradesh	Domestic Warfare
Desert Hunt Feb 24 – 28, 2024	Indian Air Force	AFS Jodhpur	Domestic Special Forces

7.3 International Humanitarian Operations

Operation Name	Location	Objective / Context
Op Sindhu 2025–26	Iran / Israel	Recent evacuation of Indians from **Iran via Armenia/Turkmenistan** due to West Asia tensions.
Op Sagar Bandhu 2025	Sri Lanka	First responder relief for **Cyclone Ditwah;** delivered tonnes of aid using **INS Vikrant.**
Op Sadbhav 2024	SE Asia	**Humanitarian aid** to Myanmar, Laos, and Vietnam after Typhoon Yagi.
Op Indravati 2024	Haiti	Airlifted Indians from Haiti to the **Dominican Republic** amid a total collapse of **law due to gang violence.**
Op Ajay 2023–25	Israel	Repatriation of Indians (mostly students/workers) during the **Israel-Hamas conflict.**
Op Kaveri 2023	Sudan	Rescued Indians from the civil war between the **Sudanese Army and RSF.**
Op Dost 2023	Türkiye/Syria	"Friendship" mission; sent NDRF and field hospitals after t**he 7.8 magnitude earthquake.**
Op Ganga 2022	Ukraine	Evacuated students via land borders (Poland, Romania) **during the Russia-Ukraine war.**
Op Devi Shakti 2021	Afghanistan	Repatriation of Indians and Afghan minorities after the **Taliban's takeover of Kabul.**
Op Raahat 2015	Yemen	**Evacuation of people from the civil war;** one of India's most successful naval/ air missions.

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7.4 Domestic Operations

UPSC Prelims PYQs

1. Operations undertaken by the Army towards upliftment of the local population in remote areas to include addressing of their basic needs is called **(2024)**
(a) Operation Sankalp
(b) Operation Maitri
(c) Operation Sadbhavana
(d) Operation Madad

Answers: 1(c)

Operation Name	Lead Agency	Objective
Op Sarvashakti (2024)	Indian Army	**Anti-terror initiative** to flush out terrorists from the Pir Panjal range (J&K).
Op Sadbhavana	Indian Army	Ongoing "Goodwill" mission in **J&K and Ladakh** focusing on schools **(Army Goodwill Schools) and health.**
Op Sankalp	Indian Navy	Maritime security operations in the **Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman** to ensure the safety of Indian-flagged vessels.

7.5 Other Operations

Operation Name	Lead Agency	Location	Objective / Context
Op Sindoor	Indian forces	Pakistan Border Areas	Recent multi-domain operation responding to the **Pahalgam terror incidents.**
Op Mahadev	Army/CRPF	Kashmir	Joint counter-terror operation by the Indian Army, CRPF, and Jammu & Kashmir Police, which neutralized three terrorists responsible for the Pahalgam attack
Op Thunderbolt	Kerala Police	Kerala	Counter-insurgency by **"Kerala Thunderbolts"** (Special Task Force) to curb Maoist sightings in the Western Ghats.
Op Rakshak	Indian Army	J&K / Punjab	Longest-running **counter-insurgency operation (since 1990)** to curb cross-border militancy.
Op Black Tornado	NSG	Mumbai	The specific 2008 operation to neutralize **terrorists during the 26/11** Mumbai attacks.

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